

Talks to help stabilize trade relations with Washington

By ZHANG CHENXU
and ZHOU LANXU

The preliminary outcomes achieved during the latest round of China-US economic and trade consultations will not only help stabilize bilateral economic ties, but also contribute to a more cooperative global economy at a time of rising uncertainties, officials and experts said.

The Ministry of Commerce announced on Wednesday that China and the United States have agreed in principle to discuss, under a trade council, a reciprocal tariff reduction framework on products of equivalent scale — worth \$30 billion or more on each side.

Under the proposed arrangement, the products of respective concern as agreed by both sides are expected to enjoy most-favored-nation tariff rates or even lower rates, the ministry said.

Once implemented, the arrangement will not only help stabilize and expand bilateral trade between China and the US, but also serve as a useful reference for global open cooperation, a Commerce Ministry official said in a statement.

The ministry said that China and the US agreed to establish trade and investment councils to address respective concerns in trade and investment cooperation, a step that will help to shift bilateral economic and trade consultations from crisis response to mechanism-based management.

Dai Mingfeng, a researcher at the Chinese Academy of International Trade and Economic Cooperation, said the move will help to create more favorable conditions for stabilizing bilateral trade.

“It will provide practical support for stabilizing and steadily expanding China-US bilateral trade, while helping to promote a recovery in trade involving agricultural and industrial products,” Dai said.

To translate the arrangement into concrete progress, the ministry called on the US to honor its commitments and ensure that, regardless of the reason or form of any future additional or replacement tariffs on Chinese goods, US tariff levels on Chinese goods will not exceed those set under the joint arrangement reached during the Kuala Lumpur economic and trade consultations in October last year.

The two sides also agreed to expand two-way agricultural trade and resolve nontariff barriers and market access issues involving some agricultural products. For instance, the US pledged to address Chinese concerns including automatic detention measures targeting dairy and aquatic products, while China will advance solutions to US concerns regarding beef facility registration and poultry exports from certain US states to China, according to the ministry.

Noting that China is the world's most important agricultural market, the ministry official said that expanded US agricultural exports to China could help meet structural demand in the Chinese market, while China's vast consumer base could provide stable demand and income prospects for farmers in the US.

Zhou Mi, a senior researcher at the Chinese Academy of International Trade and Economic Cooperation, said the outcomes could play a positive role in improving market expectations.

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President Xi Jinping and visiting Russian President Vladimir Putin wave to crowds during a welcoming ceremony on Wednesday morning outside the Great Hall of the People in Beijing. Putin concluded his two-day state visit to China on the same day. FENG YONGBIN / CHINA DAILY

Xi, Putin agree to further extend treaty

Cooperation documents signed on economy, education, science and tech

By MO JINGXI
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President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin agreed on Wednesday to further extend the China-Russia Treaty of Good-Neighborliness and Friendly Cooperation, while pledging to further strengthen political mutual trust, strategic coordination and practical cooperation between the two countries amid a fluid and turbulent international situation.

The agreement was reached during talks between the two heads of state at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing, before Putin concluded his two-day state visit to China.

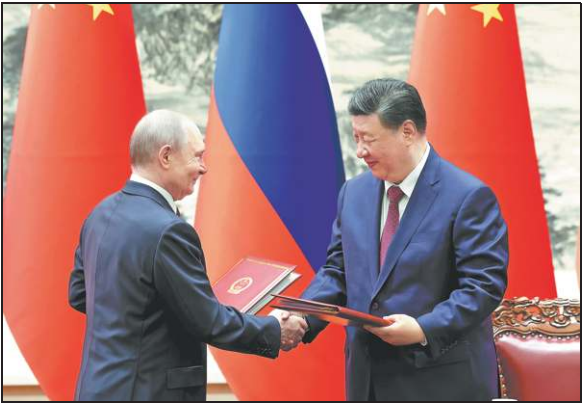
After their talks earlier on Wednesday, the two presidents signed a joint statement on further enhancing the comprehensive strategic coordination and deepening good-neighborliness and friendly cooperation between the two countries. They witnessed

the signing of 20 cooperation documents in areas including the economy and trade, education, and science and technology.

The two sides also issued a joint statement on advocating a multipolar world and a new type of international relations, and reached 20 cooperation agreements in other areas.

When addressing the media together after their talks, Xi said this was Putin's 25th trip to China since he first assumed the presidential office in Russia in 2000, which fully demonstrates the high level and uniqueness of China-Russia relations.

Noting that this year marks the 30th anniversary of the establishment of the China-Russia strategic partnership of coordination, Xi said that over the past three decades, bilateral ties have reached the highest level in history as a comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination for a new era, setting an example for a new type of major-country relations.



President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin shake hands on Wednesday in Beijing during a signing ceremony for a joint statement on further enhancing the comprehensive strategic coordination and deepening good-neighborliness and friendly cooperation between the two nations. FENG YONGBIN / CHINA DAILY

This year also marks the 25th anniversary of the signing of the China-Russia Treaty of Good-Neighborliness and Friendly Cooperation. The treaty was last extended on

June 28, 2021, when Xi and Putin held talks via video link and issued a joint statement ahead of the 20th anniversary of its signing. Xi said that over the years, the

two countries have always abided by the treaty's established principle of non-alliance, nonconfrontation and not targeting any third party, while upholding equality, mutual respect, good faith and win-win cooperation.

The two countries have made important contributions to safeguarding international fairness and justice and promoting a new type of international relations, serving as a vital constant amid changes unseen in a century, he said.

Xi called on China and Russia to build on past achievements and further support each other firmly on issues concerning their respective core interests and major concerns, maintain close strategic communication and exchanges at all levels, and continuously consolidate the foundation of political mutual trust between the two countries.

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GRAIN BUDS BRINGS WITH IT THE SWEET TASTE OF SUMMER

Perfect moment for loquats and flavor of Jiangnan arrives with *xiao man*

By LI YINGXUE
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As wheat fields across northern China begin to swell with grain, the hill-sides of Dongshan town in Suzhou, Jiangsu province, have already turned golden in the early summer sun.

Along the misty shores of Taihu Lake, loquats hang heavy on the branches. Beneath their fine golden fuzz, mellow sweetness meets gentle acidity against the floral backdrop of the rainy season in Jiangnan, the area south of the lower reaches of the Yangtze River.

As *xiao man*, or Grain Buds, arrives, so does the perfect moment for loquats.

The traditional Chinese solar term — meaning “small fullness” — marks the season when grains begin to fill but are not yet fully ripe. In Chinese food culture, it has long been associated with nourishment and relief from early summer humidity.

Few fruits capture that seasonal transition more vividly than loquats.

For generations, loquat farmers in Dongshan have followed the



rhythms of the 24 solar terms as faithfully as clockwork. Traditionally, loquats are not harvested until around *xiao man*, when the fruit sheds its sharp early acidity and develops its signature mellow sweetness.

Yet nature never follows a rigid calendar.

“This year the harvest came about 10 days later than last year,” said Song Furong, 58, a lifelong loquat farmer. “Winter temperatures were not extremely low, but there was heavy frost and thick morning fog. Some mornings, the

trees looked as though they had been dusted with snow.”

In Dongshan, farmers understand better than anyone what it means to rely on the weather. During droughts, water from Taihu Lake is pumped uphill to irrigate the orchards. Hailstorms and heavy rain can scar the fruit or knock it from the trees altogether.

But after a long winter of frost, this year's loquats have grown especially plump and juicy — nature's quiet reward for patience.

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Freshly harvested loquats are ready to be enjoyed in Beijing on Tuesday. GENG FEIFEI / CHINA DAILY



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CHINA-RUSSIA TIES



President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin unveil the emblem for the China-Russia Years of Education on Wednesday at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing. FENG YONGBIN / CHINA DAILY

Education seen as key bridge

Xi, Putin express hopes on collaboration in nurturing talent, fostering friendship

By ZHANG YUNBI and ZHAO JIA

President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin expressed their hopes on Wednesday for future collaboration between the two countries in nurturing talent and fostering friendship among young people when they attended the opening ceremony of the China-Russia Years of Education (2026-27) in Beijing.

The two leaders delivered speeches and then jointly unveiled the emblem for the China-Russia Years of Education.

In his speech, Xi said that launching the China-Russia Years of Education was a strategic decision made by him and President Putin to enhance the long-term development of China-Russia relations.

Xi said that education is an important bridge connecting the hearts of the peoples and carrying forward friendship between nations, and it is a noble cause that benefits both the present and future generations.

China-Russia educational cooperation has deepened considerably, producing remarkable results and enriching the substance of the China-

Russia comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination for a new era, he said.

Xi emphasized that both sides should take the China-Russia Years of Education as an opportunity to build further consensus on cooperation, expand its scope and raise its level.

Putin said that educational cooperation is an indispensable component of the two countries' comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination and underscored the milestone significance of launching the China-Russia Years of Education. Both countries attach great importance to education, which is crucial for individuals' development and serves as the foundation for a nation's economic and social development, he said.

The Russian president praised the China-Russia Years of Education for its rich content and large scale.

Currently, more than 80,000 students from both countries are studying in the other nation, and the two sides have established more than 150 joint educational institutions and programs, Zhang Hanhui, Chinese ambassador to Russia, wrote in an article published on Tuesday.

In his speech, Xi emphasized that thriving and strong education is the foundation of a thriving and strong nation. He said that China and Russia should deepen cooperation in talent cultivation, jointly nurture world-class professionals, strengthen national capabilities in strategic science and technology, work together to tackle cutting-edge scientific challenges, and boost the innovation-driven development of both countries.

The two countries should embrace the vision of mutual learning among civilizations, and promote the sharing of experience in terms of the inheritance of civilization and the governance of education, to improve their respective work in these fields, he said.

Both sides should carry forward the traditional friendship, further tap the potential of educational cooperation, encourage young people to cement friendship through in-depth exchanges, and nurture torchbearers who will carry forward China-Russia friendship for generations to come, he added.

Xi said that with these joint efforts, he believes the China-Russia Years of Education will surely be a complete success.

On Wednesday, Xi and Putin also toured a photo exhibition at the Great Hall of the People, celebrating

the everlasting friendship between the two countries.

The exhibition vividly presented the close interaction between the two heads of state since the beginning of the new era.

Xi and Putin paused periodically to view the photos and listen to briefings, fondly recalling moments of friendly exchanges and cooperation between the two countries in recent years. The two leaders noted that the great cause of China-Russia friendship conforms to the course of history and the times, remains unbreakable, and will continue to move forward, writing new chapters.

On Wednesday evening, Xi and Putin had a tea chat before Putin departed for Russia.

Xi said that he and Putin reached a new and important consensus on advancing the China-Russia comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination.

Putin said that Russia looks forward to maintaining close communication with China and strengthening strategic coordination.

The two heads of state also exchanged views on issues including the Ukraine crisis.

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‘Boy’ has heartwarming reunion with ‘foreign uncle’

By LI MUYYUN and HE CHUN in Changsha

Twenty-six years ago, a “foreign uncle” walked up to a young boy seated on a balustrade along a lake in Beijing, spontaneously greeted him with a kiss on the forehead, and posed for a photo with him and his family.

Fast forward to 2026. The boy, Peng Pai, now 38 years old and a civil engineer specializing in bridge construction, rebuilt that heartwarming connection through a reunion on Wednesday with this uncle, who is none other than Russian President Vladimir Putin.

The two met in Beijing during Putin's state visit to China. A video posted by Russia's RT television network shows Putin and Peng sharing a warm handshake, holding a brief conversation, and then Putin signing a copy of their group photo from the summer of 2000.

Peng, a native of Yueyang, Hunan province, who pursued his engineering studies in Moscow because his first meeting with Putin piqued his curiosity about Russia, said he never thought he would have the opportunity to meet the Russian leader again.

During their chat at the Diaoyutai State Guesthouse, Putin asked Peng who the person standing beside the boy in the photo is. “Learning that the man standing beside me is my father, he asked me to give my father his regards,” Peng said.

They hugged each other goodbye after the chat, and Peng presented Putin with a gift — a tea set made of porcelain from Liling, Hunan. “I will remember this day for the rest of my life,” Peng said.

Back in 2000, Peng, then 12, and his



Left: Russian President Vladimir Putin (left) poses with Peng Pai (front, center) from Hunan province at Beihai Park in Beijing on July 19, 2000. WU ZHIYI / CHINA DAILY Right: Russian President Vladimir Putin (left) meets on Wednesday at the Diaoyutai State Guesthouse in Beijing with Chinese engineer Peng Pai (center), who was photographed with Putin as a child in 2000 during his first visit to China. VLADIMIR SMIRNOV / SPUTNIK



family were touring Beihai Park during a trip to Beijing when they ran into Putin, who was making his first official visit to China as the Russian president.

The Russian leader made an impromptu stop at the park, indulged in some boating activities and greeted people. He approached the boy, picked him up and planted a kiss on his forehead. “It was completely spontaneous,” Peng recalled. “I remember him as a kind, gentle uncle.”

In an interview with RT before their reunion on Wednesday, Peng left a lighthearted message for the visiting leader.

“Dear President Putin, you still look the same, but I have changed from a little boy into a middle-aged man with a bigger belly,” he said.

While Peng didn't fully grasp the meaning of their encounter more than two decades ago, it certainly did increase his interest in Russia. After finishing high school, he decided to apply for higher studies in the Russian capital.

From 2007 to 2013, Peng studied bridge and tunnel engineering at the Moscow Automobile and Road Construction State Technical University, where he earned both his bachelor's and master's degrees.

“During my years in Moscow, I gained a deeper understanding of Russia's vast territory, its rich history and culture,” Peng said.

He said that the teachers and students he met along the way left a lasting impression. “They were very kind to international students,” he added.

Upon returning to China, Peng joined Hunan Construction Investment Group, a State-owned enterprise based in Changsha, the capital of Hunan, which has projects in more than 60 countries.

He is now a senior engineer at the group, leading an engineering technology team. Among the projects he has worked on, a pedestrian bridge on the Liuyang River in Changsha received the National Quality Engineering Award for 2020-21.

Although Peng has not returned to Russia, he has been closely following the development of China-Russia bilateral relations. “High-level exchanges between the two sides have been frequent in recent years, with interactions taking place in many areas, including at grassroots and online levels,” he said.

As a bridge engineer, Peng expressed his hope for greater infrastructure cooperation between the two countries. Both sides have strengths that can complement each other for mutual benefit, he said.

Now a father of two, Peng hopes to take his family to Moscow one day and walk through his old university campus. “I would tell my children everything I know about that country and its people,” he said.

Peng Yixuan in Beijing contributed to this story.

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Meeting: Both sides to extend visa-free policies

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In recent years, cooperation between China and Russia in various fields has advanced steadily and achieved many positive results. The value of bilateral trade has exceeded \$200 billion for three consecutive years, and in the first four months of 2026, two-way trade increased nearly 20 percent, according to customs data.

Xi said the two sides should build on this momentum, deepen the alignment between China's 15th Five-Year Plan (2026-30) and Russia's development strategy through 2030, and upgrade mutually beneficial cooperation in various fields to better serve the development and revitalization of both countries.

Speaking about global governance, Xi noted that the world today is far from being peaceful, with unilateralism and hegemonism causing severe harm, adding that the world is facing the danger of returning to the law of the jungle.

As permanent members of the United Nations Security Council, China and Russia should firmly fulfill their responsibilities as major countries, uphold the authority of the UN as well as international fairness and justice, and oppose all acts of unilateral bullying and attempts to reverse the course of history, he said.

China and Russia should, in particular, oppose all provocative acts that deny the outcomes of World War II and seek to justify and revive fascism and militarism, Xi said, emphasizing that the two sides should jointly promote the building of a more just and equitable global governance system.

Putin, who received a welcoming ceremony that featured a 21-gun salute, quoted the Chinese saying that “one day apart feels like three autumns” when meeting with Xi, whom he described as his “dear friend.”

“Russia-China relations have reached a truly unprecedented level, and continue to develop. At the same time, our relations are self-sufficient; they do not depend on the current international situation and can serve as an example of relations between nations in this age,” he said when addressing the media.

He said that Russia is full of confidence in the future of bilateral relations, adding that it will work with China to deepen the two countries' partnership and good-neighborly friendship, strengthen people-to-people bonds, and contribute to the development and revitalization of both countries and the well-being of their peoples.

“Moscow and Beijing will jointly uphold international law and the provisions of the UN Charter in their entirety ... and cooperate effectively within the framework of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, BRICS and other international structures, making a significant contribution to

addressing pressing global and regional challenges,” Putin said.

During their talks on Wednesday, Xi said the China-Russia relationship has entered a new stage of greater achievements and faster development.

Unswervingly promoting the long-term, sound, steady and high-quality development of the China-Russia relationship is a strategic choice made by the two sides based on the fundamental interests of the two countries and the global trends, he said.

Xi called on China and Russia to fully implement the important common understandings reached between him and Putin, seize the historic opportunities and further promote the mutual trust, cooperation and friendship between the two countries.

He emphasized that both sides should focus on the goals of national development and revitalization, fully leverage the comprehensive and well-established mechanisms of China-Russia cooperation and strengthen the overall planning for cooperation in all respects.

The two countries should also promote the upgrading of practical cooperation in trade and investment, energy and resources, transportation, and sci-tech innovation, as well as actively explore cooperation in frontier areas, in order to create new engines for growth with new quality productive forces, Xi said.

He added that efforts should be made to continue the long-standing friendship between the two sides, strengthen exchanges and cooperation in education, culture, film, tourism and sports, and consolidate the social and public support for bilateral friendship.

Also on Wednesday, China announced that it has decided to extend its visa-free policy for Russia until Dec 31, 2027. According to TASS news agency, Russian presidential press secretary Dmitry Peskov said in Beijing that Russia will also extend its visa-free policy for Chinese citizens.

During their talks, the two heads of state exchanged views on major international and regional issues, including the situation in the Middle East.

Xi emphasized that all hostilities in the Middle East must end immediately, renewed fighting should be avoided and, most important, negotiations should continue.

Noting that the situation in the Middle East and the Persian Gulf region is at a critical juncture between war and peace, he said that an early end to the conflict will help reduce disruptions to the stability of energy supplies, the functioning of industrial and supply chains, and the stability of the international trade order.

On Wednesday evening, Xi held a welcoming banquet for Putin in the Golden Hall of the Great Hall of the People.

cultural events within frameworks such as the China-Russia Years of Education, and deepen exchanges and cooperation in areas including youth, culture, tourism and sports, thereby continuously fostering mutual understanding and friendship between the two peoples.

China is set to strengthen collaboration with Russia on multilateral platforms, actively implement the Global Governance Initiative and jointly uphold fairness and justice, he added.

On his part, Putin said that Russia is willing to maintain close high-level exchanges with China, fully leverage the mechanism of regular meetings between the two prime ministers, and advance exchanges and cooperation in areas such as trade, energy, agriculture, transportation, logistics, scientific and technological innovation and people-to-people exchanges.

He also expressed Moscow's readiness to strengthen cooperation with Beijing within multilateral frameworks such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organization and BRICS, to jointly promote world peace, stability and prosperity.

By JI HAISHENG jihaisheng@chinadaily.com.cn

Premier Li Qiang called on China and Russia to achieve a higher level of mutual benefit and win-win outcomes during his meeting on Wednesday with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Beijing.

Highlighting the strategic guidance of the two heads of state, Li noted that President Xi Jinping had met with President Putin earlier in the day to make further plans and arrangements for the development of China-Russia relations.

Li said that China is willing to work with Russia to further expand trade, implement the upgraded bilateral investment agreement, and deepen cooperation in areas such as energy, agriculture, connectivity, and green and low-carbon development.

Efforts should also be made to strengthen the alignment between the China-proposed Belt and Road Initiative and the Russia-led Eurasian Economic Union, and ensure the safe, stable and high-quality development of China-Europe freight trains, he said.

Li called on both sides to organize

CHINA-RUSSIA TIES



Above: President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin, who is on a state visit to China, visit a photo exhibition on the long-lasting friendship between the two countries at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing on Wednesday. **Right:** President Xi holds a welcoming ceremony for Russian President Putin outside the Great Hall of the People in Beijing on Wednesday. PHOTOS BY HUANG JINGWEN / XINHUA



President Xi shakes hands with Russian President Putin at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing on Wednesday. FENG YONGBIN / CHINA DAILY

PARTNERSHIP ENTERS NEW STAGE



President Xi and Russian President Putin have a chat over tea at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing on Wednesday. DING HAITAO / XINHUA



President Xi holds talks with Russian President Putin at the Great Hall of the People in Beijing on Wednesday. WANG ZHUANGFEI / CHINA DAILY

CHINA-RUSSIA TIES



In April, Chinese and Russian youngsters along with their teachers pose for a photo during a camp in Harbin, Heilongjiang province, which was organized by the Association of Sino-Russian Middle Schools and focused on education, technology and sports. PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

Languages bind China, Russia closer

Young people's efforts to learn each other's tongues a testament to warm friendship, shared futures

By WANG HAORAN
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*Yi, er, san, si, wu, liu, qi,
Wo de li wu zai zhe li.*

A jumble of strange sounds foreign to millions of Anastasia Prytkova's Russian compatriots slip off her tongue as effortlessly as if she had been uttering them since she was a baby. Throw in a delightful melody, and suddenly the Chinese language does not seem as intimidating and as difficult as it is usually cracked up to be.

What she speaks means "One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, my gift is here."

And what a gift this is, one that has put ninth-grader Anastasia from Novosibirsk, Russia, on a path that is likely to shape her life.

For the past three years she has been studying Mandarin online with a Russian teacher, cultivating her fascination with a country she has so far had no physical contact with.

"My favorite food is kung pao chicken," she said in Chinese. The dish is a favorite in Sichuan province, the home of spicy food, and is a place she dreams of visiting. Seeing the Great Wall and the Terracotta Warriors is also on her wish list, but for now, there is still plenty of Chinese learning to do.

Anastasia is aware of the challenge ahead, even as she senses the rich rewards that await her. Her aim is to become a transportation engineer and to pursue a master's degree at a Chinese university.

Her mother, Oksana Prytkova, views China as the ideal training ground for the skills Anastasia wants to master. Pointing to her daughter's passion for robotics and programming, she said: "In these disciplines it makes sense to study Chinese, because there is a lot worth learning in China."

Great enthusiasm

Tens of thousands of young Russians share that sentiment, one that is reciprocated in China, where many young people are increasingly drawn to learning Russian, seeing the benefits it offers.

In Anastasia's hometown, the

Confucius Institute at Novosibirsk State Technical University is at the forefront of promoting Chinese language and culture. The institute, established in 2007 in partnership with Dalian University of Foreign Languages in Liaoning province, is stepping up its efforts to reshape how Mandarin is taught to the city's young people.

It offers a wide range of learning methods, from large lectures to one-on-one tutoring led by a mix of Russian and Chinese staff. This year and the next have been designated as the China-Russia Years of Education. In that context, the importance of these teachers and what they do has never been clearer.

Igor Khripunov, who has directed the institute since 2013, said collaboration in education is the bedrock of the two countries' partnership.

"Over the next two years I foresee a profound acceleration in such collaboration," Khripunov said. "This will do much more than catalyze our collaboration on academics, language and talent development. It will lay a solid foundation for a new generation of professionals equipped to meet the evolving needs of our countries' partnership."

The teaching of Mandarin and the way it is offered have improved markedly in Novosibirsk, and the number of those studying the language has increased in each of the past three years, he said.

"In many schools, Mandarin is now included in the curriculum as a second language and is being included in a state exam program. An increasing number of schoolchildren are taking part in the annual All-Russian Chinese Language Olympiad," he said.

Yulia Shchepina, a Mandarin instructor at the Confucius Institute, who has eight years' classroom experience, said foreign-language learning for children is less about rigid memorization and more about visual storytelling.

She tells of a lively fourth-grade class of 9 and 10-year-olds who gasped collectively when they opened their textbooks to see a dense sea of Chinese characters. Many of them exclaimed, "This is impossible!"



Chinese and Russian students interact with each other during the camp in Harbin last month. PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

It will lay a solid foundation for a new generation of professionals equipped to meet the evolving needs of our countries' partnership."

Igor Khripunov, director of the Confucius Institute at Novosibirsk State Technical University

Seven months later the same children stood up to introduce themselves in Chinese, rattling off details about their families, hobbies and favorite colors.

Among them, three came to China to further their language studies. An ultimate test of their fluency came during a trip to the Palace Museum in Beijing, also known as the Forbidden City, when they approached local Chinese children and began chatting to them, and were understood perfectly.

They returned to Novosibirsk with even more passion for the language, Shchepina said.

Pop culture is also an important motivation for many teenage students who want to play Chinese video games and understand hit dramas and music in the original language.

Travel, Shchepina said, deepens this engagement, with family holidays to Asia becoming increasingly popular.

As Mandarin clubs sprout up in local schools, learning the language

has evolved into a shared enthusiasm in which students inspire one another.

"Modern children have a clear vision of what they want to achieve. They are incredibly purpose driven," Shchepina said.

Collaboration continues

That drive is not the sole preserve of youngsters in Russia. Just as young people in Novosibirsk are both frustrated and charmed by the complexity of Chinese characters, their counterparts in China are delighting in the beauty of the Cyrillic script that helps them understand the language of Leo Tolstoy.

One such youngster is Shen Yu, a first-year student in the advanced Russian program at Harbin No 6 High School in Heilongjiang province. Her father also studied Russian in his youth, filling the family home with Cyrillic books. For Shen, learning Russian started as a daunting challenge of declensions and tongue twisters.

The study is punishing, but the payoffs are astronomical, she said.

"Whenever I can fluently express a complete thought, or understand a Russian news broadcast or a song without relying on a translation, the sense of accomplishment is overwhelming."

While learning Russian with native-speaking educators every Friday at her high school, she is also developing a profound kinship with her Russian counterparts.

"They face exactly the same academic pressures that we do, with the same stress over exams, but they also have the same love for video games and music," she said.

Harbin No 6 High School has a rich history of teaching Russian that goes back more than 80 years, and it hosts the Chinese secretariat of the Association of Sino-Russian Middle Schools. The association was initiated by the school eight years ago, aiming to advance educational exchanges and collaboration at the secondary level and cultivate talent, with an emphasis on biculturalism.

Wu Xia, principal of the school, said the association had 30 schools as members when it was established. It now has 145, with 50 of them in China and 95 in Russia.

The association operates as a high-level, institutionalized dialogue platform, with annual meetings in both countries attracting thousands of educators who discuss collaboration in secondary education.

It also organizes training courses for Chinese educators who teach Russian, and Russian educators who teach Mandarin. More than 700 Chinese teachers have benefited from the courses.

Stewards of tomorrow

Fu Zhaoxia, a Russian-language instructor who has taught at Harbin No 6 High School for 34 years, said the expertise of Russian academics has helped her transform her classes, which were once top heavy with rigid rote learning, into spaces of vibrant, real-life communication.

The alliance has implemented more than 30 cultural initiatives, including youth art festivals, paper-cutting contests and a cross-border postcard exchange, engaging more than 4,000 students. A program

called Air Classroom delivers Mandarin instruction to more than 500 students in 15 Russian regions.

"By taking part in these activities our young people break down the initial barriers of language and culture," Wu said. "It teaches them to respect differences and embrace a global vision. This is where genuine friendship takes root. Education is the bond, but friendship is the core."

Wu cites the example of a camp in Harbin last month that hosted students from Lensk No 3 School in the Sakha (Yakutia) Republic of Russia. The shared activities with Chinese students focused on education, technology and sports.

In addition to 3D printing and curling matches, the students were given the task of crafting *xiang-nang*, decorative sachets traditionally filled with scented herbs.

The Chinese students, familiar with making the colorful sachets, patiently worked with their Russian counterparts, explaining the cultural symbolism in embroidered dragons and phoenixes that were being used, as well as the traditional herbal fillings.

The awkwardness the Russians first displayed gradually dissolved, and they began weaving symbols of Harbin, such as snowflakes and ice, into their own designs. When the students finally exchanged their handmade crafts, the gesture carried a weight beyond the herbs inside.

"The sachets were no longer just ordinary pouches, but became a bond," Wu said. "You could feel this cross-border goodwill quietly flowing through hearts."

Khripunov, director of the Confucius Institute at Novosibirsk State Technical University, said he sees this generation as the future stewards of China-Russia ties.

"We are planting the seeds, and these students will inherit the responsibility of sustaining our scientific, educational and cultural exchanges. They are the ones who will forge a deeper, more genuine trust between our peoples."

Zhang Xiaomin, Zhou Huiying and Pang Yingyuan contributed to this story.



Left: Chinese and Russian students share techniques during a friendly curling match in Harbin on April 6. Middle: Students actively engage in a Chinese cultural activity at the Confucius Institute at Novosibirsk State Technical University, Russia, in April. Right: Students from Lensk No 3 School write messages and stamp school-themed marks at the school museum of Harbin No 6 High School in April. PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY



CHINA-RUSSIA TIES



Trucks line up to pass through the Manzhouli Land Port in Manzhouli, Inner Mongolia autonomous region, in December. XIAO JIANBO / XINHUA

Border policy converts grains into cash

By YUAN HUI in Hohhot and LIU BOQIAN

Russian freight trains inch across the border into Manzhouli, their cars laden with grains and oilseeds from the fertile fields of Siberia and the Russian Far East. Within days, these raw imports are cleared, processed in towering local factories, and dispatched to kitchens across China.

Manzhouli in northern China's Inner Mongolia autonomous region is the country's largest land port city. It sits opposite Russia's Zabaykalsk, where the railway crossing handles more than 60 percent of China's rail trade with Russia, making the Chinese city a critical gateway for goods moving between the two nations.

For many Russian products, Manzhouli is both the first stop in China and the launchpad for nationwide distribution after processing.

"More than 90 percent of our raw materials come from Russia," said Yang Zhihong, manager of Xin Feng Grain and Oil, a local processing company. "The supply is stable and reliable."

Inside Xin Feng's production halls, workers wash, sort and refine imported crops into flour, oils and other finished goods.

"Siberian and Russian Far East



A Manzhouli resident (right) learns about Russian handicraft at a fair in December. LIAN ZHEN / XINHUA

crops grow under strict ecological standards, producing nutrient-rich grains," Yang said. He added that oils and flour made from these grains sell well in the domestic market.

The company works with local residents through cooperatives. Under cross-border trade rules, each resident can enjoy a daily tax-free quota of 8,000 yuan (\$1,170). The cooperatives handle the purchase and transport of imported goods to compliant grain and oil processors

in Manzhouli, such as Xin Feng, where the products are processed before being sold across China.

The system cuts tariffs and value-added taxes, streamlines customs clearance and ensures a steady raw material supply. This means procurement costs are significantly lower than elsewhere. "The same quality Russian grains save 500 to 1,000 yuan per metric ton," Yang said. "It reduces production expenses and operational costs."

Local residents also share in the profits along with the enterprises under this model, creating a direct benefit for the community.

Imported Russian grains and potash have become a cornerstone of Manzhouli's processing industry.

"Since Manzhouli was designated an official import port for agricultural products in 2013, we now handle 12 crop types, including rapeseed, barley, wheat and soybeans," said Chen Rui, deputy director of the city's bureau of industry, information and technology. "Five processing enterprises operate here, with a combined annual capacity exceeding 1.35 million tons."

Manzhouli is also emerging as a cross-border tourism hub. In the first four months of the year, 7,723 visitors arrived, mostly for shopping. Some use the city as a transit point for the seaside resorts of Beidaihe or Qinhuangdao in Hebei province.

"Cross-border study tours are growing, too. Russian students visit for day trips or longer stays to experience life in a Chinese border city," said Huang Wei from the Manzhouli tourism bureau.

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Fish-skin art creates bridge for cultural exchange

By TIAN XUEFEI and ZHOU HUIYING in Harbin

Inside the bustling cultural exhibition hall of the 10th China-Russia Expo, a steady stream of international visitors found themselves huddled around a workshop table, handling a material few associated with fine art: raw, tanned fish skin.

Guided by 58-year-old Zhang Lin, Russian merchants, foreign tourists and local residents took up carving tools to cut and paste intricate shapes. Zhang's booth, showcasing the ancient fish-skin collage techniques of China's Hezhe ethnic group, has become a striking highlight of the expo, transforming an ancient hunting tradition into a medium for modern cross-border diplomacy.

"Intangible cultural heritage is a language without borders," said Zhang, a provincial-level inheritor of the endangered craft from Heilongjiang province. "As long as our neighbors come to understand this culture, my perseverance will have been worthwhile."

By the early 2000s, the grueling process of tanning, cutting, carving and sewing fish skin had nearly vanished. The craft's trajectory shifted in 2006 when it was officially listed as a Chinese national intangible cultural heritage, anchoring preservation efforts.

The Hezhe, one of China's smallest ethnic groups, have historically inhabited the river valleys of the Heilong River — known in Russia as the Amur River. Dating back to the Spring and Autumn Period (770-476 BC), their ancestors developed a unique lifestyle centered on fishing and hunting, utilizing salmon skins to construct durable clothing, daily utensils and sacred totems.

At this year's expo, Zhang brought



Zhang Lin (left) teaches a Russian trader how to make a fish-skin collage at the 10th China-Russia Expo in Harbin on Monday. ZHOU HUIYING / CHINA DAILY

two fish-skin garments and 16 collages, along with cultural and creative products made from fish skin.

Zhang's fish-skin arrangements present lively, vivid images of divine deer, soaring eagles, ancient ethnic totems and distant landscapes that evoke China's northern regions.

The inheritor has been a fixture at the China-Russia Expo since its inaugural event in Harbin in 2014. Invited by the provincial department of culture and tourism to present three-dimensional, bas-relief fish-skin art, her work always finds an audience.

"It was a great opportunity to showcase our cultural heritage," she said. "Despite the language barrier, many foreign guests stopped to observe and touch," she added. Because China and Russia share a border, they also enjoy a certain cultural affinity. Intangible cultural heritage is a language without borders, Zhang said.

At past expos, Zhang incorporat-

ed Russian cultural elements into her traditional fish-skin works.

"Each expo gave me the opportunity to have face-to-face conversations with Russian artists," she said. "We would discuss fish-skin tanning, carving and pasting techniques, and I gave them detailed explanations of Hezhe history and folklore."

Over the years, Zhang has taken her fish-skin creations to multiple Russian cities for folk cultural exchange activities. At an event in Russia's Amur Oblast, her artwork received high praise. The craftsmanship and ethnic patterns impressed ordinary people and art aficionados alike, she said.

In July, Zhang donated 20 of her works to a Russian museum, displaying themes of the 12 Chinese zodiac signs, the flower of good fortune, spring swallows, autumn cranes and fish-skin clouds.

"I was happy to see that the intangible cultural heritage of Heilongji-

ang would be permanently rooted in the cultural halls of a foreign country," she said.

Zhang has also extended her reach to universities within Heilongjiang, allowing her ancient craft techniques to take root and flourish on campuses.

"In Zhang's classes, she never follows a script," said Alla Shulgan, a Russian student at the Harbin Institute of Technology. "Instead, she brings complete fish-skin materials, production tools and fine artworks, explaining the history of Hezhe fishing and hunting culture in simple terms, and breaking down the core techniques of fish-skin tanning, carving, pasting and coloring, allowing us to experience the charm of intangible cultural heritage from scratch."

Shulgan said that before coming to China, she was completely unfamiliar with the culture of the country's ethnic groups. "After a semester of diligent study and hands-on creation, I truly understood the charm of this ancient intangible cultural heritage — simple fish skin can be transformed into exquisite and beautiful paintings, carrying the local ethnic group's lifestyle characteristics and traditional customs."

Shulgan said she has shared her fish-skin artworks and learning experiences with family and friends back home.

For Zhang, intangible cultural heritage transmission cannot rely solely on the preservation of old skills, but must also reach young people in new generations.

"With craftsmanship as a bridge and culture as a bond, I hope to ensure that the beauty of this heritage will continue to shine," Zhang said.

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Agricultural trade ripe for fresh harvest

Sino-Russian cooperation on farm products shows growing potential

By REN QI
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Agricultural cooperation is emerging as a key driver of economic synergy between China and Russia, further bolstering already robust growth momentum between the two nations, officials and experts said.

China has been Russia's largest trading partner for the past 16 years, with bilateral trade volume reaching \$228.11 billion in 2025, according to data released by the General Administration of Customs.

In the first quarter this year, bilateral trade surged 14.7 percent year-on-year to \$61.2 billion. During the period, China's exports to Russia grew by 22 percent, while imports rose by 9 percent, marking a solid start to the year.

Ma Chi, deputy director-general of the department of Eurasian affairs at the Ministry of Commerce, said the structure of bilateral trade between the two countries is continuously being optimized.

He noted that competitive Chinese products, such as automobiles, home appliances and machinery, have maintained strong export momentum, while Russia's supply of energy, minerals and agricultural products to China remains stable.

This national-level synergy is deeply felt at the regional level, particularly in Russia's Primorsky Krai, a crucial Far East region sharing a border with China.

Oleg Kozhemyako, governor of Primorsky Krai, has hailed China as a "reliable and stable partner", emphasizing that the cooperation is of paramount importance to the region. Primorsky Krai is eager to deepen collaboration in sectors including equipment manufacturing, deep processing of agricultural products and biomedicine, he said.

The Far East is a key region for China-Russia agricultural cooperation. To meet the storage and transportation needs of expanding grain exports to China, the two countries have collaborated in recent years to construct and upgrade transportation infrastructure in the Far East, including the Heihe-Blagoveshchensk highway bridge and the Tongjiang-Nizhneleninskoye railway bridge in 2022, which provided new international transportation corridors for future large-scale agricultural trade between the two countries.

Highlighting the strong connectivity between the two sides, Kozhemyako said that the region is linked to China through multiple border crossings and over 50 weekly flights. Russia is currently upgrading these border ports to enhance transit capacity. He also praised the high-quality work of Chinese enterprises that have successfully implemented agricultural planting and engineering construction projects in the region.

Kozhemyako reaffirmed the local government's full support

Russia boasts vast arable land, clean water sources and abundant agricultural resources, while China offers a massive consumer market and a mature processing and distribution system."

Wang Qun, head of the Association of Entrepreneurs in the Field of Russian-Chinese Cooperation

for bilateral agricultural initiatives, highlighting the planned Sino-Russian agricultural cooperation experimental demonstration zone at Sukhodol Port. The zone will utilize modern technology for the deep processing of agricultural raw materials from Primorsky Krai, significantly enhancing the value-added of these products.

Song Kui, president of the Contemporary China-Russia Regional Economy Research Institute in Heilongjiang province, echoed this optimism. He said that the two countries have immense potential for cooperation in energy and agriculture. The development of Russia's Far East will also inject vitality into the comprehensive revitalization of Northeast China, further promoting the socioeconomic development of both nations, Song said.

The highly complementary nature of Sino-Russian agricultural cooperation is a major catalyst for this development, according to Wang Qun, head of the Association of Entrepreneurs in the Field of Russian-Chinese Cooperation.

"Russia boasts vast arable land, clean water sources and abundant agricultural resources, while China offers a massive consumer market and a mature processing and distribution system," Wang said.

The expert noted that China has firmly established itself as the largest importer of Russian agricultural products, a milestone achieved through smooth policy communication and highly efficient customs clearance cooperation.

Wang said that both sides could further expand the trade of grains, oilseeds, meat, aquatic products and processed foods. This can be achieved by deepening the mutual recognition of agricultural quality standards — such as organic certification, and inspection and quarantine protocols — and improving cross-border cold chain and warehousing logistics networks at key ports like Suifenhe, Manzhouli and other cities in Heilongjiang province.

"Ultimately, this will help build a highly efficient 'from field to table' cooperation model," Wang added.



Tourists buy snacks at a night food market in Heihe, Heilongjiang province, last month. With visa-free entry, the market in the Sino-Russian border city attracts customers from both countries.

HAN FEI / XINHUA

Chinese and Russian youth fuel close ties

Mutual perception of friendship a robust foundation for people-to-people exchanges

By YUAN SHENGGAO

The people-to-people connections between China and Russia have continuously strengthened, as a new survey reveals that more than 80 percent of young people in both countries regard their bilateral relationship as friendly.

Released on Friday in Beijing, the survey was conducted from late April to early May by the Global Opinion Research Center at Renmin University of China, in collaboration with a Russian partner organization. It involved an online survey of participants aged 18 to 35 from both nations.

The findings show that 87.5 percent of Russian youth and 85.5 percent of Chinese youth consider China-Russia relations to be friendly. Additionally, 78 percent of Russian respondents and 76.4 percent of their Chinese counterparts hold a positive impression of the other country.

When asked about the prospects for China-Russia cooperation, 77.7 percent of Russian youth and 73.7 percent of Chinese youth said they are optimistic. This mutual perception of friendship and collaboration forms a robust foundation for people-to-people exchanges.

“Young people are a vital force in fostering generations of friendship between China and Russia,” Zhou Yong, director of the Global Opinion Research Center at Renmin University of China and dean of its School of Journalism and Communication, told Xinhua News Agency.

Zhou emphasized the importance of prioritizing educational collaboration, student exchanges, cultural activities and digital interactions. He said these initiatives can help foster understanding, build friendships and open avenues for cooperative development among the youth.

This year marks the 30th anniversary of the China-Russia strategic partnership of coordination and the 25th anniversary of the China-Russia Treaty of Good-Neighborliness and Friendly Cooperation. Following the conclusion of the China-Russia Years of Culture (2024-25), the Years of Education (2026-27) have commenced, extending the shared legacy of meaningful exchanges between the two countries.



Currently, there are more than 60,000 Chinese students studying in Russia and over 20,000 Russian students in China, according to Xinhua. Shenzhen MSU-BIT University, a nonprofit collaboration among the Shenzhen government, Lomonosov Moscow State University and Beijing Institute of Technology, has cultivated students who are proficient in both languages and cultures, while possessing a global perspective.

The Sino-Russian alliances of similar universities, referring to discipline-specific bilateral alliances that

connect universities with similar academic focuses, have become the world's largest bilateral higher education network. The Luban Workshop in Moscow — jointly built by Chinese and Russian universities — began operations in 2025. It was the first of its kind to integrate 5G technology into its curriculum. The Luban Workshop is an initiative by China to promote vocational education on an international scale.

Cultural exchanges among young



Clockwise from left: Shenzhen MSU-BIT University, a symbol of China-Russia educational cooperation. PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY
A woman photographs fans at a Chinese art exhibition held at the State Tretyakov Gallery in Moscow, Russia, on Nov 17, 2025.
XINHUA NEWS AGENCY Russian tourists in Chinese *hanfu* celebrate the Yu Garden Lantern Festival in Shanghai on Feb 12. PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY



people have also flourished. Over the past two years, the All-Russian Children's Center “Ocean” has hosted more than 100 primary and secondary school students from China. Activities such as concerts, sailing lessons and game festivals have provided opportunities for young participants to forge friendships and deepen mutual understanding.

In April, a China-Russia youth culture and art festival was held at Tianjin Foreign Studies University.

Boris Titov, chairman of the Russian side of the China-Russia Committee for Friendship, Peace and Development, noted that the richer the cultural exchanges, the deeper the friendship among the people.

This perspective was echoed by Igor Morgulov, Russia's ambassador to China. He said Russia is ready to leverage the opportunities presented by various themed years to boost people-to-people exchanges, fostering a deeper understanding and friendship between the two countries.

By YUAN SHENGGAO

Nestled in the permafrost region of Yakutia in Russia's Far East, the Elga Coal Complex has become a symbol of industrial ambition and worker welfare. As the largest coking coal deposit in Russia and one of the largest in the world, the mine boasts reserves of 2.2 billion metric tons.

The complex is operated by a group of companies that extract, process, transport and sell premium coal with low levels of harmful impurities such as sulfur, nitrogen and phosphorus. The coal serves as a key raw material for producing coke used in blast furnace steelmaking and is in high demand globally. Most of Elga's coal is exported to the Asia-Pacific region, with China being the main consumer.

In 2020, when the Elga deposit came under new ownership, the production volume was 4 million tons. In just five years, it increased more than eightfold, reaching 35.1 million tons in 2025, which was the largest output in the mine's history.

In April, 3.34 million tons of coking coal concentrate were shipped from the Elga Coal Complex to Far East ports. This was a record monthly shipment volume for a single coal-mining enterprise in the history of Russia, according to the company.

“These record figures are the logical outcome of investment decisions and the hard work of all company employees,” said Alexander Isaev, CEO of Elga Management Company.

“In a short time, we created a unique production complex, including mining facilities, the Pacific Railway, a port complex, an airport and other infrastructure. The Elga deposit development project has become a hallmark of our country's coal industry,” Isaev noted.

This sharp increase in production was the result of large-scale investments in both mining and transport infrastructure.

High-performance excavators and dump trucks have been purchased. Eleven coal-washing plants with an annual capacity of 38.5 million tons have been built and equipped with modern machinery.

The Elga Coal Complex has its own accredited coal chemistry laboratory.

In 2025, the laboratory processed approximately 10,000 coal samples per month, offering quality certi-



A panoramic view of the Elga open-pit mine. With 2.2 billion metric tons of reserves, the mine is the largest coking coal deposit in Russia and one of the largest in the world. PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

cations that are vital for both domestic logistics and exports.

Transport system

The expansion of the Elga Coal Complex hinges on its robust logistics network for transporting coal. To ensure coal transportation, the Elga-Ulak railway was modernized, increasing its annual capacity from 12 to 30 million tons.

Another logistics route is the 531-kilometer Pacific Railway. Built by Elga and commissioned in 2025, the track connects the Elga deposit to Port Elga on the coast of the Sea of Okhotsk, providing access to the Pacific Ocean.

The Pacific Railway was built in just two years, despite challenging climatic conditions. Approximately 4,000 workers from across the country were involved in its construction.

The railway is integrated with the Port Elga coal terminal, located on the coast of the Sea of Okhotsk in Khabarovsk Krai. The terminal boasts four cargo berths and will be



A train travels along the Pacific Railway, a 531-kilometer track linking the Elga mine to Port Elga on the coast of the Sea of Okhotsk.

able to simultaneously handle vessels with a deadweight of up to 100,000 tons each.

The port is equipped with coal conveyor systems and utilizes its own Arc4 icebreaking tugboats for

year-round operations.

The year-round navigability of Port Elga has unparalleled logistical advantages. The port's operations are expected to generate around 3,500 new jobs, a substantial socio-

economic benefit to the region.

The terminal employs modern machinery, featuring high operational efficiency, simple operation and easy maintenance. All equipment complies with current environmental, safety and energy consumption standards.

Together, Port Elga and the Pacific Railway form an integrated transportation cluster capable of delivering premium coking coal from the Elga Coal Complex for export.

The company's own transport and logistics infrastructure will allow it to transport up to 50 million tons of coal in 2027.

The complex's management has also built a dedicated airport near the mining area, improving regional connectivity.

Elga Airport, opened in November 2023, features a 2,200-meter-long runway. It is capable of accommodating a wide range of aircraft.

Currently handling more than 50 flights each month, the airport connects the open-pit mine to Russian

During the event, Chinese students shared the folk tale *The Cowherd and the Weaver Girl* in Russian, while their Russian counterparts told the parable *The Blind Men and the Elephant* in Chinese. Both groups also performed traditional dances and songs together.

“The most unforgettable part was learning songs in each other's languages — it was a truly magical experience,” a 19-year-old Russian participant was quoted as saying by Xinhua.

Over the years, China and Russia have hosted various themed “national years”, focusing on areas such as tourism, youth exchange, media collaboration, local cooperation, technology, sports and culture.

Tourism has experienced notable growth following the introduction of the mutual visa exemption policy in 2025. Dmitry Gorin, vice-president of the Russian Union of Travel Industry, told Russia's Izvestia newspaper that Russian citizens set a new record by visiting China's Hainan Island more than 505,000 times in 2025 — 120 percent more than the previous year. Since Jan 1, Heihe, a Chinese city on the China-Russia border, has recorded 350,000 Russian border crossings, representing an 80 percent year-on-year increase.

During China's Spring Festival in February, Beijing hosted a Maslenitsa celebration, introducing Russian traditions of saying goodbye to winter and welcoming spring.

Joint creative works have also acted as bridges of friendship. The China-Russia co-produced film *Red Silk* achieved box office success in Russia, while the co-produced opera *Eugene Onegin* received acclaim in China.

Boris Titov, chairman of the Russian side of the China-Russia Committee for Friendship, Peace and Development, noted that the richer the cultural exchanges, the deeper the friendship among the people.

This perspective was echoed by Igor Morgulov, Russia's ambassador to China. He said Russia is ready to leverage the opportunities presented by various themed years to boost people-to-people exchanges, fostering a deeper understanding and friendship between the two countries.

cities such as Chita, Novosibirsk, Neryungri and Blagoveshchensk. The airport transported more than 88,300 passengers on 600 flights in 2025.

The airport's facilities have been designed to ensure convenience and efficiency. In 2025, a new fueling station was introduced, alongside major upgrades to passenger terminals.

The revamped terminals include electronic display screens, audio and visual passenger alert systems, vending machines and modern security checkpoints. Professional cleaning equipment operates around the clock to ensure cleanliness.

The efficiency of the aviation infrastructure is a lifeline for workers stationed in the remote mine, underlining Elga's commitment to operational sustainability.

Workers' welfare

The dynamic growth of the Elga Coal Complex is the result of the work of its employees, who have been provided with comfortable working and leisure conditions.

Shift camps, canteens, shops, laundries, a cafeteria and a hair salon have been built.

There is also a medical center, which offers treatment in cardiology, orthopedics, dentistry and other areas. Recreational facilities include gyms, a cinema, a library and spaces for playing board games.

By establishing in-house dairy and soft drink production facilities, Elga has reduced its dependency on external suppliers. These factories produce a range of items, including milk, yogurt, and a variety of carbonated and energy drinks.

Similarly, Port Elga strives to create a comfortable life for its employees. The living quarters at the port's coal terminal can accommodate up to 2,000 people.

By creating thousands of skilled jobs, supporting local infrastructure development and enabling year-round export capabilities, the Elga Coal Complex advances not only Russia's industrial development but also the socioeconomic well-being of the region.

Through its blend of industrial innovation, sustainability and community investment, the Elga Coal Complex exemplifies how large-scale industrial ventures can coexist with social and environmental stewardship.

CHINA

Torrential rain triggers floods and landslides

By **LIU KUN** in Wuhan, **HE CHUN** in Changsha and **HU QING**

Persistent heavy rainfall continued to pound large parts of southern China this week, with some areas experiencing record-breaking downpours that triggered floods and landslides and forced mass evacuations across multiple provinces, as rescue teams worked to evacuate stranded residents and restore damaged infrastructure amid severe weather conditions.

The intense rainfall had, by Wednesday morning, left 15 people dead, with several others still missing in the provinces of Guizhou, Hubei and Hunan, authorities said.

Since the weekend, multiple parts of Hubei have been hit by record-breaking rainfall, causing severe urban flooding, inundating farmland and damaging infrastructure, while emergency rescue and disaster relief operations remain underway, according to Xinhua News Agency.

One of the hardest-hit areas is the Enshi Tujia and Miao autonomous prefecture, where torrential rain triggered landslides, flooded farmland and damaged infrastructure, Xinhua reported.

The rainfall left Baishuihe village in the prefecture's Xuan'en county cut off from the outside world after roads were destroyed and communication facilities severely damaged.

Ran Junjie, deputy head of Xuan'en county, told China Central Television that following intensive rescue efforts, all stranded residents were safely evacuated. Most evacuees have been relocated to local hotels, while a smaller number are staying with relatives or friends in other safe locations.

Multiple parts of Hunan have also suffered extremely heavy rainfall. In Shimen county, five people died and 11 others remain missing following the first round of heavy rain that began on Sunday morning, according to a notice issued by the county's emergency management and workplace safety authority on Wednesday morning.

The rainfall impacted 23 townships across the county, with 103,247 residents affected, the notice said.

The National Development and Reform Commission said on



Firefighters help evacuate flood-affected residents in Shimen county, Changde city, Hunan province, on Wednesday. Authorities said 23 townships have been affected, with rescue, recovery and resettlement efforts continuing. CHEN ZIDE / FOR CHINA DAILY

Wednesday that it has urgently allocated 50 million yuan (\$7.31 million) from the central government's investment budget to support post-flood emergency recovery efforts in Hunan, according to Xinhua.

Two counties in Guizhou also reported fatalities caused by heavy rain. According to the flood control and drought relief headquarters of Majiang county in the Qiongdongnan Miao and Dong autonomous prefecture, persistent and widespread torrential rainfall between Monday night and early Wednesday pushed precipitation in some townships to historic highs.

The downpours triggered flooding, landslides and other disasters in some areas, leaving homes inundated, roads cut off, and communication and power facilities damaged.

As of Wednesday morning, preliminary investigations showed that 1,456 residents from 482 households had been urgently evacuated and relocated across the county, while three people had died in the disaster.

Emergency crews continued efforts to restore damaged roads and communication lines, while the basic needs of affected residents were being properly ensured, local authorities said.

In the province's Guiding county, heavy rain since Monday led to four deaths and left five others missing as of Tuesday afternoon, according to local authorities.

The National Meteorological Center renewed a blue alert for rainstorms on Wednesday morning, with heavy rainfall expected to continue across parts of the country.

Heavy to torrential rain was forecast to hit central and northern parts of the Guangxi Zhuang autonomous region, its southern coastal areas, Guangdong province, southern Hunan, southern Jiangxi province and southern Hainan province between Wednesday afternoon and Thursday afternoon, the center said.

Some areas in northeastern Guangxi, the region's southern coastal areas, northern Guangdong and southwestern coastal Guangdong are expected to receive between 100 and 200 millimeters of rainfall, according to the center.

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Mass weddings



Couples dressed in traditional Chinese wedding attire take part in a mass wedding ceremony at Luogang Park in Hefei city, Anhui province, on Wednesday. The event, held simultaneously in four cities across the province, promotes traditional marriage customs while encouraging modern, simplified wedding practices. WU FANG / FOR CHINA DAILY

Mainland slams Lai for hostile remarks

Continued separatist stance blamed for escalating cross-Straits tensions

By **LI SHANGYI**
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The Chinese mainland, on Wednesday, condemned Taiwan leader Lai Ching-te's speech marking his second anniversary in office as deceptive and confrontational, blaming his "Taiwan independence" separatist stance for escalating tensions across the Taiwan Strait.

Chen Binhua, spokesman for the State Council Taiwan Affairs Office, said Lai's remarks were "filled with falsehoods and deception, hostility and confrontation".

He criticized Lai for stubbornly adhering to the erroneous "Taiwan independence" stance, promoting the fallacies of so-called "sovereign independence" and "mutual non-subordination", and hyping the "mainland threat" narrative.

Chen said Lai's comments have further escalated cross-Straits tensions and confrontation, reflecting an attempt to pursue "Taiwan independence" through military means and external support, and thereby undermining peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait.

He said the remarks once again confirmed Lai's role as a "peace destroyer" and "crisis creator" in the Taiwan Strait.

In his speech on Wednesday morning, Lai said Taiwan's future could not be determined by "foreign forces" and should be decided solely by its 23 million people.

He also claimed to promote dialogue and exchanges with the Chinese mainland under the principle of "equal dignity", while rejecting what he called "united front tactics" aimed at achieving "reunification under the guise of peace".

Chen dismissed such statements as "hypocritical", saying Lai continues to advocate "Taiwan independence" separatism and stir up anti-mainland sentiment. He accused Lai of attempting to mislead the public in Taiwan and deceive international opinion.

"These familiar tactics have been increasingly seen through by people in Taiwan," Chen said, adding that Lai's deceptive and provocative actions will inevitably face firm opposition from compatriots on both sides of the Strait and from the international community, and are destined to fail.

Chen added that the Taiwan question is a legacy issue of the Chinese civil war in the 1940s.

"No matter what form of elections have been held in Taiwan or who has been elected there since 1949, this cannot change Taiwan's status as part of China," he said, stressing that Taiwan's future can only be jointly decided by all Chinese people, including Taiwan compatriots.

He reaffirmed the unwavering resolve of all Chinese people to defend national sovereignty and territorial integrity.

"We will never allow anyone or

any force, under any pretext, to pursue separatist schemes for "Taiwan independence", Chen said.

In response to a media question on Lai's speech, Guo Jiakun, spokesman for the Foreign Ministry, said the true status quo across the Taiwan Strait is that both sides belong to one China.

Guo said moves by "Taiwan independence" separatist forces cannot change the fundamental nature of the Taiwan question as purely China's internal affair or undermine the international community's firm commitment to the one-China principle.

He stressed that the historical trend toward China's national reunification is unstoppable.

Although Lai did not directly mention "Taiwan independence" in his speech, Zhu Fenglian, a spokeswoman for the State Council Taiwan Affairs Office, said during a regular news briefing on Wednesday that the Democratic Progressive Party authorities have been playing word games to deceive people in Taiwan and the international community while refusing to recognize that both sides of the Taiwan Strait belong to one China.

She said only by completely abandoning the "Taiwan independence" stance, ceasing provocations aimed at seeking "independence", and returning to the political foundation of the 1992 Consensus can the DPP authorities truly safeguard peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait as well as improve and develop cross-Straits relations.

both sides have had extensive communication and will jointly explore ways to address each other's legitimate and lawful concerns, the ministry said.

According to the ministry, China conducts export controls on rare earths and other critical minerals in accordance with laws and regulations, while reviewing compliant license applications intended for civilian use.

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Consensus on tackling maritime challenges

By **ZHANG YI** in Quanzhou, Fujian
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Amid increasingly diverse regional maritime challenges, delegates from Asian coast guard agencies reached a broad consensus on strengthening multilateral law enforcement cooperation to safeguard maritime security.

The consensus was reached at the conclusion of the 22nd Heads of Asian Coast Guard Agencies Meeting Working Level Meeting on Wednesday in Quanzhou, Fujian province.

Hosted by the China Coast Guard, the four-day event brought together more than 50 foreign delegates from 18 countries and regions, as well as representatives from the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime and the ReCAAP Information Sharing Centre, to discuss ways to address maritime security threats.

Summarizing the meeting's achievements, Zhang Jianzhong, head of the Chinese delegation and director-general of the China Coast Guard's law enforcement department, said discussions focused on maritime security trends, search and rescue operations, and environmental protection.

All parties expressed willingness to deepen communication, enhance joint law enforcement capabilities, expand blue partnerships, and promote universal security, Zhang said.

Liu Zhixu, head of the China Coast Guard's international cooperation division, said the meeting remains the most influential multilateral maritime law enforcement cooperation mechanism in the pan-Asia-Pacific region and serves as an important platform for the China Coast Guard to participate in global and regional ocean governance.

As an active practitioner of the Global Security Initiative, the China Coast Guard advocates practical cooperation to turn regional law enforcement visions into reality, Liu said.

By hosting the event, China shared its experience in combating maritime crimes and advancing law enforcement related to marine carbon sinks, offering Chinese solutions for sustainable maritime development, he added.

Fu Yanxiao, deputy head of the China Coast Guard's criminal investigation division, said participants focused on transnational maritime risks and explored ways to establish an expert consultation mechanism.

The meeting also introduced maritime counterterrorism cooperation arrangements and invited member agencies to explore pathways for preventing and combating maritime terrorist activities, he said.

In addition to working group sessions on maritime search and rescue, environmental protection, information sharing and joint exercises, the event also facilitated a series of bilateral talks among member agencies.

Pongsak Somboon, deputy secretary-general of the Thai Maritime Enforcement Command Center, said the Thai delegation held bilateral talks with the China Coast Guard to enhance cooperation in training and law enforcement. "We share the same goal, and we want to help each other improve maritime capabilities," he said.

The event also highlighted Quanzhou's heritage as a historic Maritime Silk Road hub. Delegates visited the Quanzhou Maritime Museum to learn about China's ancient maritime trade and shipping history.

Trade: Talks yield outcomes in agriculture, aviation

From page 1

Such progress will allow both sides to better leverage their strengths in agricultural trade, bringing tangible benefits to companies and the broader market, Zhou said.

The topics of the talks also included aviation, a sector that has long been part of China-US commercial

ties. Based on its air transportation development needs, China will purchase 200 Boeing aircraft in accordance with commercial principles, while the US will ensure sufficient supplies of engines and related parts to China, the ministry said.

Zhang Yansheng, a senior economist, said: "China and the US are both too important to the world. When their relationship is good, the

world benefits; when it is not, the world feels the shock."

Executives from US companies noted that greater stability in China-US economic relations is important for sustaining long-term cooperation and strengthening business confidence.

Michael Doogue, chief executive officer of the US semiconductor manufacturer Allegro Microsystems,

said that China plays a dual role in the company's strategy — as both a major market and an increasingly important part of its global supply and innovation ecosystem.

"We will continue to invest in China by expanding research and development collaboration and optimizing our supply chain," he said.

On export controls related to rare earths and other critical minerals,

Loquat: Fruit inspires chefs and gains diners' attention

From page 1

Among China's many loquat-producing regions, Dongshan's famed white jade loquat remains one of the country's most prized varieties. Behind its reputation lies decades of painstaking cultivation.

Huang Jichuan, 70, from Dongshan, has worked in the orchards since he was a teenager. His family has grown loquats for

generations. According to Huang, today's celebrated white jade variety can be traced back to a single exceptional tree discovered decades ago by his father, Huang Jiyou. Through years of cultivation, the variety gradually spread across the hillsides of Dongshan.

Producing premium loquats requires meticulous care. In spring, farmers thin the fruit clusters by hand, cutting away most of

the young fruits, so that the remaining few can absorb enough nutrients to grow larger and sweeter.

The fruit may last only seconds on the palate, but the work behind it stretches across an entire year.

Around *xiao man*, Dongshan enters its busiest season. Before dawn breaks, farmers are already climbing steep orchard slopes to begin harvesting. After hours of

picking under the rising summer heat, the fruit must still be sorted, packed into foam trays by hand and prepared for overnight shipment across the country.

Yet despite the exhausting labor, the farmers speak about their trees with unmistakable affection.

"It's like raising children," Song said, looking at the orchard beside him. "If the trees get sick, you treat them. If the leaves turn yellow, you

nourish them back to health. Only careful tending can bring out the fruit at its best."

Beyond fresh consumption, loquats have long been woven into daily life in Dongshan. Excess fruit is preserved in syrup or transformed into loquat wine, while loquat flowers and leaves are traditionally simmered into herbal pastes to soothe coughs.

Today, that seasonal sweetness is also inspiring chefs far beyond Jiangnan. As seasonal Chinese ingredients gain renewed attention among urban diners, loquats are

also making their way onto contemporary restaurant menus.

At the Waldorf Astoria Beijing, chef Wang Chunzeng recently introduced a chilled *qingbuliang* sweet soup with fresh loquat, combining the fruit with traditional Cantonese ingredients such as Job's tears, glehnia root and red dates.

"Hot and humid summer days call for something light, gentle and refreshing," Wang said. "Fresh loquat brings natural sweetness and a soft floral note that perfectly captures the feeling of early summer."

COMMENT

Editorials

Sino-Russian ties have entered new stage of greater achievements, faster development

Russian President Vladimir Putin's 25th visit to China this week has once again drawn global attention to one of the world's most consequential major-country relationships. The steady development of China-Russia relations carries particular significance beyond the bilateral scope especially at a time marked by geopolitical turbulence.

During their meeting on Wednesday in Beijing, President Xi Jinping and his Russian counterpart exchanged views on bilateral ties, practical cooperation and major international and regional issues of mutual concern, injecting fresh momentum into the China-Russia comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination in its 30th anniversary year.

During Wednesday's meeting, the two sides also agreed to further extend the China-Russia Treaty of Good-Neighborliness and Friendly Cooperation — this year marks the 25th anniversary of its signing — demonstrating the stability of bilateral relations and the high level of mutual trust between the two countries.

China-Russia relations have developed steadily because the two countries have continuously deepened their political mutual trust and strategic coordination. This is the result of long-time careful cultivation, mutual support and a shared commitment to respecting each other's core interests and development paths.

What makes China-Russia relations distinctive is that they have developed according to their own internal logic rather than external pressure. The bilateral relationship is characterized by non-alliance, non-confrontation and non-targeting of third parties. That also means the relationship is not subject to interference or manipulation by external actors.

That is particularly meaningful in today's world, where some countries still view international relations through the outdated prism of bloc confrontation and zero-sum rivalry.

In recent years, bilateral trade and investment have maintained stable and robust growth, showing the strong endogenous driving force behind the relationship.

The two neighbors' economies possess complementary advantages and their practical cooperation is a long-term strategic choice serving the interests of both peoples.

In the process of cooperation and communication, political mutual trust has further deepened, while exchanges in trade, investment, energy, science and technology, people-to-people

and sub-national dialogues have continued to advance. The bonds between the two peoples have also grown stronger.

A recent survey among young people in both countries showed that more than 80 percent of respondents view bilateral relations positively and hope for stronger exchanges. Such findings reflect not only the vitality of people-to-people ties, but also the broader aspiration among younger generations for peace, cooperation and mutual understanding in a changing world.

Unswervingly promoting the long-term, sound, steady and high-quality development of China-Russia relations is a strategic choice made by both sides based on the fundamental interests of the two nations and broader global trends. In a turbulent era, mutual trust between major countries is increasingly valuable for world peace and stability.

The China-Russia relationship has entered a new stage of greater achievements and faster development, Xi said in his meeting with Putin.

In recent years, faced with a fluid and turbulent international situation, China and Russia have developed the comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination for a new era on the basis of equality, mutual respect, good faith, and win-win cooperation, as Xi pointed out.

This has enabled the two countries to expand practical cooperation at a time when unilateralism and protectionism are on the rise in some parts of the world. Such coordination also carries significance for safeguarding multilateralism and international fairness.

It is important for the two countries to work together in international organizations so as to make the global governance system more just and reasonable and jointly uphold international justice and fairness while advancing the building of a community with a shared future for humanity.

A stable and forward-looking China-Russia relationship is therefore not only beneficial to the two countries, but also contributes valuable certainty and positive energy to a volatile world.

As permanent members of the United Nations Security Council and major countries, China and Russia should continue to adopt a strategic and long-term perspective and work together to fully implement the important common understandings reached by the two leaders. The two countries should seize the historic opportunities for their respective development and revitalization and contribute to the common good of the world.

Secessionists common enemy of China and US

Lai Ching-te's tenure as the head of the Democratic Progressive Party authorities of China's Taiwan region has been marked by a series of missteps and failures that have not only strained cross-Straits relations but also undermined the island's development prospects.

Contrary to his shameless claim in a speech on Wednesday marking the two-year anniversary of his tenure that he has maintained the status quo of peace and stability in the Taiwan Strait, the DPP authorities have stubbornly adhered to a "Taiwan independence" stance, peddled separatist fallacies and obstructed cross-Straits exchanges.

That speech was a response, if not a desperate "don't desert me" plea, to US President Donald Trump's Friday interview, in which the US leader stated, "We're not looking to have somebody say, 'Let's go independent because the United States is backing us.'" This remark dealt a heavy blow to Lai.

In his speech — yet another litany of lies and deceit — Lai openly groveled to Washington, begging for an opportunity to tell the US leader that he wishes to continue purchasing US weapons, which he misleadingly labeled as essential to peace. Ironically, he tried to assure his audience that the island's future would not be determined by external forces just moments after trying to solicit US support.

In an attempt to conceal his secessionist nature, Lai peddled a so-called "Taiwan subject mentality" in his speech, openly seeking to sever the island from the Chinese motherland.

This "soft independence" is hidden and pernicious, no less harming than the DPP authorities' overt political separatist sloganeering.

Evidently anxious over the US leader's remarks, Lai posted a so-called "five-point speech" on Facebook on Sunday, in which he called black white, barefacedly claiming that his authorities are the protectors of regional peace. Yet to his horror, that "carefully worded" message failed to elicit the hoped-for response from Washington — explaining why Lai doubled down on his efforts to appeal to the US not to give up on him.

If Lai truly intends to show the world that he is not a secessionist and that he is committed to peace and stability, he should simply pledge his support for the 1992 Consensus and stop fawning over the US.

The true color of his secessionist feather is laid bare by the extraordinary lengths he has gone to in an attempt to conceal his separatist nature — and his fear of losing US support for his political agenda.

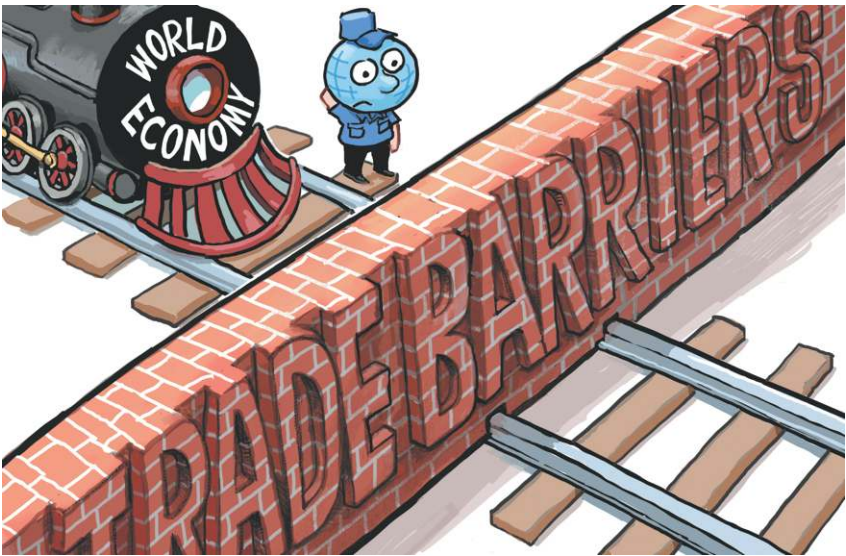
The predicament Taiwan faces today stems from the DPP authorities' long-standing practice of placing ideological manipulation above reality, staking the island's security on the will of the US, and tying the future of Taiwan people to the dangerous path of seeking "Taiwan independence" through reliance on external forces. Once Washington shows even signs of shifting priorities, that layer of illusion surrounding the DPP authorities' reckless approach will be stripped away. In short, "Taiwan independence" is a dead end.

Lai's latest remarks do not signal any abandonment of "Taiwan independence", but rather a repackaging of it in more carefully crafted rhetoric.

"Taiwan independence" is fundamentally incompatible with peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait. The expansion of separatist forces advocating "Taiwan independence" will ultimately push Taiwan toward a dangerous abyss — a trajectory that runs counter not only to the interests of the Chinese nation, but also to the strategic interests of the US. In this sense, curbing "Taiwan independence" separatist activities and maintaining peace and stability across the Taiwan Strait serve the shared interests of both China and the US. Lai's remarks further underscore the reality that "Taiwan independence" has become a common challenge confronting both Beijing and Washington.

There is but one China in the world and that Taiwan is part of China. No matter what Lai says or does, he will not stop the historical trend toward reunification, which is unstoppable, as a spokesperson for the State Council Taiwan Affairs Office said on Wednesday.

Luo Jie



Opinion Line

Redline conservation based on space-air-ground monitoring

In the run-up to the 25th International Day for Biological Diversity on Friday, the global community faces a sobering reality check.

According to a release from the United Nations Development Programme last August, only \$121 billion is invested annually in conservation worldwide, leaving an estimated annual gap of over \$700 billion.

Meanwhile, the recently unveiled UN Global Forest Goals Report 2026 reveals that the global forest area declined by more than 40 million hectares between 2015 and 2025, while financing for sustainable forest management remains far below estimated needs.

There are only two solutions going forward: either countries have to dramatically increase funding, or find smarter, more cost-effective ways to conserve nature. While dramatically increasing funding is no easy task, China may have found a way to achieve the latter. Its Ecological Conservation Redline strategy offers a way to protect biodiversity at remarkably low cost — and one that holds valuable lessons for the rest of the world.

Many nations, particularly those in the Global South, struggle with uncontrolled land encroachment and expansion. The default approach is often to develop first and clean up later — an expensive and frequently futile exercise.

China's redline strategy flips this logic on its head with a simple yet powerful principle: draw the baseline before the blueprint. Instead of spending billions to restore degraded wetlands or deforested lands at a later stage, the approach forces planners to first identify and cordon off areas that are ecologically vital or fragile. Only then is development permitted elsewhere.

This "defensive tool" is inherently low-cost and in doing so, it transforms biodiversity protection from an expensive afterthought into a preemptive safeguard, helping nations escape the zero-sum game between ecology and economy that traps so many developing countries.

The results speak for themselves. According to a blue book released by the Ministry of Natural Resources late last year, since the redlines were established nationwide in 2022, China has seen forest area within the redlines increase by 3,344 square kilometers, and water body area increase by 320 sq km. At the same time, construction area has shrunk by 6.5 sq km and mining area by 5.6 sq km.

Within marine ecological redlines, sea use area has reduced by 873 sq km, down 35 percent.

Perhaps the most innovative and budget-friendly aspect of this redline system is its administrative simplicity. Unlike traditional nature reserves,

which often require dedicated management bodies, staff members and ongoing operational budgets for each site, China's redline strategy follows a different tack: there is no special management body for each of the areas encircled by its redlines.

Instead, the government oversees these vast zones using a combination of satellites, drones and targeted on-the-ground patrols — a three-dimensional "space-air-ground" monitoring network. This model dramatically drives down enforcement costs, allowing governments to protect more land with fewer resources, narrowing the gap between ambition and affordability.

Of course, the global biodiversity finance gap of over \$700 billion is not a problem any country can solve alone. But China's Ecological Conservation Redline strategy offers a compelling, low-cost, and readily applicable model. It proves that effective biodiversity protection does not always require vast bureaucracies or unlimited budgets.

Sometimes, it takes nothing more than a clear line on a map, a satellite in the sky that shows it, and the political will to say: here, development stops, and life begins.

For any country seeking to protect its natural heritage without breaking the bank, that is a lesson worth learning.

— HOU LIQIANG, CHINA DAILY

What They Say

Global cooperation launchpad for lunar exploration

Editor's note: China's aerospace sector, especially its lunar exploration program, has made rapid progress in recent years. Yang Yuguang, chair of the International Astronautical Federation's Space Transportation Committee, spoke to China.com.cn about China's achievements and the importance of international cooperation in lunar exploration. Below are excerpts of the interview. The views don't necessarily represent those of China Daily.

China is a reliable partner in international lunar exploration, and that reliability is rooted largely in its sound technologies. Through the lunar missions from Chang'e-1 to Chang'e-6, the country has mastered exploration technologies of lunar orbiting, landing and sample return. These capabilities are essential for lunar exploration activities and will enable China to carry international payloads in future lunar missions.

China has a long history of international cooperation in outer space. For example, the resource satellites jointly developed by China and Brazil have been hailed as a model of South-South cooperation. International cooperation has been embedded in China's lunar exploration program from the very beginning. Deep-space tracking, telemetry and command communications depend on extensive support from ground stations. As China's territory cannot always face the moon, it needs assistance from stations located in other countries.

Throughout the orbiting, landing and sample return stages of the lunar

exploration program, the missions from China carried experimental payloads from various countries.

Some lunar samples retrieved by Chang'e-5 and Chang'e-6 were given as State gifts to visiting heads of state from other countries. These samples given by China to other countries for scientific research are expected to yield valuable outcomes.

Scientists from both China and other countries can apply for access to lunar soil and rock samples brought back by Chang'e-5 and Chang'e-6. These samples will help scientists worldwide deepen their understanding of the evolution and history of the moon.

China is scheduled to launch the Chang'e-7 probe this year. Together with the subsequent Chang'e-8 probe, it will help form the basic model of the International Lunar Research Station. China is making a major contribution to the construction of the station, which will be built in the South Pole region of the moon. International payloads can be carried to the station by probes from both China and other countries to become part of the station.

Lunar exploration is no longer an endeavor reserved solely for national space agencies. Many commercial enterprises are now able to participate in it. Nevertheless, lunar exploration remains a megaproject that requires huge investments and a long period of time. Through international cooperation, participants can share the financial burden, making it easier to secure government support.

China has made extensive efforts to promote international cooperation in lunar and deep-space exploration. The country will remain committed to such cooperation in the future as well.

The formulation of common standards will be crucial for advancing international cooperation, especially in technological areas. Effective cooperation needs a shared "language". Without unified specifications for electrical, mechanical, signal and other interfaces, international cooperation will become too complicated to carry out. China is also beginning to formulate international standards in the field of aerospace.

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VIEWS

Asif Ali Zardari

Pakistan and China began their remarkable journey of friendship and cooperation 75 years ago with the establishment of diplomatic relations. Since then, we have built a partnership defined by trust, consistency, and the ability to stand together through difficult times and shifting global realities. What began as a diplomatic engagement has evolved into a model of enduring cooperation between our two nations.

This relationship is also deeply personal for me. My late father in law, Shah-eed Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, and Shaheed Mohtarma Benazir Bhutto, believed strongly in building lasting ties with China and played pivotal roles in shaping our early cooperation. That legacy continues into the third generation. My son, Bilawal Bhutto Zardari, and daughter, Aseefa Bhutto Zardari, are both actively engaged in strengthening links between our two nations.

Our connection, however, predates modern diplomacy. For centuries, the regions that are now in Pakistan and China were linked through the ancient Silk Road — routes that crossed mountains and rivers, carrying goods, culture and ideas between our peoples. These exchanges have laid the foundation for a relationship that is both historic and natural. Pakistan-China relations have never been transactional. They are rooted in mutual respect, trust and a shared understanding of each other's priorities.

Since 1951, we have supported each other on issues of core importance, including Pakistan's firm commitment to the one-China principle and our role in supporting China's rightful place at the United Nations in 1971.

What makes this partnership unique is how it has evolved. Regular high-level exchanges have kept it forward-looking, translating political understanding into practical cooperation, across infrastructure, energy, trade and agriculture — areas that directly impact people's lives.

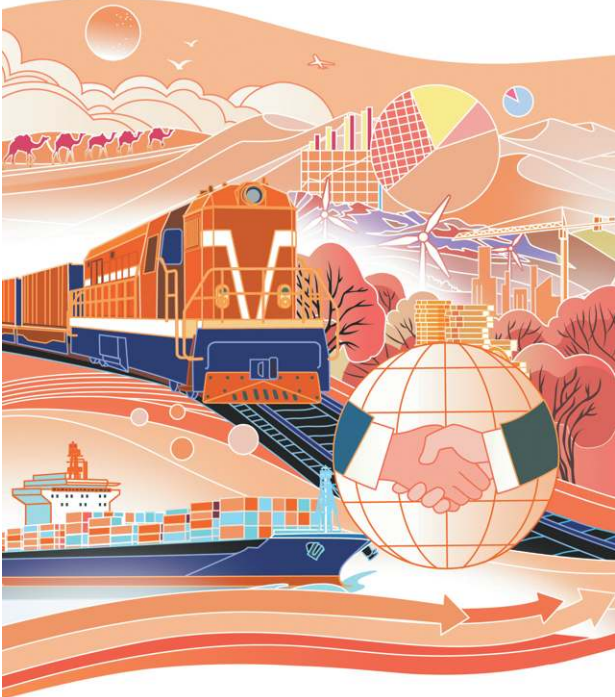
I have witnessed this closeness firsthand. During my earlier tenure as President from 2008 to 2013, I visited China frequently.

These visits were not merely official engagements; they were opportunities to deepen trust, observe China's transformation and fortify our genuine friendship.

My visits again in 2025 brought those experiences full circle.

The scale of China's progress is extraordinary. Under the leadership

Seventy-five years of friendship: Pakistan and China step into the future



SHI YU / CHINA DAILY

of President Xi Jinping, China has consolidated its position as a leading global power and the world's second-largest economy.

This transformation reflects vision, discipline, and a sustained commitment to development that has reshaped the global economic landscape.

Through profound shifts in the international system — from the Cold War to today's more complex and fragmented world — Pakistan-China relations have remained resilient.

At a time when divisions often dominate global discourse, our partnership stands out for its consistency

and clarity of purpose.

We do not view security and development as a race; we see it as a shared journey. This belief shapes our cooperation at the United Nations, within the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, and across the broader Global South, reflecting a shared commitment to multilateralism and dialogue.

This approach also guides our actions in times of crisis. During the recent war involving the United States, Israel and Iran, China played a constructive role by encouraging restraint and supporting dialogue, as

well as resolutely backing Pakistan's mediation efforts, alongside its own compelling diplomatic engagement. This reflected our conviction that even the most complex disputes must be resolved peacefully.

China's Belt and Road Initiative has taken this philosophy of shared progress to a global scale. By investing in infrastructure and connectivity, it has opened new avenues for trade, strengthened economic linkages, and created opportunities for growth.

For many developing countries, it has demonstrated how connectivity can drive inclusive prosperity.

Within this broader vision, the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) stands as a flagship of our cooperation. It has transformed Pakistan's infrastructure, reduced energy shortages, and created new economic opportunities.

As CPEC enters its next phase, our focus is increasingly on people-centered development — industrial cooperation, modern agriculture, job creation, and technology transfer — to ensure growth is both sustainable and inclusive.

Our defense partnership remains another key pillar of this relationship. Cooperation in defense technology, training, and joint exercises has reinforced Pakistan's capabilities while contributing to regional stability. It is defensive in nature and reflects our commitment to peace.

Yet, the true strength of Pakistan-China relations lies beyond governments and agreements. It rests in the bonds between our people.

Students, artists, entrepreneurs, and young people from both countries are building connections that transcend political cycles. These human ties give real meaning to the idea of an "all-weather friendship".

The symbolism of this year's Chinese zodiac — the Year of the Horse — captures the spirit of our partnership: energy, resilience, and forward momentum.

As we look ahead, our direction is clear: deepen cooperation, strengthen solidarity among Global South nations, and work together for a rule-based international order.

Our partnership is not directed against any country; it is rooted in mutual respect and shared progress.

Seventy-five years on, Pakistan-China relations remain strong, steady, and deeply humane — and that enduring spirit will continue to guide us into the future.

The author is the President of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan. The views don't necessarily reflect those of China Daily.

Loh Wee Keng

China boosts shared prosperity in Asia-Pacific

The first five months of 2026 have seen intensified geopolitical rivalries and a turbulent global economy. To ensure businesses operate smoothly, major countries should take responsibility for stabilizing both regional and global markets.

As the host of the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation 2026, China is working to inject stability and foster consensus for regional prosperity. Under the theme "Building an Asia-Pacific Community to Prosper Together", China has prioritized openness, innovation and cooperation to advance the Free Trade Area of the Asia-Pacific.

Around 2017, China shifted its focus toward the Asia-Pacific region. This pivot shaped a new economic landscape characterized by closer ties and a stronger emphasis on regional integration.

That year, China's trade with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations countries crossed a record \$500 billion.

In the following years, through the Belt and Road Initiative, APEC, the implementation of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership, and the signing of the China-ASEAN FTA 3.0 Upgrade Protocol, China has steered neighboring countries toward a new consensus. A standout result is that ASEAN became China's largest trading partner in 2020, while China has remained the association's largest trading partner since 2009.

Four years after its implementation, the RCEP has significantly impacted China's trade landscape. By 2025, China's trade with the other RCEP members reached \$1.9 trillion, accounting for 44.2 percent of the country's total foreign trade growth and underscoring the agreement's role in fostering regional cooperation.

China's high-tech exports grew by 13.2 percent, with exports of specialized equipment, high-end machine tools, and industrial robots increasing by 20.6 percent, 21.5 percent and 48.7 percent respectively. This reflects China's growing export focus on high-end technology and advanced productive forces.

China is also steering sustainable growth in the Asia-Pacific through its green transition. In 2024, Asia accounted for 72 percent of the world's newly installed renewable energy capacity.

In 2025, Asia attracted 65 percent of global investment in solar, 64 percent in wind, and 41 percent in battery sectors, propelling the global shift toward clean energy.

China's role is pivotal; in 2025, its clean energy capacity reached 2.4 billion kilowatts, about 45 percent of the global total. In just five years, its combined installed wind and solar capacity has surged from 530 million to 1.84 billion kilowatts.

Global energy transition investment reached a record \$2.3 trillion in 2025, with the Asia-Pacific region leading the charge at 47 percent of the total. Although China's investment dipped slightly due to lower equipment costs, it continued to be the world's largest single market.

Emerging markets, particularly those in Southeast Asia, are also key drivers of the global energy transition. Vietnam's energy transition investment has exceeded \$10 billion, while Indonesia's electric vehicle and energy storage markets are rapidly expanding.

Within the RCEP region, EV trade grew by 45.2 percent year-on-year, and exports of green products such as wind turbines and electric railway locomotives doubled, highlighting the significant green transformation fueled by regional cooperation.

However, Asia's energy transition still faces challenges such as reliance on fossil fuels and insufficient power grid infrastructure.

Li Baosen, deputy secretary-general of the Global Energy Interconnection Development and Cooperation Organization, notes that China's cooperation models and technical support can help address developmental disparities across the region.

By supplying photovoltaic cells, new energy vehicles, smart grids, and energy storage solutions, China is aiding regional and global decarbonization. The energy crisis sparked by the US-Iran conflict further underscored the foresight in China's new energy initiatives.

China is propelling regional smart development. In 2025, its trade with ASEAN surpassed \$1 trillion — a milestone driven by both enormous shared development needs and vibrant opportunities in the digital and green economies and other emerging fields. China's expertise in 5G, cloud computing, and artificial intelligence aligns with ASEAN countries' needs for industrial upgrading.

Their cross-border e-commerce has maintained over 20 percent growth for years. The China-ASEAN FTA 3.0 Upgrade Protocol now includes the digital economy, enabling Chinese digital and new energy companies to deepen their presence in ASEAN markets. This supports collaboration in cloud infrastructure, AI and fintech, and promotes the integration of industry and supply chains.

China's regional AI cooperation has also yielded impressive results. At the 2025 SCO Summit in Tianjin, Beijing systematically outlined a strategic direction and pathways for regional AI cooperation and offered an SCO solution for global AI governance. As China and ASEAN strengthen ties in cross-border data flows, digital payments, and smart cities, a closely integrated digital economy community is emerging.

Consensus-building is inseparable from people-to-people exchanges, with tourism playing a crucial role. In 2025, China saw a record 697 million inbound and outbound crossings, while inbound trips reached 154 million, driven by incentives such as visa-free policies for 48 countries and expanded departure tax refunds.

Tourism between China and Asia-Pacific countries is advancing across five dimensions: scale, policy, technology, consumption structure, and regional coordination, aiming for high-quality, resilient, and integrated development.

RCEP and APEC have facilitated tourism by increasing flight routes and enhancing joint marketing, boosting visitor flows. Meanwhile, technology, particularly AI, is transforming the tourism service ecosystem by improving booking, personalized guidance, and other services.

Through economic cooperation organizations, advanced new energy technologies, innovative digital economy initiatives, and open tourism policies, China is injecting stability into the Asia-Pacific region on multiple fronts.

The author is the chairman of the Malaysian Chamber of Commerce and Industry in China. The views don't necessarily represent those of China Daily.

Visit deepens good-neighborliness and friendly cooperation

Editor's note: President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin, who was on a state visit to China, on Wednesday signed a joint statement on enhancing comprehensive strategic coordination and deepening good-neighborliness and friendly cooperation between the two countries. Two experts shared their views on this matter with China Daily's Li Huixian and Wang Qingyun.

Deepened coordination beneficial to both

The high-level engagement between President Xi Jinping and visiting Russian President Vladimir Putin in Beijing on Wednesday and the signing of more than 20 cooperation agreements in areas such as education, technology and economic and trade relations by the two heads of state hold strategic significance on multiple levels.

First, both sides agreed to extend the China-Russia Treaty of Good-Neighborliness and Friendly Cooperation, thereby maintaining the legal foundation for deep bilateral ties.

This extension allows the further development of their comprehensive strategic partnership, safeguarding their sovereignty, and developmental interests across the board, while advancing cooperation in various fields.

Notably, they leverage platforms such as the China-Russia Years of Education to unlock the potential of exchanges between their peoples.

The two countries can also leverage existing multilateral cooperation frameworks — including the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, BRICS, and the coordination mechanisms linking the Belt and Road Initiative with the Eurasian Economic Union — to jointly promote regional connectivity and cross-border trade, ensure the smooth operation of regional industry and supply chains, and foster a stable and orderly environment for regional development.

This collaboration will enable China and Russia to further expand cooperation in areas such as energy, cross-border logistics, local-currency settlements, and trade and economic exchanges.

Moreover, the Chinese side called

for even higher quality development and revitalization of the comprehensive strategic coordination between China and Russia.

This approach has a solid practical foundation. Both countries are at a critical stage of industrial upgrading and are pursuing self-reliant development in their economic and technological systems. They face shared challenges, such as trade barriers and supply chain instability. By deepening their cooperation, the two nations can effectively complement each other's economic strengths.

For instance, Russia can leverage China's vast market, comprehensive manufacturing capacity, and infrastructure capabilities to broaden its development space and unlock the potential of its energy and other resources.

At the same time, China can draw on Russia's resource endowments, market and favorable geographical location to diversify its energy and resource supplies and smooth its westward-opening corridors.

This way, mutual reinforcement can serve each country's domestic revitalization needs.

From a long-term strategic perspective, by supporting each other's development and revitalization through cooperation, the two countries can steadily strengthen their development confidence, withstand external uncertainties, achieve stable growth, and further consolidate the foundation for bilateral relations.

Globally, both countries can continue working together to promote a multipolar world, advance multilateralism and implement the four global initiatives proposed by China and counter hegemony, unilateralism and bloc confrontation.

The commitment of Beijing and

Moscow to promoting a more just and equitable international order through the United Nations is a stabilizing force, and can help safeguard the legitimate rights and interests of Global South countries.

Zhao Huirong is a researcher at the Institute of Russian, Eastern European and Central Asian Studies, Chinese Academy of Social Sciences.

An enduring partnership for mutual growth

The heads of state of China and Russia held talks in Beijing on Wednesday, guiding the two countries' efforts to conduct comprehensive strategic coordination of even higher quality.

This year marks the 30th anniversary of the establishment of the China-Russia comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination and the 25th anniversary of the signing of the China-Russia Treaty of Good-Neighborliness and Friendly Cooperation.

Over the past 25 years, China and Russia have followed the spirit of the treaty and maintained close coordination in political, economic, cultural and other fields.

In 2019, bilateral relations were elevated to a comprehensive strategic partnership of coordination for a new era, placing cooperation across all fields on the fast track.

Both sides agreed to extend the treaty on Wednesday, which further consolidates the legal foundation for permanent good-neighborliness and friendly cooperation between the two countries.

Under the strategic guidance of the heads of state of China and Russia, the two countries have developed a mature relationship that has become an example for a new type of

WORLD

Well of hope



A child drinks fresh water drawn from a well built with China's assistance, in the Plateaux Region of the West African nation of Togo, on April 28. In November 2024, Jiangxi Zhongmei Engineering Group broke ground on the rural water project in Togo, marking a major step in implementing the outcomes of the 2024 Beijing Summit of the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation. The project aimed to drill 300 wells and install 300 hand pumps across the Plateaux Region, which could significantly improve rural drinking water conditions and enhance public health once completed. SI YUAN / XINHUA

AI-related data breaches are surging, report finds

WASHINGTON — Hackers are increasingly using AI to detect software vulnerabilities, which has shortened the time targets have to respond to threats, global telecommunications company Verizon said in a recent report.

Verizon said using software flaws in data surpassed stolen credentials for the first time. It said in a review of more than 31,000 incidents that 31 percent of all breaches began with vulnerability exploitation, adding, “AI is fundamentally reshaping the cybersecurity industry.”

The 2026 Data Breach Investigations Report, which reviews a wide range of industry data, shows intruders are using generative artificial intelligence to help at all stages of attacks, “including targeting, initial access, and development of malware and other tools.”

AI was being used by threat actors “to accelerate the time to exploit known vulnerabilities, shrinking the window for defense from months to mere hours”, the report said.

The report also found that the use of shadow AI, or non-authorized AI, is now the third most common non-malicious insider action in data loss incidents. Employees are submitting source code in image and other structured data formats.

AI models are making their mark beyond just the realm of finding and exploiting vulnerabilities.

It also noted a steady increase in AI bot activity, with the number of automated web crawlers growing by 20 percent each month — while human-driven traffic remains flat — pointing to a future where bot-related threats may become more frequent.

Patrick Munch, chief security officer at Mondoo, a supplier of vulnerability management services, told Computer Weekly that the report confirmed pain points defenders are already feeling.

“The breach happens in the gap between knowing and fixing, and that is where the work has to move ... 62 percent of teams still run remediation manually, only 2 percent are fully automated, and just 9 percent are confident they can fix what matters in time.”

Verizon's Chief Information Security Officer Nasrin Rezai said it was critical to address the growing threats.

“We need to fight AI with AI. We need to incorporate them into our practices.”

AGENCIES VIA XINHUA

Chinese American leaders welcome Trump’s remarks

Washington’s recent position on Taiwan question a positive sign, communities say

By **CHANG JUN** in San Francisco
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Leaders of Chinese American communities in the United States responded positively to US President Donald Trump’s remarks regarding the Taiwan question, viewing them as a positive signal that the US government understands China’s position, attaches importance to China’s core concerns, and does not support or accept “Taiwan independence”.

On Friday, Trump said in a Fox News interview that “I’m not looking to have somebody go independent”, adding that Taiwan should not expect a “blank check” from the US military.

Trump made these remarks shortly after the China-US summit, during which President Xi Jinping told his visiting counterpart that the Taiwan question is the most important issue in China-US relations.

Xi told Trump that if handled properly, the bilateral relationship will enjoy overall stability. Otherwise, the two countries will have clashes and even conflicts, putting the entire relationship in grave jeopardy. Xi emphasized that “Taiwan independence” and cross-strait peace and stability are as irreconcilable as fire and water.

“We have been closely following the meetings between President Xi Jinping and President Trump in Beijing,” said Zhang Jingjing, leader of the San Francisco-based China Peaceful Unification Western America, a pro-reunification organization based in the San Francisco Bay Area.

“The Trump administration’s recent position on the Taiwan question has served as a positive factor in China-US relations, and has laid an important foundation upon which the two sides were able to reach a series of agreements during the summit,” she said.

“It has further strengthened our conviction that the peaceful reunification of Taiwan with the motherland will surely be achieved,” she said.

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“Taiwan is an inalienable part of Chinese territory. It has never been a country, and will never become one.”

Betty Yuan, who immigrated first from the Chinese mainland to Taiwan in the mid-20th century and later to the United States, has long been an active advocate for China’s peaceful reunification.

The Taiwan question has always been among the “most sensitive and fundamental” issues in China-US relations, Yuan told China Daily.

After concluding his visit to China, Trump publicly reiterated that he did not wish to see Taiwan move toward independence, a signal of stability that helps prevent the international community from misconstruing the US position as a significant policy shift on Taiwan, Yuan said.

Trump’s remarks also reflect Washington’s recognition that sustaining “productive engagement” with China across areas such as trade, business, and regional security naturally requires reducing the disruptive impact of the Taiwan question on the broader bilateral relationship, Yuan said.

Furthermore, Trump’s remarks serve as a pointed warning to “Taiwan independence” forces on the island and place them under tangible pressure, Yuan said.

Echoing Yuan’s assessment, Dong Xudong, a community representative based in San Francisco, said Trump’s remarks send a clear “signal of stabilization” as the world’s two largest economies work to manage differences and de-escalate risks.

Cup of tea

Guests taste Chinese tea at the China Cultural Center in Berlin, Germany, during the “Tea for Harmony Yaji Cultural Salon” event on Tuesday. The event featured tea culture exhibitions, lectures, and artistic performances, offering a systematic presentation of the rich historical heritage and contemporary value of Chinese tea culture.

ZHANG HAOFU / XINHUA

US household debt hits an all-time high

By **BELINDA ROBINSON** in New York
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Household debt in the United States hit a record high of \$18.8 trillion in the first quarter of the year, a report by the Federal Reserve Bank of New York found, as some consumers found it increasingly difficult to pay their bills and manage their debts.

The findings from the quarterly report on household debt and credit, released in mid-May by the Federal Reserve Bank of New York’s Center for Microeconomic Data, said that US households owed money on mortgages, credit cards, autos and student loans. The overall increase in debt was driven by higher balances on auto loans and mortgages.

“It’s a struggle to keep our finances in check,” Sarah, 39, a married mother-of-two from Brooklyn, New York, told China Daily. She admitted feeling “embarrassed” about how high her debt was and declined to give her surname.

“With our mortgage payment and what we owe on our credit cards, student loans and the cost of having two young kids under five, it’s a lot. We feel like we’re barely above water some months. My husband works full-time, I’m a freelancer. It gets me down, yes, it feels embarrassing for sure.”

The New York Fed said that mortgage balances rose \$21 billion in the first quarter and totaled \$13.19 trillion at the end of March. Credit card balances fell by \$25 billion but stood at \$1.25 trillion. Auto loan balances increased by \$18 billion to \$1.69 trillion in the first quarter of the year.

Carlos Savala, 71, originally from Costa Rica, lives in Manhattan, New York in subsidized housing. The retiree, who used to work in

the Rockefeller Center, is fed up with the cost of everything, especially food, and gets free meals from a food pantry in midtown three days a week.

“Everything is expensive! It all costs more to me, especially food. I don’t cook. This place helps me out on Tuesday, Wednesday and Thursday. I’m very thankful to them for what they do,” Savala said. “On the other days, when they’re not open, I go to other places ... You’ve got to pull back on the nice things to afford the basics and your bills.”

Rising inflation

The rise in household debt came as inflation rose for a second consecutive month, data from the US Bureau of Labor Statistics shows.

The Consumer Price Index rose at a seasonally adjusted 0.6 percent in April, making the one-year pace 3.8 percent — its highest level since March 2023.

Rising gasoline and energy costs linked to tensions in the Middle East contributed to the increase in inflation, according to analysts and recent market data.

The national average cost of a gallon of regular gas was \$4.53 (\$1.20 per liter), the highest level since 2022, the American Automobile Association said on Tuesday.

Arnold P., 55, an economist and financial adviser from Brooklyn, New York, withheld his surname to protect the anonymity of his clients. He advises clients on tight incomes to focus on paying the essentials first and then tackle their debt.

“I see a lot of people who have massive amounts of debt,” he said. “It’s usually a mortgage, or rent, credit card debt and college loans combined, which means they find that their debt-to-income ratio is too high, exceeding 40 to 50 percent. Some are in serious financial trouble. Many really need my help.”

Source tracing



Scientists collect rodents potentially carrying the disease from traps near Ushuaia, Argentina, on Monday, to determine whether or not hantavirus is present there. JUAN MABROMATA / AFP

Briefly

UNITED STATES
Combat teams in Europe downsized

The Pentagon announced on Tuesday that it has reduced the number of US Brigade Combat Teams assigned to Europe from four to three, returning troop levels to those seen in 2021. The decision resulted in a temporary delay in the deployment of US forces to Poland, the Department of Defense said in a statement. The Pentagon will determine the final disposition of US forces in Europe based on further analysis of US’ strategic and operational requirements, the statement said. This analysis is designed to advance US President Donald Trump’s “America First” agenda by incentivizing and enabling NATO to take primary responsibility for Europe’s conventional defense, the statement added.

Talks held with Cuba on \$100m aid offer

The US and Cuba held talks this week on an offer of \$100 million in assistance, which Washington has dangled as an “incentive for reforms”, a US official said on Tuesday. The aid would be distributed through Catholic Relief Services, and Samaritan’s Purse, an evangelical Protestant charity, and not handed over directly to the Cuban government, the official said. Cuban

Foreign Minister Bruno Rodriguez last week said that Havana was open to reviewing the aid proposal. Cuba has been in the throes of a major economic crisis with persistent energy blackouts after the US forcefully seized Venezuela’s then-president Nicolas Maduro and ended the flow of free oil from Caracas in exchange for Cuban medical expertise and other services.

UNITED NATIONS
Forecast for global growth reduced

Responding to Middle East conflicts and rising oil prices, the United Nations on Tuesday lowered its forecast for global economic growth and raised the prospects for inflation this year. UN economists said the global GDP growth is now forecast at 2.5 percent for 2026, down from 2.7 percent in January, and they said it could fall to only 2.1 percent “in a more adverse scenario”. That would be one of the weakest growth rates this century, outside of the COVID-19 pandemic and the global financial crisis of 2008, said Shantanu Mukherjee, director of economic analysis in the UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs. He said life can get harder for billions of people, and some countries may see their economies contract.

AGENCIES—XINHUA

WORLD

Shift in Japan’s military policy raises concern

Moves reveal offensive orientation and undermine peace, experts say

By LIU JIANQIAO
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Although many of Japan's recent military initiatives have been framed as keeping pace with developments in defense equipment and technology, they, in fact, reveal a growing offensive orientation in the country's security strategy, which points to a significant shift in Japan's defense policy that could undermine regional peace and stability, experts said.

Thousands of demonstrators gathered outside Japan's National Diet Building on Tuesday evening to protest against the government's efforts to weaken the country's pacifist constitution through constitutional revision and military expansion policies.

Japanese media reported on Monday that the ruling Liberal Democratic Party had drafted proposals to revise the country's three key national security documents.

The proposals reportedly call for strengthening Japan's air defense systems and sustained combat capabilities, as well as accelerating the deployment of submarines equipped with advanced propulsion systems and capable of carrying long-range missiles to enhance Japan's so-called "counterstrike capabilities".

On April 21, the Japanese government officially revised the "Three Principles on Transfer of Defense Equipment and Technology" and related implementation guidelines to allow the export of weapons, including those with lethal capabilities,

ities, despite waves of large-scale protests, local media reported.

The revision scraps rules that limit Japan's military equipment exports to five noncombat categories, namely rescue, transport, warning, surveillance, and minesweeping.

Instead, military equipment will be divided into "weapons" and "non-weapons" categories, based on whether they have lethal or destructive capabilities, Kyodo News reported.

The revision maintains unrestricted exports of non-weapon equipment, such as warning and control radar systems, while also permitting the export of previously banned weapons, including destroyers and missiles, to countries that have signed agreements with Japan on the protection of classified defense equipment and technological information.

Under the revision, export of weapons will not require prior parliamentary approval. Instead, the National Security Council will make the decisions, with the Diet informed only after approval.

Consequently, a poll released by Kyodo News on Sunday showed that 57.2 percent of respondents opposed allowing exports of lethal weapons, while 37.1 percent supported the move.

In a similar poll conducted by NHK on May 11, 32 percent of the respondents said they were in favor of the move, 53 percent said they were against it, and 15 percent said they were undecided or gave no response.



People protest against the Japanese government's attempts to undermine the pacifist constitution through constitutional revision and military expansion policies in Tokyo, on Tuesday. ZHU CHENXI / CHINA NEWS SERVICE



"These measures are seen as concrete manifestations of the Japanese government's ongoing efforts to accelerate the country's remilitarization process," said Liu Shuliang, an associate researcher at the Tianjin Academy of Social Sciences.

Major step

Japan is actively advancing the development of unmanned systems and automated military infrastructure. From a technical perspective, these efforts are in line with trends in modern warfare and are intended to enhance precision-strike and long-range combat capabilities. Strategically, however, they represent another major step in Japan's accelerated "remilitarization", he said.

"This has long since gone beyond the self-imposed constraints of its

pacifist constitution and the framework of an 'exclusively defense-oriented policy,' Liu said.

In essence, they reflect an attempt to use technological innovation as a vehicle to accelerate the expansion of offensive military capabilities, marking a serious departure from Japan's self-proclaimed identity as a "peace-loving nation" and the defense principles it has long emphasized, he added.

Chen Hong, director of the Asia-Pacific Studies Centre at East China Normal University in Shanghai, said the Japanese government's decision to press ahead with its "remilitarization" process despite significant domestic controversy reflects a fundamental shift in the country's security strategy.

Previous poll results have shown that a majority of the Japanese public supports a pacifist approach. However, despite public opposition, the Japanese government appears determined to continue expanding its military capabilities, a move that could push Japanese society further toward the dangers

of war and conflict, he said.

Experts noted that Japan continues to actively foster "exclusive cliques" and promote bloc confrontation in the region, with arms exports serving as a key instrument in this process.

"The country is trying to make the development of unmanned combat systems a key new pillar in strengthening defense cooperation with countries such as Australia and the Philippines," Chen said.

Japan aims to deepen coordination with these partners, gain greater influence in regional security cooperation, and enhance its own operational capabilities in the Asia-Pacific region, he added.

"This move could have significant implications for the security landscape in the region," Liu said.

Xinhua contributed to this story.



Online
See more by scanning the code.

Cool shower



A zoo worker gives an elephant a refreshing shower to help it cool off on a harsh sunny afternoon at the National Zoological Park in New Delhi on Tuesday. The capital and much of North India are currently witnessing an intense heat wave with temperatures having already crossed 44 C in New Delhi. SANJEEV VERMA VIA GETTY IMAGES

Samsung faces strike after pay talks with union fall apart

SEOUL — The management and union leaders at Samsung Electronics failed to reach a last-minute deal on wages on Wednesday, raising the prospect of a strike at the South Korean electronics giant that could rattle global semiconductor supplies and the country's trade-dependent economy.

Government officials have threatened to invoke rarely used emergency powers to force a settlement at Samsung, where the union representing more than 70,000 workers says the company has failed to offer adequate compensation despite its soaring profits fueled by the global boom in artificial intelligence.

After the latest round of talks ended without a breakthrough on Wednesday, union leader Choi Seung-ho told reporters that unionized workers are set to begin an 18-day strike on Thursday.

Both the union and the management held each other responsible for a failure to reach a deal. Choi accused management of refusing to accept a government-mediated proposal, the details of which he refused to disclose. The management accused the union of calling

for excessive compensation packages for workers at loss-making units.

The two sides said they will continue efforts to reach a deal. The two sides met again on Wednesday afternoon at the arrangement of Labor Minister Kim Young-hoon, according to Kim's ministry.

Samsung and its crosstown rival, SK Hynix, together produce about two-thirds of the world's memory chips, which are seeing surging demand driven by AI. Samsung said its operating profit for the January-March quarter jumped eightfold to a record 57.2 trillion won (\$38 billion).

Union leaders have demanded a compensation structure in which Samsung would commit to spending 15 percent of its annual operating profit on employee bonuses and scrap bonus caps, which are currently set at 50 percent of annual salaries. The company says the demands are excessive, citing the highly cyclical nature of the semiconductor business. The strike is expected to hurt operations of Samsung's production of smartphones and other consumer electronics as well, observers say.

AGENCIES VIA XINHUA

EU avoids tariff threats as it reaches consensus on trade deal with US

By EARLE GALE in London
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The European Union is finally ready to implement the trade deal it struck with the United States almost a year ago, heading off a slew of new tariffs that Washington had threatened to introduce on July 4.

The breakthrough came early on Wednesday, after five hours of talks, when EU lawmakers and member states struck a compromise among factions in the bloc that dislike the deal and factions that feel they can agree on a way forward.

The EU-US trade deal, which was agreed upon by US President Donald Trump and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen in Scotland on July 27, calls for 15 percent import taxes to be levied on most imports into the US from the 27-nation bloc, while a zero percent tariff will be applied to US exports to the EU.

The deal, which many EU lawmakers saw as lopsided, has since sat in the EU Parliament awaiting implementation, while lawmakers haggled over possibly amending it. It was also held up by EU lawmakers protesting against US plans to take control of Greenland.

“Maintaining a stable, predictable, and balanced trans-Atlantic partnership is in the interest of both sides.”

Michael Damianos, minister of energy, commerce and industry in Cyprus

Michael Damianos, minister of energy, commerce and industry in Cyprus, which holds the EU's rotating presidency, said the compromise reached on Wednesday shows the bloc "delivers on its commitments".

"Maintaining a stable, predictable, and balanced trans-Atlantic partnership is in the interest of both sides," he added.

Trump had earlier said that if the trade deal was not ratified by July 4, he would increase tariffs on EU vehicles from 15 percent to 25 percent and also bring in other "much higher" tariffs.

His introduction of tariffs, both real and threatened, especially on aluminum, steel, and

auto parts, has pushed the EU to find new trading partners elsewhere. But the bloc has also been careful not to jeopardize bilateral trade with the US, its largest trading partner, which amounts to around 1.6 trillion euros (\$1.9 trillion) a year.

Bernd Lange, the chair of the parliament's trade committee, helped bridge the gap between the disparate EU factions on Wednesday and said that while the EU will abandon some proposed amendments, "parliament has prevailed with its demands for a comprehensive safety net".

"There is a suspension mechanism if the US does not abide by the deal, a monitoring mechanism for (measuring) the impact on our economy, provisions for unjustified tariffs on certain products, an expiration date for the legislation, and strong involvement of the European Parliament," he said, summarizing the compromise.

Von der Leyen said it means "we will soon deliver on our part", with the EU-US trade deal set to be formally implemented soon.

"Together, we can ensure stable, predictable, balanced, and mutually beneficial trans-Atlantic trade," she added.



Moment of silence

Community members mourn victims killed a day earlier in a shooting at the Islamic Center of San Diego, California, on Tuesday. Police said a pair of gunmen, aged 17 and 18, are suspected of killing three people outside the mosque on Monday and were later found dead in a car from apparent self-inflicted gunshot wounds. Authorities said they are investigating the attack as a possible hate crime.

ZOE MEYERS / AFP

Californian farmers eye stronger China ties

By RENA LI in Los Angeles
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Representatives from California's agriculture and food industries are calling for greater trade stability and stronger bilateral cooperation between China and the United States, saying demand in China for high-quality agricultural and food products remains strong despite trade tensions and shifting global supply chains, with many companies continuing to view the Chinese market as a long-term strategic priority.

Lindsay Tello, senior advisor for trade policy at the Almond Board of California, said California almond exports to China have been affected by tariffs introduced during the trade dispute between the two countries, but Chinese demand for California almonds has remained "important".

"China remains an extremely important market, and we're really proud of our long partnership," Tello told China Daily.

According to Tello, the Almond Board of California has operated in China for more than 30 years and invested over \$75 million in market development and research. She said California almond exports to China previously reached between \$200 million and \$300 million annually before the trade tensions, when China was among the industry's top export markets. By 2025, however, China had fallen from the top-five spot due to rising tariffs and shifting trade flows.

At the same time, Tello noted, overall almond consumption in China has continued to rise, reaching a record 160,000 metric tons last year.

Tello said that California's almond farming community is largely made up of multigenerational family farms that remain committed to long-term cooperation with Chinese partners.

Remaining steadfast

"We continue to remain invested and steadfast in our China engagement," she said, adding that maintaining positive relations with Chinese government agencies, importers, manufacturers and consumers remains a key priority for the industry.

Tello also said tariffs and policy certainty are essential for agricultural trade.

Despite this, Tello said California almonds continue to maintain strong competitiveness because of their quality and reputation in the Chinese market.

California's dairy industry also expressed strong interest in expanding cooperation with China.

Matt Henderson, director of international sales at California Dairies, said the company represents around 300 family-owned dairy farms and produces approximately 7.7 million tons of milk annually, exporting dairy products to more than 50 countries, including China.

Henderson, who lived in Shanghai between 2012 and 2015 and traveled extensively across China, said California Dairies had completed the certifications necessary to begin exporting milk and cream products to China.

"That is going to be an emphasis and an objective of ours here this year and moving forward," he said.

According to Henderson, growing middle-class demand in China for nutrition-focused and value-added products such as butter, cheese and cream presents major opportunities for California exporters. He said Asian markets are increasingly focused on food security, supply chain resilience, sustainability and nutrition.

"We're attempting to export nutrition," Henderson said. "In Asia, that's something they are demanding, and something that we can supply here in California."

Liu Chunxi, senior executive president of Chinese dairy producer Yili Group, said stable and predictable trade policies are essential for sustaining long-term cooperation between Chinese and US dairy companies.

WORLD

Tankers pass strait as truce hopes revive

US and Iran exchange warnings over possible return to war amid fragile calm

By CUI HAIPEI in Dubai, UAE, and JAN YUMUL in Hong Kong

Two Chinese tankers laden with oil passed through the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday, shipping data showed, brightening hopes that the regional conflict may soon be resolved despite the warring sides continuing to trade threats.

US President Donald Trump said on Tuesday the war would be over “very quickly” while Vice-President JD Vance talked up progress in negotiations with Iran about an agreement to end hostilities.

However, Israel’s Kan TV reported that the United States and Israel have completed joint preparations for a possible resumption of military operations against Iran, citing a US security official.

“We’re in a pretty good spot here,” Vance told reporters, hours after Trump said he had come within an hour of ordering fresh strikes and gave Tehran “two or three days” to reach an agreement.

Vance, who negotiated with Iran in failed talks in Pakistan, added that Washington was “locked and loaded” to restart military strikes if no deal is reached.

In response, Iran’s army spokesman Mohammad Akraminia warned that the Islamic republic would “open new fronts against” the US if the White House resumes its attacks. Iran’s Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said the US leadership was “calling a ‘threat’ a ‘chance for peace’”.

Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said early on Wednesday that Iranian forces had been confirmed as the first to down a US F-35 fighter jet, citing a US official report on aircraft combat losses.

“With lessons learned and knowledge we gained, a return to war will feature many more surprises,” he said on social media.

The conflict, which began on Feb 28, has caused the worst disruptions to global energy supplies, blocking hundreds of tankers from leaving the Persian Gulf.

The two Chinese ships — among a handful of supertankers carrying Iraqi crude that have exited the gulf this month — passed through the narrow strait carrying around 4 million barrels of crude, according to data from London Stock Exchange Group and Kpler.

South Korean Foreign Minister Cho Hyun said on Wednesday that a South Korean-operated vessel carrying 2 million barrels of crude oil is also passing through the strait in coordination with Iranian authorities.

Oil prices eased on the positive signals, with the benchmark Brent crude falling to as low as \$110.16 a barrel, before regaining much of its losses.

Trump had indefinitely extended the truce and made clear he wants to exit the war, which has proved to be a political liability with US people paying more at the pump and



Targeting an active educational institution during school hours constitutes a grave violation of international humanitarian law and is a clear war crime.”

Esmail Baghaei, spokesman for Iran’s Foreign Ministry

growing frustrated with the war. The US Senate on Tuesday advanced a war powers resolution to halt the campaign unless Trump obtains congressional authorization. The move represented a distinct challenge to the Republican leader’s executive authority, marking the first time the chamber voted in favor of the measure.

Despite the political significance of the vote, the resolution still needs a majority in the House of Representatives — after which it faces Trump’s presidential veto — to take effect.

School attack update

Meanwhile, the US military again avoided taking responsibility for an attack on a school in Iran that killed about 170 people, mostly schoolchildren, on the first day of the war.

Brad Cooper, commander of US Central Command, told a congressional panel that the probe was “complex”, claiming the school was located on an Iranian cruise missile base.

Hours after, Iran’s Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei described the claim as a “baseless fabrication”.

“Targeting an active educational institution during school hours constitutes a grave violation of international humanitarian law and is a clear war crime,” he said on X.

In another development, Russia joined other United Nations Security Council members on Tuesday to condemn an unclaimed drone strike on the United Arab Emirates’ Barakah Nuclear Power Plant, which Abu Dhabi said originated from Iraq.

The drone struck a generator on Sunday near the Arab world’s first nuclear power plant, triggering a fire but causing no injuries or radiation leaks. The UAE Defense Ministry said on Tuesday its air defense systems had detected six drones from Iraq over the past 48 hours.

Agencies and Xinhua contributed to this story.

Contact the writers at cuihaipei@chinadaily.com.cn

Light after darkness



A Chinese ophthalmologist examines a patient in Bujumbura, Burundi, on Tuesday. Experts from China’s Qinghai province are set to provide free cataract surgeries for about 300 patients as part of a campaign to restore sight. CHINESE MEDICAL TEAM IN BURUNDI VIA XINHUA

Serbian president to visit China to deepen relations

By ZHOU JIN zhoujin@chinadaily.com.cn

Serbia’s President Aleksandar Vucic will pay his first state visit to China starting Sunday, a five-day trip expected to deliver more tangible outcomes in building a community with a shared future for the new era between the two countries.

President Xi Jinping and Premier Li Qiang will meet Vucic separately to exchange views on bilateral relations and regional and international issues of mutual interest, Foreign Ministry

spokesman Guo Jiakun said on Wednesday.

Beijing stands ready to work with Belgrade to take the visit as an opportunity to consolidate ironclad friendship, expand mutually beneficial cooperation, enrich people-to-people and cultural exchanges, and strengthen coordination on multi-lateral affairs, he said.

In an address to the nation on Saturday, Vucic highlighted “the exceptional honor of paying an official state visit to China”, saying that “we expect a great deal from it”, as

reported by Russia’s Tass News Agency.

Serbia, the first European country to agree with China on building a community with a shared future for the new era, is an important partner for China in Southeast Europe, Guo said.

The two presidents have maintained close interactions, he said. Xi paid a state visit to Serbia in May 2024. In September last year, Vucic attended the commemoration of the 80th anniversary of the victory in the Chinese People’s War of Resistance

against Japanese Aggression (1931-45) and the World Anti-Fascist War in Beijing.

Under the leaders’ strategic guidance, China-Serbia relations have been moving forward at a high level in recent years, Guo said.

Earlier this month, a \$1.5 billion contract to build a highway in Serbia was signed by the Serbian government and Shandong Hi-Speed Group.

In 2025, their bilateral trade reached \$6.49 billion, marking a 13 percent year-on-year increase, according to the Foreign Ministry.



Palestinian children prepare to fly kites inscribed with their hopes and dreams in Khan Younis, southern Gaza, on Tuesday, during an event titled “My Sky, My Kite” organized by a local charity. ABED RAHIM KHATIB VIA GETTY IMAGES

Israel intercepts Gaza-bound flotilla, detains over 400

JERUSALEM — Israel said on Tuesday it had intercepted all boats in a Gaza-bound aid flotilla, detaining hundreds of activists and transporting them to Israel.

Organizers of the Global Sumud Flotilla said all boats in their humanitarian convoy were intercepted after Israeli naval vessels surrounded them in international waters, about 250 nautical miles from the coast of Gaza.

Israel began intercepting the ships on Monday morning.

Around midnight on Tuesday, the Israeli Foreign Ministry said all 430 activists “have been transferred to Israeli vessels and are making their way to Israel”, adding that they would be allowed to meet their consular representatives.

Video from the flotilla’s livestream showed Israeli soldiers firing shots at two of the boats. The type of ammunition fired was not clear.

“At no point was live ammunition fired,” the Israeli Foreign Ministry said. “Following multiple warnings, nonlethal means were employed toward the vessels — not toward protesters — as a warning.”

The ministry said Israel would not allow any breach of what it called the “lawful” naval blockade of Gaza. It described the flotilla as “a PR stunt at the service of Hamas”.

Israeli rights group Adalah said on Wednesday that the activists had been “detained at Ashdod port” and “taken into Israel against their will as Adalah attorneys enter for legal consultations”.

The flotilla’s organizers said the activists would be taken to Ketziot prison in Israel’s southern Negev desert.

On Wednesday, Israel’s National Security Minister Itamar Ben-Gvir posted a video on X showing detained activists kneeling with their hands tied behind their backs and foreheads on the ground. The post was captioned “Welcome to Israel”.

Italy’s Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni slammed the treatment of activists as “unacceptable”.

“It is intolerable that these protesters, among whom there are many Italian citizens, are subjected to this treatment, which violates human dignity,” Meloni said, calling for the immediate release of any

detained Italian citizens and demanding an apology from Israel.

The flotilla set sail from Türkiye’s Marmaris coast on May 14 in a third attempt to break the blockade and deliver aid to Palestinians in the war-devastated enclave.

Türkiye and Spain have condemned the interception.

A previous flotilla, comprising about 20 boats and 175 activists, was intercepted by Israeli forces on April 30 near the southern Greek island of Crete.

Two of the activists were detained for days before being released. Dozens of activists said they were mistreated, abused and beaten by Israeli forces.

XINHUA—AGENCIES

Dialogue only right path forward in Mideast: Envoy

By MINLU ZHANG at the United Nations minluzhang@chinadailyusa.com

China’s ambassador to the United Nations briefed the Security Council on Tuesday to voice concerns over the situation in the Middle East and called for joint efforts to restore stability in the region at an early date.

Fu Cong, China’s permanent representative to the UN, made the remarks while commenting on a Sunday drone attack on facilities at the Barakah Nuclear Power Plant in the United Arab Emirates. Although the incident did not cause any casualties or affect radiation safety levels, this “dangerous and irresponsible act” has sounded the alarm for the international community, he said.

China expresses great concern over the incident, opposes armed attacks on nuclear facilities for peaceful purposes, and calls on all parties to abide by international law, including the Convention on Nuclear Safety, and to effectively safeguard the safety and security of nuclear power plants, Fu said.

The sovereignty, security and territorial integrity of countries in the Middle East and the Gulf must be fully respected, and civilians and nonmilitary objects should be protected, he said.

As long as the armed conflict continues, the safety risks it poses to regional nuclear facilities will persist, he said.

The war originated from the illegal military attacks by the United States and Israel against Iran, Fu said. Since its outbreak, the conflict has inflicted severe losses on the people across the region, severely disrupted global economic development and harmed the shared interests of the international community.

“This war should never have happened in the first place. To find an early way to resolve the situation is in the interest of not only the US and Iran, but also regional countries and the rest of the world,” Fu said.

“I wish to make three points,” he said. First, there is a strong call for cessation of hostilities, and any resumption of fighting must be avoided. For some time now, the US and Iran have, on the whole, maintained a ceasefire, but the risk of escalation remains.

“At this critical stage between war and peace, all parties must exercise maximum restraint, uphold the ceasefire arrangements, refrain from irresponsible threatening rhetoric and military adventurism, and make efforts to prevent a relapse into conflict and further escalation of tensions,” he said.

Second, military means offer no



The Barakah Nuclear Power Plant sits in the western desert of the Emirate of Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates. ARUN GIRIJA VIA AP

way out, and dialogue and negotiation are the only right path forward. The recent US-Iran truce and efforts to explore resolving issues through negotiation are welcomed by regional countries and the international community.

Political solution

“China encourages both sides to stay committed to a political solution and to continue settling their differences and disputes through negotiation, including on the nuclear issue, with a view to reaching a solution that accommodates the concerns of all parties,” Fu said.

China commends Pakistan for its mediation efforts and supports all parties in reaching a comprehensive and lasting ceasefire as soon as possible, he added.

Third, priority should be given to

solving pressing issues and preventing the spread of negative effects. “The situation in the Strait of Hormuz is a demonstration of the spillover of the conflict,” Fu said.

“Disruptions to this vital shipping lane have severely affected global supply chains, international trade order and energy security, with countries of the Global South bearing significant livelihood costs,” he said.

China calls for reopening the strait as soon as possible on the basis of a continued ceasefire, Fu said.

Since the outbreak of the conflict, China has been actively working to end hostilities and promote peace, he said. China will continue to work with the international community to play a constructive role in bringing an early end to hostilities and restoring peace and development in the Middle East, he added.

Tech-friendly moves boost China's clout

Pro-growth policies seen enhancing nation's capabilities in key sectors

By JIANG XUEQING
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China is poised to play an even bigger role in the global trade and economic system as its innovation-driven industrial policies strengthen domestic competitiveness and accelerate industrial self-reliance, said an executive of a global credit rating agency.

"The global supply chain is more fragmented but still interconnected, where China plays and continues to play a significant role, particularly and increasingly in some of these higher value-added and strategically important sectors," said Philipp Lotter, managing director and head of global ratings and research at Moody's Ratings, during a recent visit to Hong Kong and the Chinese mainland.

The push is expected to enhance China's capabilities in key strategic sectors, expand its domestic market and reduce vulnerability to external shocks.

Lotter said stability in Sino-US relations is an important factor for global economic and financial resilience.

The New York-based credit rating agency in April affirmed China's A1 sovereign credit rating and changed its outlook to stable from negative.

"What our revision of China's outlook to stable does reflect is that the country's economic and fiscal strength will remain resilient," Lotter said, adding that it also highlights China's policy effectiveness and strong policy coordination capability.

The AI rating takes into account ongoing structural challenges, including periodic supply-demand imbalances and rising public-sector debt, but Moody's expects China to effectively maintain broad economic and financial system stability, he said.

"China will continue to benefit from what is a very large and diversified economy. The economy is increasingly complex and deep. There is a very strong capacity for innovation, and that will help offset some of those structural challenges, such as an aging population and slower growth. The economy is more robust because, unlike past peaks and troughs where growth was driven by sectors that were yielding diminishing returns, the policy emphasis today is on driving high

quality growth," he said.

Moody's views generative artificial intelligence as a structural rather than a cyclical force, given its potential to reshape productivity and economic performance across sectors over time globally.

In China, Lotter said the development of generative AI is supported by three major factors. First, AI has



Philipp Lotter

become firmly embedded in the country's policy agenda, which prioritizes innovation, domestic demand and new growth drivers.

Second, China's vast domestic market enables large-scale deployment and rapid adoption of AI technologies across industries, led in part by major technology companies providing infrastructure, models and applications. Third, the country has built a strong ecosystem anchored by leading tech firms that are accelerating innovation and expanding AI use throughout the broader economy.

"AI is becoming part of the economy and a key driver of China's growth and competitiveness going forward," he said.

Regarding the impact of Middle East tensions on sovereign credit conditions, Lotter said that while China remains partly dependent on energy shipments through the Strait of Hormuz, it also has significant policy and economic buffers to mitigate potential disruptions.

"China has reasonably strong fiscal buffers, and its energy mix is also more diversified. This is where China's multiyear investment in the renewable sector is starting to pay off and provide advantages in this situation. I think on balance, particularly in comparison with the broader Asia region, China has a number of mitigating factors that can help absorb some of the shocks."

Standard Chartered said that unlike most large energy importers, China's exposure to Middle East oil and gas remains manageable, accounting for 6.5 percent of its total energy consumption. Risks are further mitigated by the country's sizable strategic crude reserves of approximately 1.2 billion barrels — equivalent to roughly 108 days of import cover.

Caofeidian Port enters new phase for ore carriers

By GUO YANQI
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The fully loaded 400,000-metric-ton-class ore carrier *Yuan Jian Hai* berthed at Caofeidian Port Area of Tangshan Port in Hebei province on Sunday, marking a new phase in regular full-load berthing for such ultra-large ore vessels at Caofeidian.

Carrying Brazilian iron ore, the vessel sailed through the Laotieshan channel — Caofeidian Port Area of Tangshan Port Deep-water Route (Southern Route) before docking.

The vessel is about 360 meters long and 65 meters wide, featuring a deck area roughly the size of three standard soccer fields and a fully loaded draft of roughly 23 meters, local authorities said.

The route was formally included in China's national coastal public route system in January, removing a key constraint that had previously forced some 400,000-ton ships to reduce cargo before reaching the terminal.

"This is a landmark full-load berthing operation," said Li Wei, chairman of Caofeidian Port Ore Terminal Co under Hebei Port Group Co.

Li said navigation limits had long prevented the port's deep-water terminal capacity from being fully released. Caofeidian Port Area is the only world-class deep-water port in Hebei province and the Bohai Bay area capable of handling 400,000-ton vessels, and is home to the two berths of this class serving the Beijing-Tianjin-Hebei region.

To support the *Yuan Jian Hai*'s arrival and efficient port operations, maritime, customs, border inspection and pilotage authorities



A fully loaded ore carrier berthed at the Caofeidian Port Area of Tangshan Port in Hebei province on Sunday. GUO YANQI / CHINA DAILY

worked together. Once the ship was secured, the operation shifted from navigation to clearance, weighing and unloading.

"We use risk-based inspections for imported iron ore, classifying cargo by factors such as origin, route and vessel," said Gao Jiangong, deputy head of Caofeidian Customs. For medium and low-risk iron ore vessels, the differentiated system has helped cut inspection time from more than 60 hours to within 24 hours, he added.

Customs officers also used drones to read draft marks on the hull, with images sent back to a command center for artificial intel-

ligence-assisted calculations. Compared with traditional manual draft surveys by boat or rope ladder, the method shortens the weighing process by about 1.5 hours per vessel and reduces safety risks, according to Caofeidian Customs.

With regular full-load berthing now supported by the deep-water route, Hebei Port Group is also advancing two major projects to strengthen Caofeidian Port's bulk dry cargo layout and extend its role from ship unloading to storage, processing and onward distribution.

The phase-three ore terminal expansion will extend the quay by

107 meters to 910 meters, allowing two 400,000-ton vessels to berth at the same time, improving handling capacity and operating efficiency.

Behind the terminal, construction of the Caofeidian ore storage and logistics project is also being accelerated to provide more space for ore unloaded from 400,000-ton vessels.

"Once completed, the project will have 3 million tons of static storage capacity. It aims to support ore storage, screening, bonded services, processing and rail-water intermodal transport," said Wu Xiujian, general manager of Tangshan Caofeidian Ore Storage and Transportation Co.

Jolting to action



Staffers from State Grid Hangzhou conduct a check on Zhejiang province's first fishery photovoltaic complementary cluster with a capacity of over 1 million kilowatts, aiming to ensure stable supplies of electricity for local enterprises. As demand for electricity from local firms continues to climb amid rising temperatures, local power staff work to maintain optimal operational status of equipment, eliminating safety hazards and providing them with solid green energy support.

HE CHAOQI / FOR CHINA DAILY

Borouge sees China as hub of innovation

By WANG KEJU
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China is no longer just a super-sized market — it is rapidly transforming into a dynamic innovation hub where global companies come not only to sell, but to create and collaborate, a senior business executive told China Daily.

With its economy projected to expand between 4.5 percent and 5 percent this year, China remains a "massive growth engine" for the world, especially against a backdrop of persistently soft global demand, said Roland Janssen, chief executive officer at Borouge Pte Ltd, now part of the newly established Borouge International — a global petrochemical company with its global headquarters in Vienna, Austria, major operational hubs in Europe, the Middle East and North America, and innovation centers in six countries around the world, including China.

"We are deeply committed to the Chinese market, and I am making sure that our solutions can play a role in the energy, infrastructure, mobility and packaging industries," Janssen said.

In the new energy vehicle sector, where China now leads the way, lightweight and sustainable solutions are increasingly sought after — a trend that, according to Janssen, presents significant opportunities for Borouge International.

"We see growing demand for lightweight plastics, alongside an increasing focus on sustainability, including the use of recycled materials in automotive applications," Janssen said.

To support this trend, Borouge International is collaborating with ROX Motor, a Chinese hybrid carmaker, with its polyolefin solutions applied in 17 components of the Adamas SUV. The two companies have also established a joint innovation laboratory in Shanghai to advance next-generation materials.

"China's electric vehicle market is a global engine for the world. That makes it very attractive for us to be here with our partners and customers, helping them in their development while also learning from it ourselves," Janssen added.

Beyond mobility, Borouge International is also strengthening its pres-

ence in China's energy and infrastructure sectors, which continue to benefit from large-scale investment and the country's energy transition.

"In the past year, we have supported the development of China's wind power sector, particularly as the industry advances toward deep offshore applications," Janssen said.

The company is supporting applications ranging from advanced pipeline systems for urban networks to materials used in offshore wind and electrification projects, helping improve durability, efficiency and sustainability across critical infrastructure in China.

Janssen noted that the speed of innovation in China is remarkable. "Markets evolve more quickly here than anywhere else in the world, creating opportunities to be part of that momentum while also offering valuable learning experiences," he said.

China's fast-growing innovation capacity has gained international recognition. For the first time, the World Intellectual Property Organization ranked the country among the global top 10 in its Global Innovation Index 2025.

The formation of Borouge International in late March — through the combination of Borouge, Borealis and Nova Chemicals — marks a significant step in the company's global strategy. The new entity brings together global scale, advanced technologies and deep application expertise, along with a broad international footprint and enhanced innovation capabilities.

With integrated production assets, a global innovation network and expanded capacity, Borouge International is well positioned to deliver reliable, high-performance material solutions across key sectors, including energy, infrastructure and mobility, while strengthening supply chain resilience and customer collaboration worldwide.

"The idea is to bring the global portfolio to China, work with our industry partners and address the needs of the Chinese market," Janssen said. "At the same time, the reverse is equally important: we learn from the Chinese market, bring those developments back into our organization, and expand into other regions with the technologies and ideas we gain here."

Briefly

Loan prime rates remain unchanged

China's one-year loan prime rate, a market-based benchmark lending rate, came in at 3 percent on Wednesday, the same as the previous month. The over-five-year LPR, on which many lenders base their mortgage rates, also remained unchanged from the previous reading of 3.5 percent, according to the National Interbank Funding Center.

China's power use up 6% in April

China's electricity consumption, a key barometer of economic activity, rose 6 percent year-on-year in April, official data showed. Power use totaled 820.5 billion kilowatt-hours last month, according to the National Energy Administration. A breakdown of the data showed that power consumed by the primary industry rose 2 percent year-on-year to 11.2 billion kilowatt-hours, while power consumed by the secondary industry increased 5.3 percent to 558.4 billion kilowatt-hours.

BUSINESS

Chipmaker YMTC seeks Shanghai float

Listing seen as milestone for nation’s cutting-edge semiconductor sector

By **MASI** in Haikou
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China’s leading flash memory maker, Yangtze Memory Technologies Co (YMTC), has officially begun its initial public offering process with plans to list on Shanghai’s STAR Market, marking a major milestone for the country’s semiconductor industry.

The filing showed that YMTC has no controlling shareholder and features a diversified ownership structure led by State-backed entities. Its largest shareholder, Hubei Changsheng Development — wholly owned by the administrative committee of Wuhan Optics Valley in Hubei province — holds 26.54 percent of the company.

\$44 billion

expected market value of Yangtze Memory Technologies Co for its planned IPO on Shanghai’s STAR Market

Other key investors include phases I and II of the National Integrated Circuit Industry Investment Fund, as well as local State-owned capital and industry funds.

Guosheng Securities said in a research note that YMTC is expected to submit its listing application as early as mid-June, with market forecasts valuing the company at around 300 billion yuan (\$44 billion) for the IPO.

YMTC is China’s only company capable of end-to-end 3D NAND flash chip manufacturing. NAND is a type of high-end nonvolatile memory chip used for data storage in data centers, smartphones and other tech gadgets.

By the third quarter of 2025, YMTC held roughly 13 percent of

the global NAND flash market, securing a top-tier position, the filing citing third-party market research said.

Guosheng Securities said that YMTC launched construction of its third phase base in Wuhan in September. By early 2026, the facility had entered the equipment installation phase for its clean-rooms.

Once the third phase base reaches full production, YMTC’s market share of the global NAND flash sector is expected to exceed 15 percent. The company plans to build two more wafer fabs thereafter, which would double its total production capacity when fully operational, Guosheng Securities said.

Driven by surging demand from artificial intelligence-powered data centers, the company’s revenue exceeded 20 billion yuan in the first quarter, doubling year-on-year.

The IPO plan comes as the rapid development of large AI models and computing infrastructure has ushered in a “supercycle” for the memory chip market.

Market research firm Gartner said global chip sales are expected to approach 9 trillion yuan in 2026, up 64 percent year-on-year, with memory chip sales estimated at around 4.3 trillion yuan.

Roger Sheng, vice-president of research at Gartner, said that YMTC has made significant progress, but there remains a significant capacity gap between Chinese memory leaders and their global counterparts, pointing to substantial room for expansion.

Soochow Securities said in a research note that South Korea’s Samsung and US firm Western Digital each commanded around 410,000 and 400,000 wafers per month in the second quarter of 2025, while YMTC’s monthly capacity stood at only 140,000 wafers.

Finishing touches



Construction workers conduct welding work on joints of the steel space grid structure of Xuanhan South Railway Station on the Xi'an-Chongqing High-speed Railway in Dazhou's Xuanhan county, Sichuan province, on May 14. The integral jacking of the station building's 1,800-metric-ton steel grid, undertaken by China Railway 24th Bureau Group, was successfully completed the same day, marking its full transition to the interior decoration and exterior finishing phase. A key passenger node on the Beijing-Kunming corridor of China's national high-speed railway network, the station will enable the line to further optimize the railway network in central and western China.

PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

State-backed investors eye nation’s top AI startups

By **CHENG YU**
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China’s powerful State-backed investors are piling into the country’s top artificial intelligence startups, turning the efforts over large language models from a venture capital frenzy into a strategic national move over technological self-sufficiency.

Moonshot AI, a leading Beijing-based startup behind the Kimi chatbot, has added a cluster of State-backed funds and government-linked investors to its shareholder roster, sources confirmed to China Daily.

The new investors include State-owned platforms such as Beijing AI Industry Investment Fund and a

State-backed investment fund under Shanghai Guosheng Group, alongside State-owned enterprise telecom giant China Mobile, marking one of the clearest signs yet that China’s “national team” is consolidating around a select group of domestic AI champions.

The move comes as DeepSeek is seeking to raise more than 50 billion yuan (\$7.35 billion) in a financing round that could push its valuation above 350 billion yuan, with China’s State-backed semiconductor investment fund in talks to lead the deal, according to media reports.

“Such investments extend far beyond commercial returns and also the strategic value of technological self-sufficiency,” said Wang Peng, a researcher at the Beijing

Academy of Social Sciences. “State-backed investors are increasingly stepping in not just with capital, but with access to computing power, data resources and industrial ecosystems.”

Wang pointed to DeepSeek’s reported migration onto Huawei’s Ascend AI chips as an example of how capital could help domestic AI firms reduce dependence on foreign hardware and software stacks.

On the other hand, Moonshot AI’s latest funding round is being led by the venture arm of food delivery giant Meituan.

Since the beginning of 2026, the company has raised more than \$3.9 billion in total, making it one of China’s fastest-rising AI startups by valuation.

Prior to the latest round, Moonshot AI’s shareholder roster already included Chinese internet giants such as Alibaba and Tencent, social media platform Xiaohongshu, as well as major venture capital firms.

China Mobile’s involvement is drawing particular attention among investors and industry experts because of the State-owned telecom operator’s massive cloud infrastructure and nationwide distribution network.

“Cooperation between the two companies could eventually embed Kimi’s AI agent capabilities into telecom services, giving Moonshot AI access to hundreds of millions of users while securing more stable computing resources,” Wang said.

Smart tech reshaping hiring trends, workplace dynamics

By **LI JIAYING**
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The accelerating adoption of artificial intelligence is increasingly reshaping hiring trends and workplace dynamics, as companies race to recruit AI talent while workers scramble to adapt to the technology’s growing influence, a recent report showed.

According to a 2026 spring recruitment report released by recruitment platform Maimai this month, job postings in China’s new economy sectors rose 22.6 percent year-on-year in the first four months, while AI-related positions surged 8.7-fold during the same period.

The new economy sector refers to industries driven by technologies such as the internet, big data, cloud computing and AI, which give rise to new products, business models and formats.

The rapid rise of AI also drives broader changes in China’s labor market, with more than 20 of the 72

new occupations identified over the past five years being directly related to AI, data from the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security showed in March.

Against this backdrop, competition for AI talent has intensified across the country’s technology sector as companies speed up AI deployment.

“Demand for AI application talent is definitely set to surge,” said Lin Fan, founder and CEO of Maimai. “We have seen that it is no longer just major technology companies and large-model developers competing for talent. Firms in embodied AI, smart hardware and intelligent driving have also joined the race.”

In this regard, the report also showed that the competition for talent has gone beyond established tech giants to rising players. Companies such as ByteDance, DJI, Xiaohongshu, Tencent and Meituan remained among the hottest recruiters this spring, while AI startups such as MiniMax and

smart appliance company Dreame Technology also entered the top 20 most active recruiters.

High-end AI positions are also commanding significantly higher salaries. AI scientists and AI leadership roles topped the salary rankings with an average monthly salary of 132,796 yuan (\$19,521), becoming the only category exceeding 100,000 yuan per month. Other high-paying roles included AI infrastructure engineers, large-model algorithm researchers and AIGC (AI-generated content) algorithm engineers, the report showed.

By contrast, programmers are among the first groups feeling the pressure brought by AI-driven development. According to the report, 38.51 percent of surveyed programmers said their companies have incorporated AI capabilities into performance evaluations, with 54 percent having already experienced workforce adjustments at their companies in the past year. In response, 39.1 percent chose to stay

in their current positions and improve their skills, while 25.7 percent planned to move into AI development roles.

“The proportion of AI-assisted coding in my work has reached 90 percent, or even higher,” said Chen Feng, a backend engineer at a major tech company, adding that he has felt the shift becoming particularly evident since the beginning of this year.

“In this sense, the ability to come up with ideas has become especially important,” Chen said. “As AI continues to evolve, what the industry really needs are people who know how to effectively work with AI.”

Despite the hiring boom, however, competition for jobs has eased somewhat overall. The Maimai report showed that the talent supply-demand ratio in the new economy sector fell from 2.45 to 2.09, meaning that roughly two candidates compete for one position. Meanwhile, average monthly salaries rose 12.13 percent year-on-year to 49,600 yuan.

Riding AI boom, NW China emerges as key computing hub

URUMQI — A new kind of hub is emerging in the landscape of energy-rich Northwest China. Instead of oil derricks, these centers are filled with rows of server racks.

Inside a 200-square-meter room at the Tianshan Smart Valley Advanced Computing Cluster in Hami, Xinjiang Uygur autonomous region, hundreds of servers hum day and night. In just over a year, the likes of telecom giants, cloud computing service providers and tech firms have moved into the city.

“Since March, we have had companies visiting almost every day for talks,” said Paruq Yehya, head of a local digital development bureau. “Three clients are vying for one server company’s computing power.”

Artificial intelligence’s soaring power demand has made Xinjiang and neighboring provinces such as Gansu attractive destinations for AI firms.

With abundant solar and wind reserves, Xinjiang offers green power at roughly one-third the price of coastal industrial electricity. Operating costs for a computing company in Hami are more than 40 percent lower than in the eastern regions of China. In Qingyang, Gansu, one of the northwestern region’s flagship computing hubs, a branch of telecom giant China Mobile has revealed that monthly savings can reach 4 million yuan (\$585,000).

The region’s cooler climate and cheaper land add to the appeal, lowering air-conditioning and operational costs below those of first-tier eastern cities.

For these computing centers, the core mission is to convert green power into computing power, via AI training and reasoning, resulting in tokens, the smallest unit of information processing in AI models.

“Just as oil is the lifeblood of industry, tokens are the most fundamental fuel for AI development,” said Tang Shuheng, head of the Xinjiang International Integrated Supercomputing Center.

Major AI models based in eastern cities process reasoning requests on servers located in the northwest. Some of these requests serve overseas businesses in North America, Europe and the Asia-Pacific. The clients of these AI model providers pay for token consumption, and the resulting revenue covers electricity, wages and equipment costs. In this way, token flows contribute directly to the local economy.

In Qingyang, more than 500 AI-related firms had been set up by 2025, generating \$1.28 billion in revenue and creating job opportunities, local authorities said.

In 2026, the concept of “comput-

ing power and electricity synergy” made its debut in China’s Government Work Report, and earlier this month, several departments released an action plan, setting a 2030 goal to significantly improve clean energy supply security for AI computing facilities and AI applications in the energy sector.

Northwestern regions are also a testing ground for domestic chips. Huawei and other homegrown AI chips are now deployed at scale. At a computing center in Qingyang, a massive Enflame cluster successfully handled a peak-season surge of billions of image requests for photo-editing app Meitu’s AI virtual try-on during the 2026 Chinese New Year holiday in February.

More than China’s energy backyard, the northwest has become an AI hub, with its computing power being exported westward.

Many Central Asian countries lack large-scale computing facilities but face urgent data processing demand in sectors such as satellite remote sensing, agriculture and energy infrastructure inspection. The computing power center in Xinjiang will function as a “digital post station” — satellite data arrives via dedicated links and reaches customers in tailor-made services after being processed by AI models.

Tang, the Xinjiang computing center’s head, said the facility will enable high-precision monitoring of the China-Kazakhstan oil pipelines and cut the warning time to 15 minutes should pipeline deformations, even tiny, occur. Meanwhile, a satellite-linked AI crop farming system, supported by the Xinjiang center, is expected to help boost wheat yields and cut fertilizer use in Kazakhstan.

However, not all workloads can move west. Web access, e-commerce and online gaming, which demand extremely low latency, have to stay in the east.

From Hami to Chongqing in Southwest China, network latency is about 50 milliseconds, exceeding the 30-millisecond threshold for real-time uses like autonomous driving and telemedicine. In addition, information infrastructure in Hami still lags behind coastal regions, while talent is scarce.

“Right now it is something like machines ‘waiting for’ people,” Paruq Yehya said, adding that equipment has arrived, but staff with expertise in tech, operations and the market are not in place. Rapid construction of large-scale computing centers also strains local equipment supply chains and logistics.

Still, the future looks promising. A Morgan Stanley report earlier this year predicted that data centers in China’s far-flung regions will contribute 2.4 gigawatts of new orders in 2026, further increasing to 3.3 GW in 2027, accounting for about 70 percent of new orders.

BUSINESSFOCUS

Smart robotics driving rehab breakthroughs

Pursuit of comprehensive solutions boosting global demand for Chinese robot applications

By WANG XIN in Shanghai wangxin2@chinadaily.com.cn

With China firmly at the forefront of artificial intelligence and robotics, the nation's technology companies are targeting opportunities in the global rehabilitation sector as advances in Chinese robotics gain increasing recognition worldwide, experts and business executives said at a recent summit.

The Global Rehabilitation & Assistive Technology Network Summit 2026 convened in Shanghai on May 13, offering a platform to showcase real-world application scenarios of breakthrough technologies. AI and robotics are rapidly advancing to make a difference with great potential in the rehabilitation sector.

Robert Riener, full professor for sensory-motor systems at ETH Zurich, pointed out that the application of such advanced technologies is playing a vital role in areas with large incidences and high numbers of new cases where rehabilitation is needed.

"Now we have large neural networks based on large databases and deep structures with more computational power, which give us huge potential (in the rehab sector). We also have a lot of data about patients that enable us to monitor their physiological data, social behavior, and sleep wake rhythms. Using AI, the data can help predict certain symptoms or diseases," he said.

He especially highlighted strokes, as they show one of the highest numbers of cases each year, making patients suffer

from hemiplegia and other problems. Many Chinese robotics are used for stroke therapy and neurorehabilitation, such as rehab robots, exoskeletons and intelligent systems from Chinese robotics company Fourier.

Founded in 2015, Fourier has evolved from exoskeleton robots into a diverse portfolio of humanoid robots and intelligent rehabilitation systems. As an industry-leading proactive AI robotics company dedicated to enriching human life through full-stack robotic technologies, the company's products are serving over 2,000 institutions across 40 countries, including hospitals, communities, manufacturing and everyday environments.

Owen Teoh, managing director of Fourier rehab international division, has been working in the rehabilitation robots sector for over 15 years. He shared that in the past two years, the company has seen rapidly growing demand in its overseas markets including Europe, North America and Southeast Asia. Last year, its sales doubled compared to 2024.

"The popularity of Chinese robotics represents the rise of China's high-end manufacturing. What I have observed is that the overseas market's recognition of Chinese robotics is rapidly growing. The need for rehabilitation robots is clear, and overseas acceptance of Chinese rehabilitation robots is among the highest in the industry," said Teoh.

The development trend is shifting from single products to comprehensive solutions, from passive execution to active



A Fourier employee demonstrates a brain-computer interface combined with a lower-limb exoskeleton robot in Shanghai on May 13. PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

40 countries

served by Fourier's products including hospitals, communities, manufacturing and everyday environments

embodied intelligence, and from hospital settings to widespread access in community and home environments, he added.

Behind the growing demand for rehab robots, Teoh saw several key drivers, including the continuous demand spurred by global aging and rehabilitation, and the increasing application of robotics in clinical rehabilitation settings. With technological exploration made in 2025 such as embodied intelligence and rehabilitation training integration, the application of embodied intelligence technology in the health and wellness sector

began to garner wider attention.

"In the rehab sector, I think that the game changing thing will come when we are able to embody intelligence in the robotics system," said Professor Jose Luis Pons, who leads a research team at Shirley Ryan AbilityLab to apply the most advanced methods for measuring and restoring lower-limb function in diverse patient populations.

He indicated that it doesn't mean building an autonomous intelligent entity or agent to interact with patients or with clinicians. Instead, it requires understanding basic principles of rehabilitation, and then to synthesize those principles by using AI techniques in robotics, so they become more intelligent but have collaborative technologies with a human expert.

"Our robots are often evaluated as a 'warm-hearted' robot. In terms of application and interaction with patients, we are

better attached to the needs of both patients and therapists," Teoh said.

He further explained that, for example, when it comes to human-robot interaction, traditional robots tend to rely heavily on repetitive movements, but Fourier's game design and user experience are tailored more closely to actual needs. Additionally, featuring the company's force feedback technologies, the robot can sense the patient's muscle strength and provide corresponding assistance. This is perceived as a more human-like interaction, making it easier for them to use.

"China is among the world's leaders in robotics and its intelligent applications possess a technological foresight that other countries and regions lack ... In addition to hospitals and communities, we hope our robotics can reach households in need, to help improve their quality of life," Teoh added.

By TANG ZHIHAO tangzhihao@chinadaily.com.cn

Daiichi Sankyo, a Japan-based innovative global pharmaceutical company, said it has made significant strides in expanding indications for an antibody-drug conjugate (ADC) for cancer treatment in China. Leveraging its advanced DXd ADC technology platform and favorable government policies, the company will further deepen its presence in China, aiming to become a leading cancer treatment provider, thus contributing to the Healthy China 2030 initiative.

According to Michio Hayashi, president of Daiichi Sankyo China, since its launch in China three years ago, the T-DXd has been approved for seven indications across three major cancers at an accelerated pace. The latest approval for early-stage breast cancer at the end of March made China the first country globally to have this indication. Another TROP2 ADC drug has now officially had its commercial launch in China, offering a new treatment option for more breast cancer patients.

"We have established a portfolio characterized by one drug for multiple cancer types in the country. This approach may not only meet China's critical oncology needs but also lay a robust clinical and commercial foundation for expanding into additional cancer types in the future," said Hayashi.

Keys to success

Daiichi Sankyo has recently emerged as an oncology player. Its designed ADC technology platform and premium business environment in China are two main factors that have helped it stand out in the market over the past three years, according to Hayashi.

"Our DXd ADC technology platform represents the culmination of extensive, long-term research and development efforts by our global research centers. The core of this innovation lies in the unique combination of a specialized linker and payload. Historically, a major challenge with ADCs was that the antibody and payload would often decouple before reaching tumor cells, causing the drug to dissipate



Daiichi Sankyo's factory in ZJ Science City, Shanghai. PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

New approvals and faster regulatory pathways support Daiichi Sankyo's oncology expansion in China



Michio Hayashi, president of Daiichi Sankyo China

prematurely and lead to serious side effects. Our scientists have designed a mechanism that can hold the payload until it reaches the target cell," he said, adding that the innovation-friendly environment in China has become another key factor.

"The 'Healthy China 2030' initiative has established clear objectives for enhancing healthcare quality and fostering innovation among industry stakeholders. To support this, the Chinese government has introduced numerous regulations that streamline clinical trials and regulatory approvals, encouraging pharmaceutical companies to prioritize new drug development in China," said Hayashi. "Historically, there was a significant gap — often five years or more — between regulatory approvals in the United

States and China. Today, we are seeing approvals in China occurring almost simultaneously with those in the US and, in some instances, even faster. For Daiichi Sankyo, we have benefited significantly from these regulatory improvements."

A market leader

Daiichi Sankyo, with more than 20 years of operations in China, said it has set a clear development goal to address the country's unmet medical needs over the next five years.

"Our ambition is to become a global top five oncology company by 2035 and establish a very strong position in the breast and lung cancer fields," said Hayashi. "With our robust portfolio, we are confident in delivering new treatment

options for more patients."

In September 2025, Daiichi Sankyo began construction of a new ADC manufacturing facility in Shanghai's Pudong New Area, with a total investment of approximately 1.1 billion yuan (\$160 million). The project, designed to include manufacturing facilities, R&D laboratories and quality control centers, is expected to begin operation by 2030. "Our global group has designated China as one of the key markets, meaning it is a top priority for investment. This commitment is reflected in our ongoing participation in global clinical trials and our decision to invest in the new drug manufacturing plant in Shanghai," said Hayashi.

China, known for its rapidly growing biotech sector, a vast com-

munity of highly capable scientists and a significant volume of quality scientific papers, is viewed as a destination with capabilities that extend beyond production in Daiichi Sankyo's global map, he added.

"We have just launched our new five-year business plan this May. In China, one of our core strategies is to enhance a business development function," said Hayashi. "Our ultimate goal is to generate new products in China for the global market."

Patient-centric approach

While accelerating the clinical translation of innovative medicines, Daiichi Sankyo China has been committed to empowering patients and local physicians. Last year, the company supported the "Speak Up for HER" breast cancer patient education and care campaign hosted by the Beijing Love Book Cancer Foundation. Focusing on the unmet needs of breast cancer patients, especially those with HER2-low expression, the initiative adopted diverse activities to enhance patients' health literacy and facilitate communication between patients and healthcare providers. The campaign is set to roll out in multiple cities nationwide this year.

Additionally, scholarship programs and initiatives to support the training of young physicians have been established to strengthen the oncology workforce, laying a solid foundation for the sustainable advancement of cancer prevention and treatment in China, according to the company.

"Recognized as a premier leader in the field, we will be positioned to pursue more strategic growth in China. This includes expanding partnerships, advancing our local R&D, and strengthening our support for key physicians and healthcare professionals at major hospitals," said Hayashi. "This creates a positive cycle where high performance leads to greater market recognition and support, which in turn accelerates our business growth within the oncology sector."

The information contained is for reference of healthcare professionals only and does not intend to substitute professional medical advice or recommendation.

LIFE

The drive from Southwest China's Sichuan province's Mabian county seat to Baixiang village is a test of one's limit for car sickness, full of sharp turns that wind upward for 11 kilometers. But roll the car windows down and everything is worth it: the sweet air permeated by the terraced tea bushes following the mountain's contours like the whorls of a giant fingerprint.

Before you lies 1,600 *mu* (107 hectares) of contiguous tea gardens, cascading down from 1,100 to 1,400 meters. Tea pickers dot the hillside, bamboo baskets on their backs, hands fluttering across the leafy surface to pinch off the most prized early spring buds in late March.

"Our tea garden sits at a high altitude, so the tea is just starting to sprout," says He Yingjun, who presides over the sprawling plantation. "With the big temperature swing between day and night, the tea accumulates more beneficial compounds. The secret to good Mabian tea is right here," he says as he pinches a plump bud.

Four decades ago, this was a barren hillside without so much as a path. Then his father began planting. Today, it has become a calling card for the tea industry in the Mabian Yi autonomous county, and a lifeline for the people who live here.

His father did not start from nothing. Historical accounts show tea has been grown on these mountains for almost 2,000 years, since the Han Dynasty (206 BC-AD 220). Nestled in the Xiaoliangshan Mountains, home to the Yi ethnic group, Mabian was a key node on the ancient tea-horse route, where people of the Yi and Han ethnic groups lived side by side, trading tea for horses.

In the early 1980s, as China's reform and opening-up gained momentum and market demand for tea outweighed supply, He's father contracted a 70-*mu* collective tea garden in his hometown. He spent more than a decade learning from local tea masters.

They traveled far and wide together, even going to the provincial capital Chengdu to meet clients from abroad, He says.

"His mentor treated him well and took him everywhere," He adds. When the tea master passed away in the 1990s, his father inherited both his mentor's business connections and approach to tea cultivation.

The family's full commitment to tea came in 2006, when He's father set his sights on the barren hillside in Baixiang village.

"There was nothing — no road, no electricity, just wasteland," He recalls. The choice was simple, because it was only 11 km from the county seat, meeting the "half-hour rule" for tea processing. Fresh leaves must reach the factory within 30 minutes after picking. If they sit longer, they begin to heat up and ferment in unwanted ways, turning the bright green leaves dull and muddying the flavor, He explains.

"You then lose the freshness. Once that happens, no amount of skill or processing in the factory can bring it back," he adds.

When He was discharged from military service in 2008, he returned to Mabian. "My father was getting older, and someone



Mountains teeming with tea

A county in Southwest China is boosting economy and the beverage's industry, leading to innovation and tourism opportunities, Yang Feiyue reports in Mabian, Sichuan.

had to carry on," he says.

He now manages the tea plantation and production. His father, with a knack for distinguishing Mabian tea from any other, oversees quality. Over the years, the family has witnessed the transformation of Mabian tea from backyard production to modern plantations.

Today, their family business employs 30 to 40 people year-round. During peak harvest, they have 400 to 500 pickers, and pay over 2 million yuan (\$294,286) in wages annually.

In 2020, Mabian was designated "the home of Yi tea" by the China International Tea Culture Institute, and the Yi tea brand was formally established.

Five incomes, one leaf

In Mabian, growing tea pays dividends in more ways than one.

Li Min, a local official with rural affairs, points out that a farming family can earn five separate incomes from working on a tea plantation —



Top: A tea-picking celebration is staged at a tea plantation in Baixiang village of Sichuan province's Mabian county in late March. **Above:** Tea workers pick off fresh tea leaves at Xiangyang tea garden in Mabian. **Below:** The tiered tea plantation landscape and neighboring spring flowers form a picture at Mabian, attracting visitors from far and wide. PHOTOS BY HE WEI / FOR CHINA DAILY

renting land, selling fresh leaves, wages from labor-intensive work, collective village dividends, and tourism spillover from neighborhood homestays, where tourists buy directly from farmers and some villagers find work.

"A family of four, including grandparents in their 60s and 70s, can pick tea and earn 800 or 900 yuan a day," He says. "That's better than leaving town to work, and they can look after the children and pick them up from school."

Across the county, about 80,000 people are directly or indirectly employed in the tea industry, with per capita fresh-leaf income of about 6,000 yuan, according to local authorities.

"One leaf enriches one people," says Like Haomao, deputy head of Mabian, adding that the tea industry truly plays a leading role in increasing farmers' income.

However, the major bottleneck constraining local tea development is the lack of market recognition.



Chinese humanoid robots ready to work in Central, Eastern Europe

WARSAW — The steady hum of robotic arms filled the exhibition hall as automated welding machines from FAIRINO operated with precise movements. Nearby, visitors gathered around a humanoid robot made by Unitree Robotics, taking photos as it greeted them with animated gestures.

Many of the robots attracting visitors are made by these Chinese firms and others participating in the International Trade Fair for Industrial Automation and Robotics held in Warsaw in mid-May.

At the booth of Polish company Positive Machines, logistics robots moved smoothly between simulated warehouse shelves, demonstrating cargo handling and transport functions. Product manager Michal Zdrada says his company primarily purchases logistics and transportation robots from China and has sold more than 500 units to date.

According to him, Chinese-made robots stand out for their cost-effectiveness, with comparable products from Poland or Germany often priced three to four times higher.

Also opting for Chinese-made robotics products, Polish company ELTRON showcased industrial



Left: A drone photo taken on May 2 shows robots performing at a park during the May Day holiday in Wuzhou city, Guangxi Zhuang autonomous region. **Right:** An intelligent traffic management robot makes a "heart" gesture for pedestrians at an intersection in Hangzhou, Zhejiang province, on May 11. PHOTOS BY HE HUAWEN AND HUANG ZONGZHI / XINHUA

robotic arms produced by FAIRINO. The machines are used for tasks such as welding, laser marking, and industrial safety inspection.

ELTRON's regional sales manager, Jacek Slusarek, says the company chose the Chinese brand for its competitive pricing and reliable quality. He says the robotic arms have already received positive feedback after entering the market, prompting continued cooperation.

A large share of exhibitors at the fair are using Chinese robotic products. Among them, the Polish company Tech4Business showcased China-made floor-cleaning, food-delivery and humanoid robots, attracting crowds of visitors. Project manager Piotr Kozynacki says the company's founding team has spent nearly 15 years working in cleaning services before establishing Tech4Business last year.



After extensive market research and supplier screening, the company selected Chinese brands including AgiBot, KEENON Robotics and Lens Technology. "These were simply the best solutions we found," Kozynacki says.

He notes Chinese manufacturers often adopt suggestions and customize products based on local customers' feedback. "That is something we are very satisfied with

when working with Chinese companies," he says.

According to Tech4Business, given China's rapid development in the robotics industry, the company is seeking cooperation with more Chinese robotics suppliers, while European firms are competing to become distributors of Chinese robotics brands.

The appeal of and faith in Chinese automation technology has

"Our tea output in Sichuan is very high, but our brands are not much," He says bluntly, adding that a large part of Mabian tea is sold as raw material or processed leaves to brand owners in other provinces.

Additionally, the underutilization of summer-autumn tea has traditionally been the county's weak spot. After the spring harvest, many gardens are left fallow.

Summer heat speeds up the tea plant's growth, producing leaves that are larger, tougher and higher in bitter compounds, He explains.

The resulting tea is more astringent and fetches lower prices, making it hardly worth the labor to pick, he adds.

Breaking new ground

Local officials say the county is now tackling the problem head-on and has been exploring new avenues in recent years.

"We've brought in a company from Hubei province to produce matcha, and we're collaborating with Anhui Agricultural University to develop mellow yellow tea, constantly innovating summer-autumn tea processing," Like Haomao says.

He Yingjun is also experimenting. On part of his plantation, shade nets have been installed to produce the raw material for matcha.

"We signed a contract with a major tea company, producing tea to their standards. If summer-autumn tea is done right, it could account for half our income," he anticipates.

He has already seen summer-autumn tea prices rising. New processing techniques have opened new markets hungry for the raw material to make novel tea drinks or functional extracts.

Beyond the product innovation conducted by tea planters like He, Mabian is also pushing tea tourism.

Kashasha Homestay is the flagship project, consisting of 10 Yi-style courtyards scattered across the tea hills of Fulai village, about an hour's drive from He's tea plantation.

Open the window, and you look out over a sea of clouds and tea fields. The only sounds are the wind and the birds. Rooms are not cheap, but during peak season, they are hard to come by.

"Kashasha Homestay relies entirely on the tea gardens. Without the tea gardens, that place would be barren. There wouldn't be much to see," Like Haomao says.

In 2025, the county's tea-tourism integration project attracted about 45,000 visitors and generated 32 million yuan in revenue, according to local authorities.

Standing in the Baixiang village tea garden, He Yingjun points to a construction site in the distance.

"That's our new factory. Once it's completed, we won't sell any fresh leaves. We'll process everything ourselves and pay taxes here," he says.

The new factory will give him control over the entire process, from fresh leaf to finished product. It will also allow him to experiment with new processing methods without relying on outside facilities. Whether that solves the brand problem, he does not know.

"You do it because you're in it, and you can't just stop," he says.

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LIFE

What animals are comparatively less featured in animated shows yet still possess facial traits that make them slightly resemble humans?

This question, which might seem strange to most people, was once a central concern for director Yu Shui during the early development of *Nobody*, an animated blockbuster that grossed over 1.7 billion yuan (\$250 million) last summer.

Loosely inspired by the Ming Dynasty (1368-1644) novel *Journey to the West*, the movie is a spin-off of one of the most popular standalone episodes of *Yao — Chinese Folktales*, a series that proved to be a phenomenal hit in 2023. Portraying a little pig monster who dares to dream big despite harsh realities, the tale stirred widespread resonance among urban dwellers. Yu served as director of both the episode and the film.

Recalling being approached in 2021 to develop the story's concept, Yu, who describes himself as an animation fan since childhood, began searching through his memories of Chinese mythology for inspiration. "One day, I suddenly thought: the monsters in *Journey to the West* are very interesting and diverse," he tells China Daily following a forum at the 16th Beijing International Film Festival.

Emotional resonance

Comprising 100 chapters, the literary masterpiece follows the pilgrimage of the Buddhist monk Tang Sanzang (also known as Xuanzang), escorted by three powerful disciples — including the famous hero, Monkey King — as they resist various monsters. Most of these creatures yearn to eat the monk in pursuit of immortality during their treacherous journey to acquire Buddhist scriptures.

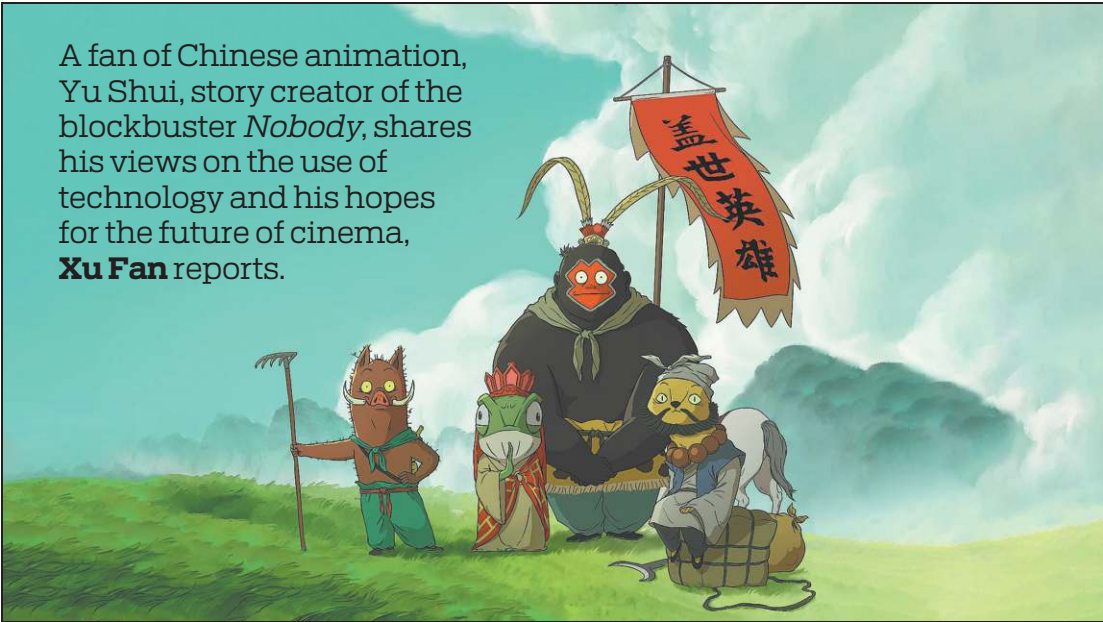
The film's plotline unfolds as a farce: the low-level pig monster attempts to escape from his oppressive boss and assembles a team to disguise themselves as a monk and his disciples, heading west with the intention of taking credit for the pilgrimage.

Yu drafted a set of selection rules. These monster protagonists, he decided, should be inspired by less popular animals and should not be modern-day favored pets like cats or dogs. More importantly, their very appearances should carry a sense of defeat — something overlooked and even a bit subdued. Their faces also needed to represent a certain type of person: ordinary and conflicted, suspended between aspiration and resignation.

Selecting from a pool of dozens of candidates, the director and his fellow creators pitched four — a pig, a gorilla, a weasel, and a toad — gathering more than 600 animators that spent four years producing over 1,800 shots for the film, featuring ink-water animation as a tribute to the Shanghai Animation Film Studio, the pioneer of Chinese animation.

Sound director Zhang Jinyan then tailored each monster's voice to match its traits: the ambitious pig's naive yet firm tone; the toad's high-pitched, flat timbre; the weasel's rapid-fire, density-shifting delivery that provides a comedic effect; and the gorilla's slow, stuttering deep voice, which "sets up his later roars as signs of emotional growth".

Beyond visual craftsmanship, the story carries a deeply relatable emotional core. One of the most touching plotlines features the little pig monster's yearning to escape Langlang Mountain, the fictional place where he



A fan of Chinese animation, Yu Shui, story creator of the blockbuster *Nobody*, shares his views on the use of technology and his hopes for the future of cinema, Xu Fan reports.

Film director still finds inspiration in digital era



From top: Scenes from the animated blockbuster *Nobody*, which recount how a low-level pig monster attempts to escape from his oppressive boss and assembles a team to disguise themselves as the Buddhist monk Xuanzang and his three powerful disciples, heading west with the intention of taking credit for a pilgrimage to acquire Buddhist scriptures. Above: Director Yu Shui attends a forum at the 16th Beijing International Film Festival in April. PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY



resides and works. Yu, also a professor at the School of New Media Art and Design at Beihang University, explains that the mountain contains a metaphor that resonates with everyone.

"Each of us has an environment that we wish to escape. It could be a boring, stressful workplace or an exhausting, suffocating family. Langlang Mountain represents the life predicament we are all trying to escape," says Yu.

The impact of AI

While the film's themes address personal struggles, a larger question looms over the industry. In a rapidly evolving digital era, a persistent question shadows cinema: can the medium, long regarded as the "seventh art" for its reliance on human creativity, withstand the unprecedented challenge posed by artificial intelligence?

For Yu, the answer lies in preserving a precious legacy of cinema: making commercially viable works that still carry the imprint of their creators. His view echoes a long tradition. Over the medium's 131-year history, some of its most enduring works have balanced technological innovation with personal vision. James Cameron, for instance, combines cutting-edge effects with reflections on humanity and nature in the *Avatar* series, while Ridley Scott is known for crafting visually arresting worlds in films like *Alien* and *Blade Runner*.

Yet the tension between technology and artistry has taken on new urgency. As AI tools become increasingly sophisticated, they are already reshaping parts of the filmmaking process — from subtitle translation to the digital creation of on-screen faces — raising concerns about the future of traditional roles within the industry.

It is against this backdrop that Yu shares his perspective: "To make a film possessing the distinctive temperament of its auteur is still a rarity in the market. Filmmakers can use distinctiveness to confront AI, and distinctiveness is probably the sole 'weapon' to win."

But challenges for cinema extend beyond AI. In 2025, China's micro-drama market reached 67.79 billion yuan, with monthly production exceeding 3,000 titles. By comparison, the country's total box office revenue for the same year stood at 51.8 billion yuan — meaning micro-dramas have already overtaken traditional feature-length films as a main driving force in China's digital cultural consumption.

Despite these shifts, Yu remains optimistic. He believes cinema will exist forever. "Real life is becoming busier," he explains. "The expansion of the internet has made most people live in their own small worlds. Artistic creation is also becoming lonelier, because with the help of AI, work that once required a team can now be done by one person."

But cinema, Yu argues, offers something irreplaceable. "Cinema is a place where people still gather together, providing a sense of social connection," he says, reflecting on the enduring value of the shared moviegoing experience. "Sitting in the dark and watching a film with others reminds you that you are still surrounded by people."

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Online
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Paintings evoke a silent blue symphony of people lost in memory

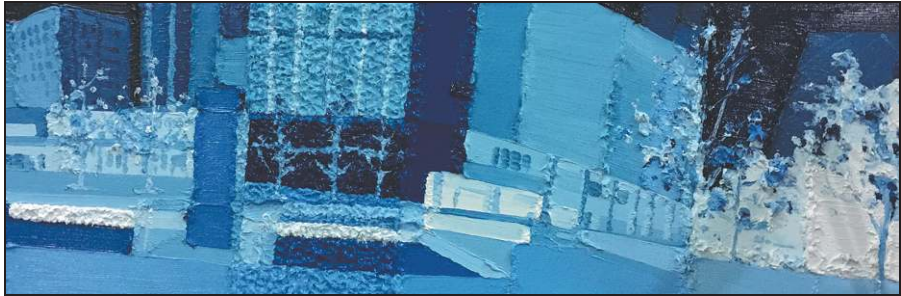
By LIN QI
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When one's time is inevitably overloaded with images and clamorous expressions, the oil paintings of Liu Kun, born in 1968, offer rare restraint and a still moment of meditative reflection.

From his earlier depictions of urban landscapes and vegetables to his latest use of blue as the dominant color in his works, what Liu cares about is not the physical forms of his subjects but the mental state of people lost in memory.

Blues / Big Blue, Liu's ongoing exhibition at Beijing's Today Art Museum, which runs through May 25, illuminates blue as an essential element in the artist's recent oil paintings. The moment they step into the museum, audiences are immersed in a calm yet nostalgic world created by shades of blue, from dark to light, that jump from the canvas to orchestrate a silent symphony.

In the world of painting, blue is "a vast and ambiguous territory", Liu



says, referring to a variety of gradual hues — lake blue, cobalt blue, Prussian blue, and indigo. He adds that each shade is different from the other and, in his works, the varied combinations of blue "mirror the vagueness of the world".

A captivating group of works on show is themed on *Yanjing Bajing*, or the eight sceneries of old Beijing, in which Liu, a native of the capital city, rendered this phrase invented centuries ago with

modern sensibilities laced with individual memories.

The first piece from which he began this collection is *Peacock Blue — Sunset Glow at the Golden Terrace*, named after Jintai Xizhao, one of the eight sceneries.

Jintai is the name of a main road in today's bustling CBD area, where he grew up nearby.

The accumulation of colors gives forms to the roads, trees and towering buildings that today

define the skyline of one of Beijing's busiest commercial areas. It assumes an effect of ambiguity as if the subjects were showered with rain, which Liu says indicates his state when lost in childhood memories of the area where the landscapes have been drastically altered by urbanization.

In 2006, construction workers on a subway stop near Jintai Road found a stone tablet inscribed with the four characters *jin tai xi zhao*

(sunset glow at the golden terrace), attributed to Emperor Qianlong of the Qing Dynasty (1644-1911). For years, historians have debated whether the ruler's focus was on the scenery itself or on expressing ideals of preserving the past and enlightened governance.

"The entanglement between people, the natural environment and history are what fascinate me," Liu says.

Yan Yan, executive director of Today Art Museum and the exhibition's curator, describes Liu as an artist who works at a deliberate pace, enjoying the process of thinking, taking time to dab on strokes or pigments, and avoiding jumping to conclusions.

She says Liu's blue works hint at a state of uncertainty between remembering and forgetting. Standing before the artworks, one senses the quiet power of time "to reveal, to preserve, and sometimes, to blanket things", with the thick layering of pigments reflecting the depth of Liu's thoughts over the years.

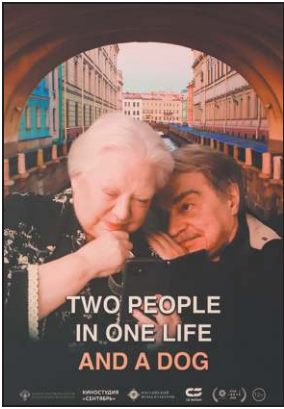


Above: Liu Kun at the opening of *Blues / Big Blue* at Beijing's Today Art Museum, illuminating blue as an essential element in his recent works. He paints at a deliberate pace, enjoying the process of thinking, and not in a hurry to dab on strokes. Left: One of his works, *Peacock Blue — Sunset Glow at the Golden Terrace*. PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY



Online
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LIFE



“Because our two elderly actors tired easily, we usually filmed their scenes first. But when we started shooting, the dog would suddenly run into the frame ... it had practically become one of the lead actors.”

Andrei Zaitsev,
Russian director

Top: Poster for the Russian film *Two People in One Life and a Dog*, which earned a nomination for the 16th Beijing International Film Festival's Tiantan Awards — the festival's highest honor.

Above: Director Andrei Zaitsev shares behind-the-scenes stories from the movie with a Chinese audience during a festival post-screening session held in Beijing earlier this year. **Top right:** A scene from *Two People in One Life and a Dog*, a quiet and heartwarming Russian film, features the protagonists, two elderly intellectuals — a husband and wife — living in St. Petersburg. **Middle right:** While confronting loneliness after their adult children move abroad, their pet dog becomes the elderly couple's pivotal comfort.

PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

Finding warmth in Beijing

Director Andrei Zaitsev brought his moving feature film to this year's international movie festival in the capital, where Chinese audiences surprised him with their emotional attentiveness, **Xu Fan** reports.

Despite a grueling festival schedule packed with post-screening discussions and public appearances, Russian director Andrei Zaitsev rarely turned away an eager Chinese film fan.

Outside a crowded room in a downtown cinema during the 16th Beijing International Film Festival held late last month, he patiently signed posters one after another, pausing for selfies with a gentle smile. At one point, he even stopped an event organizer to ask fans to speed up the signing process and skip photos, so the long line could move more quickly.

For Zaitsev, 50, who brought his latest film, *Two People in One Life and a Dog*, to Beijing, the warmth of the reception came as an unexpected surprise. Chinese audiences, he said, often picked up on subtle details and emotional nuances that even Russian moviegoers had overlooked.

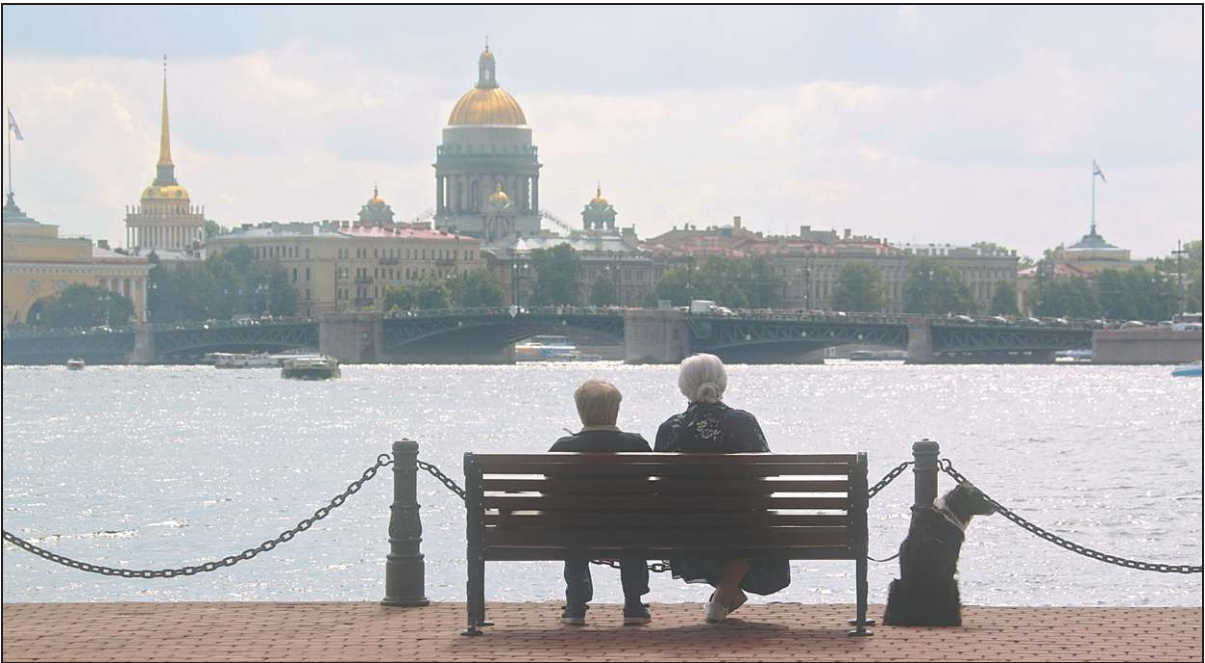
Such attentiveness became especially apparent during the film's post-screening exchanges. At one session, a female audience member raised her hand to ask about a scene that had clearly resonated with many local viewers. In it, one of the protagonists — a retired intellectual — meticulously copies an album of Song Dynasty (960-1279) fine-brush paintings in his study. The delicate depictions of birds and plants evoked a strong sense of familiarity among Chinese viewers.

“The inspiration came from the story of a renowned Russian philosopher and his wife,” Zaitsev explained.

As the philosopher's birthday approached, his wife asked what gift he wanted most. He requested a rare and expensive album of Song Dynasty paintings, published in China in the 1950s. Finding a copy proved difficult. Determined to fulfill his wish, she went to bookstores in Moscow and, by luck, discovered the last remaining copy — which she purchased with the exact amount of money she happened to have on her at the time.

The scene, Zaitsev added, was also shaped by his friendship with the late Russian actor Sergey Dreyden (1941-2023), who acted in his 2020 directorial feature, *A Siege Diary*, about the brutal Siege of Leningrad during World War II. The historic feature earned Zaitsev the Tiantan Award for Best Director at the 11th Beijing International Film Festival in 2021.

“I became very close friends with Dreyden. We talked constantly, shared books and spent a lot of time together. He was a warm person. People naturally gravitated toward him, as if seeking warmth from his



presence alone. I wanted that warmth to reach many viewers, not only the people around him,” recalls the director with China Daily during an interview.

Dreyden loved sketching on electric trains or outdoors in nature. He often walked his dog through the streets of St. Petersburg, slowly wandering through the city he loved. “Many details in the film came directly from him,” the director says.

That quiet tenderness permeates *Two People in One Life and a Dog*. Selected from 1,826 submissions from 139 countries and regions, the film was nominated for this year's Tiantan Awards, the festival's top honor. Following its screening, it received a score of 8.7 out of 10 on the Chinese review platform Douban.

Told in a restrained yet deeply humane tone, the story follows an elderly intellectual couple living in St. Petersburg. Having survived World War II as children, they confront loneliness after their adult children emigrate abroad. Accompanied by their pet dog, their quiet lives regain warmth when they befriend a young neighbor girl suffering under an abusive father.

The film lingers on seemingly trivial yet poetic moments. In one such memorable sequence, the husband becomes irritated by the vulgar commentary blaring from a tourist cruise ship along a river. Unable to tolerate it, he impulsively volunteers to serve



as the guide himself, captivating passersby with stories about the literary giants who once lived and wandered along the riverbanks.

“The marriage in the film shows how difficult love can be. The elderly couple's affection for each other is unconditional. Their relationship is built on mutual respect and steadfast support through every hardship,” says Zaitsev.

Yet while the film radiates warmth on-screen, its production was marked by setbacks. In 2023, just two months before filming was scheduled to begin, Sergey Dreyden, the actor originally chosen for the lead role, passed away, forcing production to be postponed for an extended period.

Even the film's canine star brought unexpected complications. The cou-

ple's pet, a border collie, was highly obedient and capable of performing complex actions on command. But the dog, interestingly, had a habit of stealing scenes.

“Because our two elderly actors tired easily, we usually filmed their scenes first. But when we started shooting, the dog would suddenly run into the frame. Later, during editing, we realized it had appeared so often that it had practically become one of the lead actors,” recalls Zaitsev.

The festival marked Zaitsev's first visit to Beijing, a city he says reminds him in some ways of Moscow, as they serve as capitals of two vast countries. What impresses him most, however, is the greenery.

“I have noticed that Beijing has a large number of trees. Many of them

are no longer young saplings but towering old trees. That shows China has been committed to environmental protection and urban greening for many years already,” he says.

Like many first-time visitors, Zaitsev toured the Forbidden City and the Temple of Heaven. He was amused to discover that the bedrooms for emperors and their wives inside the sprawling palace complex were surprisingly modest in size.

But it was an ordinary human moment that stayed with him most vividly: in a narrow palace lane, an elderly man in a wheelchair slowly crossed paths with a baby sitting in a stroller — one face marked by age and weariness, the other filled with new life and curiosity. To the director, it felt like a fleeting scene that could be used in one of his future films.

Asked whether he would be interested in making a film in China, Zaitsev, who says he admires the works of Hong Kong auteur Wong Kar-wai, replies that the stories he most longs to tell remain simple ones — films about ordinary people, their emotions and the details of everyday life.

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Online
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In Harbin, the taste of Russian bread becomes a link to home

By **ZHOU HUIYING** in Harbin
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For international students studying abroad, the familiar taste of home often serves as the most tangible link between their homeland and a foreign country.

Viktoriya Poletaeva, a first-year master's student at Harbin Institute of Technology in Harbin, the capital city of Heilongjiang province, grew up with the aroma of Russian bread baked by her grandmother, and the scent of Russian rye bread has long been etched in her memory since she came to the city in 2022.

“The familiar Russian architecture in the city makes me feel at home,” she says. “However, I always yearned for the authentic Russian bread from my hometown.”

One day, by chance, she saw Churin *lieba* (which comes from the Russian word *khleb*, meaning bread) at a Churin Food store, and the familiar shape and aroma instantly triggered her homesickness.

“With one bite, the crispy crust paired with the soft interior and the slightly sour taste from the hops fermentation,” she says. “At that moment, the longing for my distant homeland was gently soothed.”

“In fact, Russian bread is generally more sour and harder, while Harbin *lieba* perfectly blends the rich wheat aroma of Northeast China,”



Left: Workers make *lieba* at the Churin Food bakery in Harbin, Heilongjiang province. **Right:** Churin *lieba* weighs around two kilograms and has a traditional European flavor. PHOTOS PROVIDED TO CHINA DAILY

she says. “It is solid and chewy, with a long-lasting aftertaste. It retains the traditional essence of Russian baking while cleverly adapting to local tastes, making it a distinctive delicacy rooted in the black soil, combining flavors from both countries.”

Poletaeva also visited the Churin Bread-Making Skills Exhibition Hall.

In the center of the hall stands a model of a loaf of Churin *lieba* sitting on a four-meter-long wooden paddle.

In the experience area, visitors were already lining up.

As the freshly baked *lieba* was unveiled, its soft interior and steaming warmth were handed to each visitor.

The traditional way to eat it is with butter and jam and another way is to pair it with slices of Russian-style sausage.

“These are authentic Russian ways of eating it,” she says. “I'm delighted to see my hometown's food culture so welcomed in Harbin.”

In 1900, Russian merchant Ivan Churin brought Russian bread-making techniques to Harbin.

Passed down through five gener-

ations of craftsmen, the large round bread, which weighs around two kilograms and has a traditional European flavor, has become a specialty of Harbin and a taste memory etched in the daily lives of local residents.

At 3 am, the fire in the Churin bakery is already lit.

Master Lei, the fifth-generation inheritor of Churin bread-making techniques, carefully records the room temperature.

His keen intuition, honed from years on the production line, allows him to accurately estimate

fermentation based on variables like temperature and environment.

He adjusts the water temperature, kneads the dough, and gently awakens the century-old starter yeast.

Every detail affects the traditional flavor of *lieba*.

After three natural fermentations, manual shaping, and slow baking in a brick oven, the crispy-on-the-outside, soft-on-the-inside Churin *lieba* is ready, filling the air with the rich aroma of wheat.

“Churin *lieba* has been passed down through five generations, always using traditional Russian



handmade techniques and facilities,” says Lei. “Its three major processes are distinctive — using hops to make liquid yeast for fermentation, giving the bread an enticing hop aroma; employing a traditional three-stage fermentation to produce a rich variety of organic acids; and baking with hardwood, creating a slightly charred and crispy crust with a soft and tasty interior.”

“Kneading and shaping by hand are the two key steps in the production process,” she says. “Kneading by hand is a race against time; it requires speed and ensuring the dough is well-formed.”

Lei says he spent over two years mastering the basic skill of kneading.

At the Churin bakery, the average age of the core worker team is over 35. Many of them entered the workshop when young and have been working on the front line for decades.

“In 2007, the Churin *lieba*-making technique was recognized as a provincial intangible cultural heritage. In 2009, we established the country's first Churin Bread-Making Skills Exhibition Hall,” he says. “The exhibition hall is not only a simple reproduction of intangible cultural heritage techniques, but also an interpretation from a new perspective.”

SPORTS

NEW YORK — The New York Knicks, fueled by 38 points from Jalen Brunson, erased a 22-point fourth-quarter deficit to stun the Cleveland Cavaliers 115-104 in overtime Monday in Game 1 of the NBA Eastern Conference finals.

The Knicks looked done for when they trailed 93-71 with 7:52 left in regulation. But Brunson spearheaded an 18-1 New York run and banked in a floater to tie it at 101-101 with 19.3 seconds left.

When Cleveland's Sam Merrill missed a three-pointer they went to the extra session — in which the Knicks scored the first nine points.

Brunson admitted he did not know how the Knicks had pulled off the sensational comeback.

“I don’t have an answer for you,” he told broadcaster ESPN.

“We got some stops. We kept fighting, kept believing, just kept chipping away.

“They were playing great basketball and we just found a way.”

Mikal Bridges added 18 points, and OG Anunoby, back from a two-game injury absence, was one of three Knicks players with 13.

Donovan Mitchell scored 29 points to lead the Cavaliers, and James Harden added 15.

The Knicks will have a chance to double their lead in the best-of-seven series when they host Game 2 on Thursday.

The winner of the series will face either the defending champion Oklahoma City Thunder or San Antonio Spurs in the championship series.

The Spurs, fueled by a 41-point performance by Victor Wembanyama, beat the Thunder in double-overtime in Game 1 of the Western Conference finals.

It is the first time in NBA history that the first games in both conference finals have been decided in overtime.

Rust may have played a role in the Knicks’ sluggish start. New York had been off for nine days after sweeping the Philadelphia 76ers in the second round.

The Cavaliers, meanwhile, were battle tested, if not rested, having polished off a second straight seven-game series with a triumph at top-seeded Detroit on Sunday.

A three-pointer by Mitchell saw Cleveland emerge from a back-and-forth first half with a 48-46 lead, and the Cavaliers pulled away relentlessly in the second half, as the Madison Square Garden crowd looked on in stunned, silent disbelief.

But they were the ones celebrating wildly by the end, as the Knicks moved one step closer to their first NBA Finals appearance since 1999. They reached the conference finals last year, but were beaten by the Indiana Pacers.

The Cavaliers are in the conference finals for the first time since 2018, when they were led by LeBron James.

Harden, 36, is back in the penultimate round for the first time since his 2018 Most Valuable Player season with Houston, when the Rockets fell in seven games to the Golden State Warriors.

It was a crushing welcome to the conference finals for seven-time All-Star Mitchell, who never made it past the second round in five post-season appearances with the Utah Jazz.

“We should have won the game,” Mitchell said.

“We’re up 22 with God knows

New York Knicks guard Jalen Brunson reacts while masterminding an unprecedented comeback during the fourth quarter of Game 1 in the NBA playoffs Eastern Conference finals against the Cleveland Cavaliers at Madison Square Garden in New York on Tuesday. REUTERS



BASKETBALL

Brunson leads Knicks back from 22 down to stun Cavs

Staggering fourth quarter comeback in dying minutes turns game on its head

how much time? Eight minutes? Gotta win the game. We didn’t.”

But, he added, there's still plenty of time to regroup.

“It's one game,” Mitchell said. “We could have lost by 40, still would have been 1-0. We played pretty solid for three quarters or so. We'll make adjustments and go from there.”

Beyond belief

If the NBA had screenwriters, not even they could come up with a start this good to the conference finals.

Wembanyama has 41 points and 24 rebounds. San Antonio goes into Oklahoma City and beats the defending champion Thunder. New York trails by 22 points with about eight minutes left in regulation, then beats Cleveland. Both games go to overtime, a conference finals first. And the score at the end of regulation in both games — 101-101.

Well done, Spurs and Knicks. If there was a common trend in both games, it was that the best player on the winning teams decided to become the best player on the floor at crunch time.

On Monday night, it was Wembanyama for the Spurs. On Tuesday night, it was Brunson for the Knicks — who led a 44-11 run over the last 13 minutes.

That's right, 44-11. “I don’t know if I’ve seen that in a playoff game,” Knicks coach Mike Brown said.

“I take my hat off to my group.” The numbers — from both opening games — are of the video game variety.

Start with what happened at Madison Square Garden on Tuesday night. A 44-11 run doesn’t happen in the NBA, certainly not in the conference finals.

Teams that led by 22 points or more in the fourth quarter were 452-1 this season, including play-offs. They're 452-2 now.

In the playoffs, teams had won 330 consecutive games when leading by 22 or more points in the fourth quarter since 2013. They're

330-1 now. Make it make sense. “I don’t have an answer,” Brunson said.

Neither did the Cavaliers, either while it was happening, nor in the immediate aftermath.

“We got a little unlucky,” Cavaliers coach Kenny Atkinson said.

“Brunson obviously took over at the end. We played great basketball tonight for three quarters. Unfortunately, the fourth quarter, they dominated us.”

A 41-point, 24-rebound game doesn’t happen that often, either. Wembanyama was brilliant in his conference finals debut, as was Spurs rookie guard Dylan Harper. The Spurs, like the Cavs, wasted a double-digit lead in the fourth quarter of Game 1 and settled for overtime; San Antonio's lead was 10, not 22, but still double digits.

Unlike the Cavs, they found a way to settle down — repeatedly, really — in the two extra periods Monday night.

“That game was in the balance multiple times for both teams,” Spurs coach Mitch Johnson said Tuesday. “You can’t get preoccupied with the outcome because there was so much in the balance that could have gone either way.”

In short, stealing home-court advantage by winning Game 1 doesn’t mean the Spurs think the series is over. And the Thunder knows that Game 1 is meaningful — but not a deciding game by any stretch.

The defending champion is feeling some pressure. New York is rocking. Wembanyama's star keeps rising.

The Cavaliers — winners of two Game 7s in these playoffs — need to dig their way out of trouble, again.

The start to these conference-final stories was stellar. Chapter two awaits.

Game 2 of Spurs-Thunder is Wednesday, Game 2 of Knicks-Cavaliers is Thursday and the drama is only going to keep building.

AGENCIES

No Kidd around: Mavs coach out after five years in Dallas

Jason Kidd is out as coach of the Dallas Mavericks after five seasons, and two weeks after the club hired former Toronto Raptors executive Masai Ujiri as team president and governor.

The team said Tuesday it was parting ways with Kidd, describing the move as a mutual decision.

The Hall-of-Fame point guard led the franchise to its only championship as a player in 2011.

When asked about the future of Kidd at his introduction on May 5, Ujiri was noncommittal, saying he would talk to Kidd while evaluating all aspects of the team.

“As we evaluate the future of our basketball program, we believe this is the right moment for a new direction for our team,” Ujiri said in a statement. “We have high expectations for this franchise and a responsibility to build a basketball organization capable of sustained championship contention.”

Kidd made two deep playoff runs with Luka Doncic, reaching the NBA

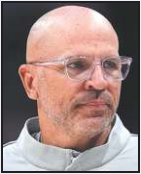
Finals in 2024, two years after a loss to Golden State in the Western Conference finals.

The Mavericks traded Doncic to the Los Angeles Lakers during the 2024-25 season, getting Anthony Davis as the centerpiece in a deal that backfired badly on the franchise.

Dallas missed the playoffs that season, and again in 2025-26. The 53-year-old Kidd had said he was looking forward to developing 2025 No 1 overall pick Cooper Flagg, who won Rookie of the Year award. Instead, that task will fall to someone else.

Kidd finished with a .500 regular-season record (205-205) with the Mavericks, an appropriate illustration of the up-and-down nature of his tenure in Dallas.

The run to the West finals came in



Jason Kidd

his first season, when Dallas stunned the favored Phoenix Suns in Game 7 on the road in the second round. The Mavericks lost in five games to the Warriors, who won the title.

Then general manager Nico Harrison traded for Kyrie Irving the next season, but injuries to him and Doncic limited their chances to be an elite scoring pair.

Dallas missed the playoffs.

In their only healthy season together in 2023-24, Doncic and Irving led the Mavericks to the Finals for the first time since Kidd helped Dallas win it all.

Nine months later, Harrison shocked the NBA with the trade of Doncic. Because of injuries, Irving and Davis played together for just two-and-a-half quarters.

Harrison was fired early in the 2025-26 season, after a slow start and with Davis injured again. Davis was later traded to Washington, and despite plenty of brilliant play from Flagg, the Mavericks finished 26-56.

AGENCIES VIA XINHUA



**INVITATION FOR
EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)**
**GOVERNMENT OF PAKISTAN -
PRIVATISATION COMMISSION**

FOR PRIVATE SECTOR
PARTICIPATION IN / PRIVATISATION OF
Faisalabad Electric Supply
Company **FESCO**
Gujranwala Electric
Power Company **GEPCO**
Islamabad Electric
Supply Company **IESCO**



PRIVATISATION OF FESCO, GEPCO & IESCO
**FOR ACQUISITION OF 51% TO 100% SHARE CAPITAL TOGETHER WITH
MANAGEMENT CONTROL IN EACH OF FESCO, GEPCO & IESCO**
ABOUT FESCO, GEPCO & IESCO

FESCO, GEPCO and IESCO (collectively, referred to as "Batch-I DISCOs") are public limited companies incorporated in 1998 under the Companies Ordinance, 1984, established to assume the role of electricity distribution and supply in their respective areas from the relevant electricity board owned by the Water and Power Development Authority. The Batch-I DISCOs are wholly owned by the Government of Pakistan ("GoP") and are responsible for the distribution and supply of electricity to industrial, commercial, agricultural, domestic and other consumers within their notified geographical jurisdictions. Each Batch-I DISCO owns and operates an extensive distribution network comprising 132-kilovolt and 66-KV grid stations, distribution infrastructure and transmission lines, along with other offices and facilities across their relevant districts.	Batch -I DISCOs	Districts / Coverage	Service Area	Consumers
	FESCO	Central Punjab, incl. Faisalabad, Jhang, Toba Tek Singh, Chiniot, Sargodha, Mianwali, Khushab and Bhakkar	44.3K km ²	5.7 million
	GEPCO	Gujranwala, Sialkot, Narowal, Gujrat, Mandi Bahauddin and Hafiz Abad	17.2K km ²	5.1 million
	IESCO	Islamabad, Rawalpindi, Jhelum, Attock, Chakwal and Azad Jammu & Kashmir (AJK)	23.2K km ²	4.1 million

TRANSACTION OVERVIEW

Interested parties that are companies, firms, body corporates or other legal entities (and not individuals, nor the Federal or Provincial Governments of Pakistan or any enterprise owned or controlled by the Federal or Provincial Governments of Pakistan) should submit a separate EOI for each DISCO they are interested in (as a single entity or as a consortium) in 6 copies (i.e., 1 original, 4 hard copies (duly marked) and 1 soft electronic copy in an uncorrupted USB), to the Privatisation Commission (PC) at the following address, together with the applicable non-refundable processing fee of USD 5,000 (United States Dollars Five Thousand only) or PKR 1,400,000 (Pakistani Rupees One Million Four Hundred Thousand only) per EOI/ DISCO.

FESCO: 7th July 2026 (16:00 Hours PKT)
GEPCO: 6th August 2026 (16:00 Hours PKT)
IESCO: 7th September 2026 (16:00 Hours PKT)
The deadlines may, at any time in the sole and absolute discretion of the GoP / PC, be changed

**Director General (Admin), Privatisation Commission,
4th Floor, New Pak Secretariat Building, Kohsar Block,
Constitution Avenue, Islamabad, Pakistan**
EOI must be submitted to the above address.

EOI must contain the following information:

i Name of the interested party whether a company, firm, or consortium comprising of the same and background information (including profile, place of incorporation, ownership details);

ii In case of foreign interested parties, copies of passports of Directors and Shareholders holding or controlling (by itself or in concert), directly or indirectly 20% or more voting power;

iii For local interested parties: CNICs of directors and shareholders holding or controlling (by itself or in concert), directly or indirectly, 20% or more of voting power;

iv Name, address, email address and telephone number(s) of the authorized representative;

v Signed Confidentiality Agreement available at: <https://privatisation.gov.pk/Batch-I-DISCOs-EOI>;

vi Statement of Qualification (SOQ) in response to the Request for Statement of Qualifications (RSOQ) and preliminary information for each Batch-I DISCO available at <https://privatisation.gov.pk/Batch-I-DISCOs-EOI>.

Where the interested party is a consortium, each consortium member shall provide the above information. The SOQ submitted by interested parties will be used by the PC, in its sole and absolute discretion, to pre-qualify interested parties in accordance with the RSOQ. Only pre-qualified interested parties will be issued the bid documents and allowed access to the virtual data room to conduct due diligence and, subject to compliance with the bidding conditions, participate in the bidding process.

OTHER INFORMATION

At any stage, the GoP / PC may, in its sole and absolute discretion, inter alia, alter the transaction structure, mode of privatisation, impose additional conditions or otherwise modify or amend the transaction process. Interested parties are encouraged to review information relating to submission of EOI, RSOQ and other transaction documents as made available by the PC on the following weblink: <https://privatisation.gov.pk/Batch-I-DISCOs-EOI>. GoP / PC and the Financial Advisor or any of its member thereof, reserve the right to not respond to any request for preliminary or other information and further reserve the right to accept or reject any or all EOIs and may cancel the whole privatisation process at any time. This EOI Invitation is intended only to seek expressions of interest from interested parties. The details of the transaction, information memorandum, conditions of sale, draft bidding documents and process will be advised to pre-qualified parties at the appropriate time as part of the privatisation process.

The PC reserves the right at its sole and absolute discretion to amend, supplement or otherwise modify the transaction structure, including but not limited to, by providing additional information, incentives or concessions, to pre-qualified interested parties. No interested party, whether it submits an EOI or not, shall be entitled to object to or challenge any such amendment, supplement, modification, information, incentive or concession at any stage. This advertisement and the information provided or referenced herein do not constitute, and should not be construed as: (a) an offer or invitation to acquire any securities and/or assets of any of the Batch-I DISCOs; (b) a representation or warranty, express or implied with respect to any statement made herein or in any document referenced herein; or (c) any statement of commitment, warranty or indemnity of any kind by the Government of Pakistan, the PC or any of their advisors. The PC has appointed Alvarez & Marsal Middle East Limited as Financial Advisor to conduct this transaction.

ONLINE BRIEFING

An online briefing, outlining key investment highlights, will be conducted by the Privatisation Commission and the Financial Advisor on **Wednesday 3rd June 2026 from 16:00 to 18:00** Pakistan Standard Time. You may join the online briefing on Zoom (www.zoom.com) **meeting ID: 872 3355 2592; passcode: 749093** (you will be invited to fill a brief registration form when you join the Zoom link).



Privatisation Commission
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Financial Advisor
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Web-Link: <https://privatisation.gov.pk/Batch-I-DISCOs-EOI>





SPORTS

SOCCER

By SUN XIAOCHEN
sunxiaochen@chinadaily.com.cn

China's youth soccer revival has netted another morale boost, with its men's under-17 squad's unexpected Asian Cup final run relieving fans, at least for now, from the disappointment of having no home side to root for at the upcoming FIFA World Cup.

As the whole world prepares to tune in the marquee tournament next month, Chinese fans will have to watch on as bystanders again, but not before enjoying a Cup final relevant to their team's future ambitions, thanks to China's recent breakout performance at the AFC U17 Asian Cup in Saudi Arabia.

They will also have a World Cup of their own to look forward to at the end of the year.

The Chinese U17 squad, arriving in Jeddah only eyeing the knockout stage as a marker of success, has pulled off one of the most inspiring turnarounds on the continental stage in recent years after stunning Australia 2-0 on Tuesday to reach the tournament final for the first time in 22 years — all the way from the brink of elimination in the group stage.

The team's deeper-than-expected run, which culminates with a title showdown against powerhouse Japan on Friday, has also helped secure its berth at the FIFA U17 World Cup, to be held in Qatar from Nov 20-Dec 14, marking the first time the Chinese men's U17s have made it to the global tournament since 2005.

The prestige and appeal of reaching the U17 World Cup, of course, is nowhere near that of reaching the expanded 48-nation senior showpiece, but it is enough to keep Team China's young talent dreaming big.



A FINAL COUNTDOWN

China sets up title showdown with Japan at the AFC U17 Asian Cup, while securing its spot at November's World Cup in Qatar



China defeated Australia 2-0 in the semifinals of the 2026 AFC U17 Asian Cup in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, on Tuesday, reaching the final for the first time in 22 years. **Below left:** Substitute Xie Jin celebrates scoring China's second goal in stoppage time on Tuesday. XINHUA

"My dream is to play in the FIFA World Cup. I want to keep improving every day, work hard and continue challenging myself against the best players in the world," forward Shuai Weihao, who scored the critical opening goal against Australia, said after the semifinal at the King Abdullah Sports City Stadium.

"I don't think there was a big difference between the two teams. Maybe, we just showed a bit more fight and determination than our opponents," the 17-year-old Sichuan province native said of the result, which came as a shock to many.

"We've proved that we can compete with the best in Asia at this level, so why not keep going and see what we can do in the final."

In a fine example of the team's high-pressing, quick counterattacking style of play, China's captain Zhou Yunuo dispossessed Aussie midfielder Oliver O'Carroll and threaded the ball to Shuai, who completed his bursting run down the middle with an easy finish that broke the deadlock five minutes into the second half.

Chinese substitute Xie Jin put the result beyond any doubt in the first minute of stoppage time, when he pounced on a loose ball inside the box, sealing the deserved win with a close-range strike and sending the vocal Chinese supporters into raptures in the stands.

"We didn't expect that we would



China's Shuai Weihao (second from left) slots the ball past diving Australian keeper Charlie Wilson-Papps to score the opening goal of the AFC U17 Asian Cup semifinal on Tuesday. XINHUA

be here before the tournament, to be honest," said Zhou. "We will allow ourselves to celebrate tonight, and then we will move on to prepare for the final with our utmost focus."

It's the second time in just four months that a Chinese squad has fought its way into a continental youth final, following the men's U23 team's final-match appearance, also against Japan, at its respective Asian Cup in the same Saudi city.

China's U23 squad was thrashed 4-0 by Japan in that final, played at the same stadium on Jan 24, signing off its Saudi campaign with a sobering reminder of the task that lies ahead.

The U17 unit, however, has a bigger advantage this time around, with Japanese coach Bin Ukishima barking instructions from the Chinese dugout.

Ukishima, who took over the reins of the Chinese junior program in 2024, attributed his team's breakthrough to its collective focus and resilience.

"Soccer is always about the team. Whether we score or defend, everyone is involved. I don't see it as an individual performance above the group," the 58-year-old former J-League player and coach said. After opening its tournament

with two straight round-robin losses to Indonesia (0-1) and Japan (1-2) in Group B, Team China stayed mentally strong and dug itself out of the mire with a crucial 2-0 win against Qatar in its final group fixture to edge out the Gulf nation and advance into the knockout phase.

A solid 3-1 effort over the host Saudis in the quarterfinals boosted Team China's confidence, while rekindling long-suffering Chinese fans' hopes for their national program's future.

The young squad is drawing huge attention from the nation's soccer community, where long-term commitment to youth cultivation is the consensus when it comes to figuring out how to turn around the fortunes of the underachieving senior side.

"Having twice reached a continental youth final in the first half of 2026, and to challenge Japan again, good job Team China! It's time, perhaps, for a turn of fortunes," veteran soccer journalist Ma Dexing with Titan Sports posted on Weibo.

Ukishima agrees. "We have done our research on this Japanese team after losing to them in the group, and we understand their weakness and strengths," he said. "I have my notes prepared to give our players when facing them again."

"Although I am Japanese, I am Team China's coach now. I will fight on my team's side with my best effort (to ensure the win)."

Cherries bomb City's title bid, handing Arsenal first Premiership crown in 22 years

Arsenal's decades-long wait is over.

Mikel Arteta's team was crowned Premier League champion for the first time since 2004 on Tuesday after Manchester City drew 1-1 with Bournemouth.

"I told you all. it's done," Arsenal midfielder Declan Rice posted on social media with a photo of him and his teammates celebrating.

The result put an end to what might be Pep Guardiola's final title challenge with City, after the decorated manager didn't dismiss reports he was set to leave the club at the end of the season.

City needed to win at Bournemouth to take it down to the final game of the campaign on Sunday, but the draw left Arsenal with an unassailable four-point lead at the top, ending its 22-year wait for the title.

Arsenal fans celebrated wildly outside the Emirates Stadium, setting off flares and partying in the street. There were celebrations at the club's training ground, too, where the players had gathered to watch the match.

City threatened another twist in an engrossing title race when Erling Haaland scored in stoppage time to equalize, neutralizing Junior Kroupi's first-half strike, but it was too

late to find a winner.

Arteta's players can now stand alongside club icons Thierry Henry, Dennis Bergkamp and Ian Wright, who previously reached the summit of English soccer. And Arsenal's current class could yet break new ground by winning the Champions League for the first time in its history later this month.

Thoughts of the May 30 final against defending champion Paris Saint-Germain can be put on the back burner for now.

Now is a time for celebration and relief for Arteta, after finishing runner-up in the league three years in a row.

In back-to-back seasons in 2023 and '24, he watched as Guardiola's City chased down Arsenal's lead to be crowned champion.

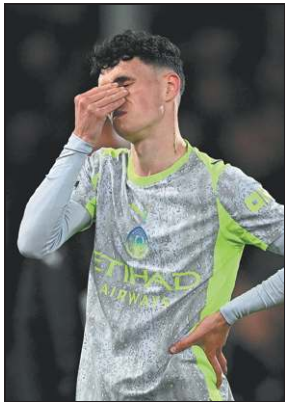
Another chance was missed last year, when the Gunners finished second to Liverpool.

Once again, Arsenal has led the way for most of this campaign and, despite seeing its points advantage ebb away during a gripping run-in, it has finally managed to get over the line.

Arsenal's last championship-winning side was the so-called "Invincibles" team of 2004, which went an entire campaign without losing in the league.



Arsenal fans celebrate winning the league title for the first time in 22 years, while a dejected Phil Foden rues Manchester City's missed title opportunity after Tuesday's draw with Bournemouth. AP / REUTERS



Since then, it has seen Chelsea, Manchester United, City, Leicester and Liverpool all take the title. This is the first time since 2017 that a team other than City or Liverpool has been crowned champion.

It is Arsenal's 14th title, and Arteta will hope it is the beginning of a new era of dominance.

He has finally got the better of Guardiola, to whom he was once an assistant at City.

The Spaniard took over at Arsenal

in December 2019 — his first role as a manager. After winning the FA Cup in that first season, it has been a frustrating wait for more honors. Even still, at 44 he is the second-youngest coach after Jose Mourinho to win the Premier League.

While his team has not maintained the attractive playing style of former manager Arsene Wenger, it has powered its way to the title with the best defense in the league and earned a reputation as a specialist

for set-piece goals.

Time will tell if Arteta adopts a more expansive style in the future, more in-keeping with Guardiola's City.

How City will look going forward is a bigger question, with Enzo Maresca widely considered the front-runner to replace Guardiola.

The future of City's greatest manager overshadowed the buildup to the game. "I should talk with my chairman first," Guardiola said.

"After that, when I talk with my chairman, we will decide. We will talk in the coming days."

He was aiming to win a seventh English title and a second domestic treble after winning the League Cup and FA Cup this term, but Kroupi's curling shot in the 39th minute left City with a mountain to climb.

Bournemouth wasted further chances to extend its lead, and Haaland ensured a tense finish for Arsenal fans when he leveled in the fifth minute of added time.

Ultimately, it wasn't enough and Guardiola has gone two years without winning a league title for the first time in his coaching career.

Relegation battle

The title fight might be done, but the relegation battle will go down to the final day, after Chelsea beat Tottenham 2-1. Spurs are two points ahead of West Ham, which is in the final relegation spot.

West Ham needs to beat Leeds on Sunday to have any chance of leapfrogging Tottenham and escaping the drop zone.

Tottenham hosts Everton, and a win would guarantee safety, though a draw would likely be enough thanks to its superior goal difference.